

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Aquifer Open Study Notes

Isaiah 1:1

- *This is the vision:* This term introduces the book as a unified whole, covering Isaiah's prophecies over about fifty-five years, from around 740 to 685 BC.
- *Isaiah son of Amoz:* Nothing else is known about Isaiah's family.
- Jerusalem, the capital city of Judah, was the center of Isaiah's ministry. Some of his prophecies also relate to the northern kingdom, Israel (called Samaria and Ephraim, [Isaiah 9:8-21](#); [28:1-13](#)), which Assyria destroyed in 722 BC (see [2 Kings 17](#)).

Isaiah 1:2

heavens . . . earth: All of creation is called to witness the trial that God convened against Judah (cp. [Deut 31:28](#); [32:1](#)).

Isaiah 1:3

an ox knows its owner: Not so with Judah. Yet despite their rebellion, God still graciously addressed them as my people.

Isaiah 1:4

The expression Holy One of Israel is frequently used in Isaiah as a title for the Lord. God is the righteous and just King of heaven and earth ([6:3-5](#)), the incomparable God ([40:25](#)), and the Redeemer of his people ([43:14](#)). It was a terrible and foolish sin for Judah to reject him.

Isaiah 1:5

God sent famine, war, disease, and death as punishment. In most cases, however, God wanted to change stubborn behavior rather than simply to

punish. • As a result of their persistent rebellion, the people's head is injured and their heart is sick. The nation was wounded physically from Assyrian aggression, while spiritually they were defiled and overtaken by sin ([64:6](#)).

Isaiah 1:6

without any soothing ointments or bandages: Judah's national condition was like the body of an injured person who had not received medical care.

Isaiah 1:7

country . . . towns: By 701 BC, the Assyrians had destroyed the infrastructure, taken cities, and ravaged the fields (see [64:10](#)). This fulfilled Isaiah's prophetic word ([6:11-13](#)). Those who survived this Assyrian onslaught would know by experience to heed later warnings of exile to Babylon ([39:6-7](#)). God does what he says he will do, so the warning of God's judgment on all the nations is certain.

Isaiah 1:8

Beautiful Jerusalem (Hebrew *The daughter of Zion*): Zion, one of the hills on which Jerusalem stands, often served as a synonym for Jerusalem. Zion carried with it the notion of God's presence ([Ps 46](#)), his protection of his people, and Jerusalem's resistance to enemy forces. Now, however, the opposite was true. Jerusalem had become weak, like a helpless city under siege and like an abandoned . . . shelter or lean-to.

Isaiah 1:9

The Lord of Heaven's Armies refers to the millions of angels that are at the Lord's command (see [2 Kgs 6:16-17](#); [Matt 26:53](#)). At the Exodus, Moses described God as a warrior fighting for his people ([Exod 15:1-21](#)). Ironically, in Isaiah's day, God fought against Judah because of their wickedness ([Isa 1:24](#); [3:1-5](#)).

Isaiah 1:10

Listen to (literally *listen to the word of*) the Lord: In this context, *listen* means to respond in obedience to the law (or *teaching*; Hebrew *torah*) of our God (see [2:3](#); [5:24](#)). • leaders . . . people: All levels of society were guilty. • Like Sodom and Gomorrah, Jerusalem had come under divine judgment for its rebellion against God's laws. Jerusalem might have been utterly destroyed like those cities were it not for God's grace ([1:9](#); see [Gen 19](#)).

Isaiah 1:11–15

The people had so offended God through their sin that he took no pleasure any more in their sacrifices. The Lord wanted Judah to stop the religious exercises he had commanded them to do rather than to continue them in a manner that was sinful and false ([1:13](#)). Ritual is never an acceptable substitute for true godliness.

Isaiah 1:13

The incense that accompanied offerings was intended as a sweet fragrance to the Lord (see [Exod 30:7–8](#)), but when offered with hypocrisy it was a nauseating stench and an abomination to God. • While the Lord had ordered special days for fasting at the Temple ([Lev 16:31](#); [23:32](#); [Num 29:7](#)), they were ruined by the guilt of Judah's sin (see [Isa 58:1–7](#); [Matt 6:16–18](#)). • pious meetings: These holy days were associated with the new moon and other festivals (see [Lev 23](#)).

Isaiah 1:14

New moon celebrations occurred on the first day of each lunar month ([Num 28:11–15](#)) and included sacrifices, feasting, and rest from work. • The annual festivals were the festivals of Passover, Harvest, Trumpets, and Shelters ([Num 28:16–29:39](#); [Deut 16:1–17](#)).

Isaiah 1:15

I will not look . . . I will not listen: The Lord does not respond to prayer offered from a life of persistent wickedness. In this case, God charged the people

with perverting his laws in order to practice violent injustice toward innocent victims.

Isaiah 1:16

Wash . . . and be clean! The people were defiled by their sin and the uncleanness of their sacrifices. To be clean in God's eyes, they needed to change their behavior, get rid of their sins, and give up their evil ways (see also [1:18](#)).

Isaiah 1:17

Seeking justice means upholding God's standards of fairness and advancing the rights of the oppressed, orphans, and widows—those who are weak and marginalized in society (see also [Jer 7:5–7](#); [22:3](#); [Zech 7:10](#); [Matt 23:23](#); [25:31–46](#); [Jas 1:27](#)).

Isaiah 1:18

God called his people to come and settle their dispute so that he could restore his covenant relationship with them. This required Judah to make a decision between obeying or turning away ([1:19–20](#)). Isaiah says their sins are like scarlet . . . they are red like crimson, the color of blood, which Judah had unjustly shed ([1:15](#)). • white as snow . . . white as wool: The people would be radically transformed—cleansed, purified, and made holy (see also [Ps 51:7](#); [Dan 7:9](#)).

Isaiah 1:19–20

Repentance leads to life, whereas resisting God's will and turning away from him results in death (see [Deut 11:26–28](#); [28:1–62](#)).

Isaiah 1:20

I, the Lord, have spoken! This statement marks the solemnity of what God has just promised. The phrase is used eleven times in Isaiah.

Isaiah 1:21

The image of Jerusalem as a prostitute represents Judah's unfaithfulness to God (see [Jer 3:6-14](#); [Ezek 16:25-26](#); [Hos 1-3](#)).

Isaiah 1:24

The Lord of Heaven's Armies, the Mighty One of Israel, was usually Israel's protector ([31:5](#)). However, in this context, God was coming to take revenge against his own people, who by their wickedness had become his enemies and foes.

Isaiah 1:25

I will raise my fist against you: God, normally Israel's protector, would become their attacker. However, he had a purpose beyond punishment. • I will melt you down. . . . I will remove all your impurities: God would use the Exile to remove the wicked from among his people and to refine those who would return.

Isaiah 1:26

The restoration of the community would be marked by new leaders who uphold justice rather than perverting it (see [1:23](#)). Jerusalem would again be pure silver (see [1:22](#)), the Home of Justice and the Faithful City.

Isaiah 1:27

Here, Zion refers to the remnant community. Only those who repent would receive God's salvation and purification and would dwell in his presence. Zion was required to be the bastion of justice and righteousness, for God loves righteousness. God expected the covenant community to reflect the holy standards he cares about.

Isaiah 1:29-30

The rebels ([1:28](#)), who practiced idolatry in groves of sacred oaks and in gardens dedicated to idols, would become like drought-stricken oaks and gardens. They would lack the nourishing vitality of the true God's presence. Those who followed the

Canaanite fertility religion of Baal treated gardens and trees as sacred, believing that they brought blessings. Instead, they brought spiritual death.

Isaiah 2:1

vision (literally *word*): This heading (see [1:1](#)) likely introduces the revelation of chs [2-12](#). The main focus of this section is on Judah, but a handful of passages expand that focus to include the nations in general ([2:2-4](#)), humanity at large ([2:6-22](#)), Syria and the northern kingdom of Israel (chs [7-9](#)), and the Assyrians (ch [10](#)).

Isaiah 2:2

In the Old Testament, the expression the last days is a general reference to the future era (see [Jer 49:39](#); [Ezek 38:16](#); [Hos 3:5](#)); in the New Testament, it is used to refer to the period that began with the coming of the Lord Jesus ([Heb 1:2](#)) and more specifically to the period immediately preceding the end of the present age ([2 Pet 3:3](#)). • The mountain of the Lord's house referred to the Temple Mount. This location symbolized God's glorious exaltation (see [Isa 6:1](#)) and his kingdom on earth. Isaiah's focus on God's exalted and supreme kingship flows out of his famous vision of God (ch [6](#)). • Far from being a narrow nationalistic dream, Isaiah's prophetic hope extended beyond Judah and Jerusalem to include people from all over the world.

Isaiah 2:2-4

God's gracious salvation would one day extend beyond Israel and Judah. This would prompt the nations to come to Zion, not in battle but to be blessed there and live by the rules of God's kingdom. Isaiah encouraged Judah to look at the benefits that the nations would enjoy. He wanted to stimulate the people of Judah ([2:5](#)) to jealousy and provoke them to follow the Lord so that they would not be left out in that day. This section is repeated almost verbatim in [Micah 4:1-3](#).

Isaiah 2:3

Human society will undergo changes as people conform to God's revelation and follow his ways

and paths. • Judah received the revelation (teaching . . . word) but did not obey it ([1:10–15](#)); however, the nations will be ready to do God’s will.

Isaiah 2:4

The Kingdom of God is evident when conflict and violence end, and it is characterized by peace ([Rom 14:17](#)). People will cooperate willingly or they will be forced to end their hostilities ([Ps 46:9](#)). The nations will submit to divine arbitration rather than go to war (see [Isa 1:18–20](#)). • The words mediate and settle refer to God’s acts here, but later verses show the Messiah as the executor of justice ([11:3–4](#)). When this takes place, war will cease, and the nations will change their instruments of war into agricultural tools. • swords into plowshares: Cp. [Joel 3:10](#), where the nations are exhorted to hammer their plowshares into swords.

Isaiah 2:5

Come . . . let us walk: Walking in God’s light (his revelation) will lead to glorious participation in his kingdom (see [60:1](#); [1 Jn 1:7](#)). God is the only light that overcomes the darkness of sin and evil ([Isa 9:2](#)). People cannot generate such light in and of themselves ([59:9](#)) but must walk in the light God provides, as they trust him and live in obedience to his will ([50:10](#)). • The phrase descendants of Jacob alludes to Israel’s special historic relationship with the Lord as well as their history of sinfulness and rebellion (see [14:1](#); [48:1](#)).

Isaiah 2:5–22

The prophet threatened judgment and scoffed at human pride. All human structures (religious, economic, military, social) will come under divine scrutiny and be found deficient on the day of the Lord—that final day in history when God will judge the wicked once and for all ([1 Cor 1:8](#); [1 Thes 5:2](#); [2 Thes 2:2](#); [2 Pet 3:10](#); [Rev 20:7–15](#)). At times, the prophets also used the expression “the day of the Lord” (or others like it, such as “that day”) to refer to special instances of God’s judgment upon wickedness during the course of history (see [Isa 13:6, 9](#); [Ezek 13:5](#); [30:3](#); [Obad 1:15](#)). On the day of the Lord, God alone will be exalted, while all human wickedness and pride will be struck down. The

glorious day of God’s coming will fill wicked and arrogant humans with terror ([Isa 2:10, 19, 21](#)).

Isaiah 2:5–4.1

Isaiah condemned Israel’s and Judah’s arrogance and self-exaltation, warning them that only God was to be exalted. All attempts by humans to lift themselves up will actually result in humiliation.

Isaiah 2:6

The Lord had rejected his people to discipline them ([8:17](#)). While not permanent, the rejection seriously threatened their expectations of a glorious future. • sorcerers: These practitioners of pagan religion were expressly banned from Israel ([Deut 18:10–11](#)). • The Philistines were Israel’s ancient enemies ([Isa 9:12](#); [11:14](#); [14:29, 31](#)).

Isaiah 2:7–8

Isaiah pointed out all the things that people substitute for the true God: material achievements and securities (silver . . . treasures), military strength (warhorses . . . chariots), and objects of affection (idols). Such wealth and military strength characterized the reign of King Uzziah ([2 Chr 26:6–21](#)). Elsewhere, Isaiah pointed out the sheer folly of worshiping anything that is made with one’s own hands (see [Isa 44:9–20](#); [45:16](#)).

Isaiah 2:10

In the day of God’s judgment, people will seek refuge in caves in the rocks, natural hiding places in the rocky land of Judah, rather than repent in humility before almighty God. Kings and leaders as well as slaves and free persons will seek protection from judgment (see also [Rev 6:15](#)). • The terror of the Lord refers to God’s unbridled wrath against wickedness that will be revealed on the day of the Lord’s judgment. The prophecy shifts from Israel ([Isa 2:5–6](#)) to humanity at large. The Lord is against anything and anyone that exalts and trusts in human structures and beliefs rather than in him ([2:11–12, 22](#)).

Isaiah 2:11–12

A key theme in Isaiah is that the Lord will be exalted and humble people will be restored ([57:15](#)), while proud and mighty people are humbled ([26:5](#)). • The day of judgment and the “day of reckoning” are also called the “day of the Lord.” There are seven such references in chs [2–4](#) ([2:11](#), [17](#), [20](#); [3:6](#), [18](#); [4:1](#), [2](#)).

Isaiah 2:13

The cedars of Lebanon were prized trees used in the construction of Solomon’s Temple and palace ([1 Kgs 5:6](#)) and other important buildings ([Ezra 3:7](#)). They represented wealth and power ([2 Chr 25:18](#); [Pss 92:12](#); [104:16](#)), yet these mighty trees were as nothing before the Lord ([Isa 10:34](#); [33:9](#); see the boast of Sennacherib in [37:24](#)). • The oaks of Bashan were also an image of strength and splendor ([Ezek 27:6](#)); they, too, will disappoint ([Isa 33:9](#); [Nah 1:4](#); [Zech 11:2](#)).

Isaiah 2:13–16

The prophet used several images of human strength to elaborate on [2:11–12](#).

Isaiah 2:16

every magnificent vessel: Ornate sea-going vessels were a sign of prosperity.

Isaiah 2:17

The day of judgment is the “day of the Lord” (see [13:4–13](#)).

Isaiah 2:20–21

Animals such as rodents and bats lead a shadowy, subterranean existence. Those who worship idols will become like them in attempting to escape the Lord’s judgment.

Isaiah 2:22

The judgment prophecy of [2:6–21](#) is set between two related exhortations: to trust the Lord ([2:5](#)) and not to put trust in human beings ([2:22](#)). • Human strength is temporary, frail as breath (see [Ps 90](#)).

Isaiah 3:1

take away . . . bread . . . water: God had long ago warned of famine, with its horrible conditions that sometimes led to desperate acts, as one possible judgment for wickedness ([Lev 26:26–29](#)).

Isaiah 3:1–12

These verses continue the subject of judgment against Israel’s leadership (see [1:23–25](#)). The removal of leadership at all levels would allow the mob to gain control. Chaos and famine would turn Judah and Jerusalem into a social wasteland.

Isaiah 3:2–3

Regardless of their status, all military, civil, judicial, and religious leaders would be removed in the day of judgment ([39:7](#); [2 Kgs 24:14–16](#)). God would eventually give his people good leaders again ([Isa 1:26](#)) but not diviners and others who used pagan forms of revelation ([47:9](#), [12–13](#); see [Deut 18:10–12](#)).

Isaiah 3:4

Conditions would be so severe that boys and toddlers would qualify as candidates for office. By this, Isaiah either meant that adult leaders would be so decimated that only children would be left alive to assume the role or simply that the new leaders would be as immature, unwise, strong willed, and inexperienced as children.

Isaiah 3:6–7

Things would be so bad (a heap of ruins) that no one would want to take leadership. The people would become so desperate that anyone providing food or clothes ([3:7](#)) could be the leader of the

people. In fact, however, no one would have food or clothing (see [4:1](#)).

Isaiah 3:8-9

The failure of human strength and societal organization can be a form of divine judgment. • to his face: The people of Judah had become bold in their wickedness like the people of Sodom ([3:9](#); see also [1:9-10](#)).

Isaiah 3:9

The very look on their faces: At this time people boldly displayed their rebellion against God.

Isaiah 3:10

The godly—the righteous remnant—will receive God's rewards (see [40:10](#)).

Isaiah 3:11

The wicked who practice and execute injustice will receive God's just punishment.

Isaiah 3:13

The Lord is both the prosecutor and the supreme judge in this trial against his people.

Isaiah 3:14

elders and rulers: Wickedness and abuse by ungodly and incompetent leadership thwarts God's purpose for his people (see also [3:12](#)). Therefore, leaders come under more severe judgment because they bear responsibility for the welfare of those under them. • my vineyard: See the Song of the Vineyard ([5:1-7](#)).

Isaiah 3:15

The Lord cares for the poor. These were the marginalized and oppressed (see [1:17](#)), but God is their protector (see [25:4](#)). God called for his people

to share his concern for the poor, but the Israelites were exploiting them to gain wealth (see [3:14](#)).

Isaiah 3:16

The dramatic descriptions show how the people of Jerusalem loved their refined way of life. They openly displayed their proud self-reliance, power, and prestige. • Beautiful Zion: See "Zion" Theme Note.

Isaiah 3:16-4.1

This passage applies the prophet's teaching on arrogance (see [2:11-12](#)) to the people of Jerusalem. An alternate understanding is that this passage applies specifically to the women of Jerusalem.

Isaiah 3:17-25

In a reversal of fortune, the affluent and proud people of Jerusalem would suffer disgrace. Some of their ornaments ([3:18](#)) likely were amulets to keep evil away, but they could not ward off the calamity of judgment. These items of beauty were status symbols and represented financial security.

Isaiah 3:25

The men . . . will die in battle: Part of the city's hopeless destitution would be the deaths of the men.

Isaiah 4:1

During Isaiah's ministry, Jerusalem's population was so decimated through war, famine, and disease ([3:1-3](#); [6:13](#); [14:30](#); [22:2](#); [37:4](#)) that there were few men left, creating an absence of leadership (see [3:1-12](#)). Even worse conditions lay ahead with the approaching war between Judah and the alliance of Syria and Israel in 734-732 BC ([2 Chr 28](#)) and eventually the conquest and fall of Jerusalem (605-586 BC).

Isaiah 4:2

The branch in this context probably refers to the remnant that would constitute Israel's new beginning after the Exile (see [6:13](#)). Some also understand it as representing the ideal descendant of David, the Messiah (see [11:1](#); [Jer 23:5](#); [33:15-16](#); [Zech 3:8](#); [6:12](#)). • A beautiful and glorious transformation from shame and disgrace ([Isa 3:17-25](#)) to fertility and beauty would manifest God's presence and blessing among the remnant ([4:6](#)). • The fruit of the land, nature itself, would also be transformed from desolation to glory. Elsewhere, Isaiah described the future circumstances as resembling the Garden of Eden (see [51:3](#); [65:22](#)). The message of renewal finds its ultimate fulfillment in the new creation (see [Rom 8:19-27](#); [2 Cor 5:17](#); [Gal 6:15](#); [Eph 2:15](#); [4:24](#); [Rev 21:22-27](#)). • Those who survive in Israel—the remnant—would be the true citizens of Zion.

Isaiah 4:2-6

In bold contrast to the desperate picture of [3:16-4:1](#), this prophecy of salvation and hope (see also [2:2-4](#)) promised cleansing, consecration, and the renewal of God's presence with the remnant. The imagery in [4:5-6](#) alludes to Israel's exodus from Egypt, when a pillar of cloud and of fire guided and protected them. Israel's restoration from exile would be a second exodus.

Isaiah 4:3

To be holy was the requirement for citizenship in Zion, where God dwells in his glorious majesty (see [6:3](#); [Heb 12:14](#)). • The remnant would have their names recorded among the living in the Book of Life ([Exod 32:32](#); [Dan 12:1](#); [Mal 3:16](#); [Rev 3:5](#); [20:12](#)).

Isaiah 4:4

God's judgment has a purifying effect on his covenant people (see [Mal 3:3](#)). Justice must be satisfied before restoration can be offered.

Isaiah 4:5

The references to a canopy of cloud . . . and smoke and flaming fire recall God's continuous presence and protection during the exodus from Egypt ([Exod 13:21-22](#); [14:21-22](#)).

Isaiah 4:6

shelter (literally *shadow*; see [32:2](#)): See [32:2](#); God's protection would keep the remnant safe from enemies and from the destruction he would bring on the wicked ([33:14-16](#)).

Isaiah 5:1

The one I love refers to the Lord; the prophet was singing this song on the Lord's behalf. • At first, the song sounds like a love song, but by [5:3](#) readers realize it is actually a complaint. • On Israel as God's vineyard, see also [3:14](#); [Matt 21:33-46](#); [John 15:1-17](#).

Isaiah 5:1-7

The Song of the Vineyard expresses in poetic form God's indictment of the wicked leadership that had ruined his vineyard, Israel. Like some wisdom literature, it presents readers with an account of a puzzling situation ([5:1-2](#)) before giving its spiritual significance ([5:3-7](#)). The theme of the vineyard's transformation is found again in ch [27](#) and in Jesus' teaching ([Matt 21:33](#); [Mark 12:1](#)).

Isaiah 5:1-30

The prophet pronounced judgment through song ([5:1-7](#)) and prophecies of woe ([5:8-30](#)). Although Israel's future condition would be one of purity and fellowship with God ([4:2-6](#)), that future cannot ignore the present sinful condition of the people and their leaders.

Isaiah 5:2

The Lord gave the best care to his vineyard, preparing and nursing it as an expert agriculturalist. He watched over it with great attentiveness, planting the best vines—ones that

had the potential for abundant sweet grapes. God had great expectations of Israel as his people (see [Exod 19:5-6](#)), so the bitter grapes they produced—their unrighteous deeds—were useless and disappointing (cp. [Gal 5:22-23](#)).

Isaiah 5:3-4

Clearly, the Lord had graciously done everything possible for the vineyard. He was not to blame for the bitter grapes. • you judge: Isaiah wanted the audience to condemn the vineyard before he revealed that in fact they were the vineyard ([5:7](#)). This rhetorical tactic is similar to the one Nathan used to confront David ([2 Sam 12:1-5](#)).

Isaiah 5:5-6

The Lord promised to make his vineyard, Israel, a desolate place because it was fit only for destruction. Later, Isaiah prophesied the gracious, glorious transformation of Israel from desolation to fruitful vitality (see [55:13](#)).

Isaiah 5:6

The withholding of rain was at times a divine judgment ([Deut 28:23-24](#); [Hag 1:11](#); [2:16](#)). It was especially devastating to a society that depended heavily on agriculture.

Isaiah 5:7

The identification of Israel as the vineyard is a surprise that resolves the riddle of this passage. • Here, a powerful play on Hebrew words indicted Israel. The Lord expected justice (Hebrew *mishpat*) but saw only oppression (*mispakh*) of the needy. Instead of righteousness (*tsedaqah*), there were cries of violence (*tse'aqah*) against the poor (see [1:21-23](#)).

Isaiah 5:8-10

What sorrow: The first threat of judgment was against oppressive greed. Properties (house and field) were being taken by illegal means. The new owners were thugs who used every avenue to

enrich themselves at the expense of the poor (see [1 Kgs 21:1-29](#); [Amos 2:6-7](#)).

Isaiah 5:8-23

This section contains six pronouncements of sorrow—six threats of dreadful judgment ([5:8](#), [11](#), [18](#), [20](#), [21](#), [22](#)). The sorrows identify some of the “bitter grapes” produced by the vineyard of Israel ([5:1-7](#)).

Isaiah 5:10

As with drought ([5:5-6](#)), the reduction of crops was at times a divine judgment (see [Hag 1:6](#), [2:16](#)).

Isaiah 5:11-17

What sorrow: The second threat of judgment concerned indulgent lifestyles. The language throughout this section indicates a life of corruption.

Isaiah 5:12

Self-indulgent and contented, these people never think about the Lord. They were too busy enjoying their drunken parties to reflect on why things went bad in the first place, such as why God sent no rain, or why they lost a battle.

Isaiah 5:13

Israel and Judah would go into exile to Assyria (722 BC) and Babylon (586 BC). • The people did not respond to the Lord because they did not know him (see [1:3](#)). They likely knew about him, but their behavior showed that they did not know him in any intimate way.

Isaiah 5:14

The grave (Hebrew *Sheol*) represented the place of the dead in ancient Near Eastern thinking (see [14:9](#)).

Isaiah 5:16

God's kingship is by definition just and righteous, and he will be exalted by his justice. At his exaltation, oppressors will be condemned (see [1:21-23](#)).

Isaiah 5:18

God's ropes were "ropes of kindness and love" for Israel ([Hos 11:4](#)).

Isaiah 5:18-19

What sorrow: The third threat of judgment was against mockers, who openly treated God's authority with contempt.

Isaiah 5:19

The people challenged God to hurry up and do something to prove that he really exists and is in control of this world. The verb *hurry up* translates two Hebrew verbs: maher ("be quick") and khush ("be speedy"). The same Hebrew words are used in the name *Maher-shalal-hash-baz* ([Isa 8:1](#)). • God's plan was revealed to Isaiah. Little did the people know that God's purposes would turn against them.

Isaiah 5:20

What sorrow: The fourth threat of judgment was against a lack of integrity. • evil is good . . . dark is light . . . bitter is sweet: This twisted way of looking at life corrupts God's holy order.

Isaiah 5:21

What sorrow: The fifth threat of judgment concerned the folly of self-deception.

Isaiah 5:22-24

What sorrow: The sixth threat of judgment was against the indulgent lifestyle of the wicked.

Isaiah 5:24

The image of rotting roots reflects human transience (cp. [11:1](#); [27:6](#); [37:31](#)). • To despise the Lord's word means to ignore it, to live without regard for keeping it. Such an attitude toward God's revelation leads to folly and ruin ([Prov 1:30](#); [5:12](#); [15:5](#)).

Isaiah 5:25

mountains tremble: God's wrath against sinners is often expressed as the shaking of the earth's foundations ([13:13](#); [23:11](#); [24:18-19](#); [29:6](#); [54:10](#)). God's appearance in judgment or salvation in natural phenomena such as smoke, darkness, lightning, and earthquake is called a theophany (see [6:1-4](#), [6](#); [13:13](#); [Exod 19:18-19](#); [Ps 18:7-15](#); [Mic 1:3-4](#); [Rev 8:5](#); [16:17-18](#); [18:21-22](#)).

Isaiah 5:26

The signal was a banner raised on a long pole and often placed on a high hill (see also [13:2](#); [18:3](#); [30:17](#)). The expression signal to distant nations is common in Isaiah and might be a call for participation in battle (as here) or in salvation ([11:10](#), [12](#); [49:22](#); [62:10](#)). • Distant nations refers to the Assyrians and Babylonians, who served as instruments of God's judgment on Israel (722 BC) and on Judah (586 BC). They were the wild "animals" ([5:5](#)) called in to trample the vineyard ([5:1-7](#)). They would fiercely attack Israel and Judah, not letting up until God's judgment was complete ([5:27-30](#)).

Isaiah 5:30

day of destruction (literally *that day*; see study note on [2:5-22](#)). • In Old Testament prophecy, darkness represents the experience of God's alienation, wrath, and judgment (see also [8:22](#)), while light stands for his holy presence (see especially [60:2](#), [19](#)).

Isaiah 6:1

At the time of King Uzziah's death, the Assyrians had begun to reassert their dominance in the ancient Near East. It marked the beginning of an

era dominated by major world powers—Assyria, then Babylonia, Persia, Greece, and Rome. • I saw the Lord: “Lord” (Hebrew *’adonay*) is used to describe human rulers as well as God. God is the supreme King. • on a lofty throne: The apostle John also had a vision of God’s heavenly throne (see [Rev 4:2](#); [7:10](#); [21:5](#)). • If just the train of the Lord’s robe filled the Temple, how great and majestic must have been the robe itself and the one wearing it.

Isaiah 6:1-13

Isaiah’s marvelous vision of God as King on his throne served as a pivotal event in the life of the prophet. The historical circumstances surrounding this event can be interpreted in two ways: (1) Some see ch [6](#) as Isaiah’s original call to ministry, meaning that chs [1-5](#) and [7-12](#) fit into the reign of Ahaz, who came to rule after the death of Uzziah ([6:1](#)). If this were so, why was Isaiah’s call not at the beginning of the book? Perhaps his call was put in ch [6](#) for literary reasons, serving as a conclusion to chs [1-5](#) and an introduction to chs [7-12](#). The prophet’s own transformation and commissioning symbolizes the entire nation’s need for conversion if it wants to fulfill its mandate to be God’s light to the world. (2) Others understand chs [1-12](#) as chronological; Isaiah’s call in ch [6](#) would then serve as a recommissioning of the prophet to minister in a new way in a different period (the time of Ahaz) when his words would be rejected. Those who hold this interpretation point to [2:7-9](#); [3:16-24](#); and [5:8-14](#), contending that these passages reflect a time of prosperity, military strength, pride, and splendor; these conditions existed during Uzziah’s reign but not during Ahaz’s reign.

Isaiah 6:2

The mighty seraphim are heavenly beings not mentioned elsewhere in Scripture (but see also [Rev 4:6-9](#); [15:8](#)). The Hebrew term might suggest an association with fire. They covered their faces so as not to look on God.

Isaiah 6:3

The triple usage of the word holy emphasizes the absolute separateness of the Lord. • The whole earth is filled: Because there is no verb in the Hebrew, two slightly different translations of the

seraphim’s proclamation are possible. It could be that the earth, though defiled, is currently filled with his glory in creation. Or, it could mean that the earth *will* be filled with the glory of the Lord when he establishes his kingship on the earth in the future. Either way, the Lord’s glorious presence will one day dwell more fully on earth, despite humanity’s sinfulness and the power of wicked nations. God’s glory was further revealed in the incarnation of the Son ([John 12:41](#); [2 Cor 3:18](#); [4:4-7](#)).

Isaiah 6:5

It’s all over! I am doomed: The prophet felt unworthy of the vision. He was painfully aware of his personal uncleanness (sinful . . . filthy lips) when compared to the holiness of God. Isaiah knew that he was unworthy to speak the pure word of God, as were his people.

Isaiah 6:7

your guilt is removed, and your sins are forgiven: The prophet’s experience of forgiveness anticipated Israel’s national need for forgiveness and cleansing ([43:25](#); [44:22](#); see study note on 39:6-7).

Isaiah 6:8

Who will go for us? The Lord spoke in the presence of his angels, the heavenly council (see also [1 Kgs 22:19-22](#); [Jer 23:18, 22](#)). • Here I am: The prophet was so overcome by the grace of God in cleansing him that he willingly committed himself to a lifetime of ministry.

Isaiah 6:9

do not understand . . . learn nothing: The prophet’s words brought out the heart response of his audience. The people were so sunk in sin that when they heard the truth it did not bring them closer to God but actually drove them away (e.g., Ahaz, ch [7](#)). Yet the truth had to be declared. Jesus also applied this principle in his own preaching ([Matt 13:14-15](#); [Luke 8:10](#); [19:42](#); [John 12:40](#); see also [Acts 28:26-27](#); [Rom 11:8](#)).

Isaiah 6:10

Isaiah was God's agent to stimulate blindness and deafness in the wicked and sight and hearing in the godly (see also [29:9-10](#), [18](#); [35:5](#); [42:7](#), [16-19](#); [43:8](#); [56:10](#); [59:10](#)). • turn to me for healing: The Lord was ready to heal those who truly repented, but not those who merely wanted to avoid judgment while holding on to their sinful ways.

Isaiah 6:11

how long . . . until . . . the whole country is a wasteland: During the prophet's ministry (740 to 685 BC), the nation was plagued by wars, famines, and other forms of devastation.

Isaiah 6:13

Even if a tenth—a remnant—survive, the judgment would continue until nearly all were destroyed. The prophet often spoke of near extermination or decimation ([9:18-21](#); [10:20](#); [22:4](#); [48:19](#); [51:18](#)) but maintained the hope of a remnant who would make a new beginning ([7:21-22](#); [29:23](#); [37:31](#); [44:26](#); [49:19](#); [54:1](#)). • Israel's stump will be a holy seed: The stump represents a remnant of holy people (see [4:2-3](#)) whose new leader would be pleasing to the Lord ([11:1](#)).

Isaiah 7:1

Rezin was king of Syria. Damascus was Syria's capital city. • Pekah was king of Israel 740–732 BC. He was a renowned warrior ([2 Chr 28:5-8](#)). • Pekah and Rezin began to attack Jerusalem while Jotham was king (750–732 BC), and they intensified their efforts during the early years of young King Ahaz ([2 Kgs 15:37](#); [16:5](#)).

Isaiah 7:1-25

At one point in his reign, Ahaz found himself in a crisis. The leaders of Syria and Israel attacked Judah. They planned to replace Ahaz and force Judah to join them in their resistance against Assyria. Ahaz responded by calling Assyria in to help him ([2 Kgs 16:7-10](#)), thus refusing Isaiah's

challenge to trust the Lord instead ([Isa 7:12](#)). Although the Assyrians squelched the alliance of Syria and Israel, leading to the eventual downfall of both those nations, they also soon set their sights on total domination of Judah.

Isaiah 7:1-12.6

The historical context of these prophecies involved Assyria's rise to power and the alliance between Syria and Israel as enemies of Judah ([7:1-2](#); see [2 Kgs 16:5](#)). Assyria became God's rod to punish Syria, Israel, and Judah ([Isa 7-10](#)).

Isaiah 7:1-39.8

In this long section of the book, the nation of Israel was confronted with a vision of God, similar to how Isaiah was confronted in [ch 6](#).

Isaiah 7:2

hearts . . . trembled with fear: In contrast, Ahaz's son King Hezekiah faced the Assyrians some thirty years later with great faith (701 BC; see [37:6-7](#), [14-20](#)).

Isaiah 7:3

The aqueduct was a place where political negotiations took place later during Hezekiah's reign (see [36:2](#)).

Isaiah 7:4

he doesn't need to fear: This was a "fear not" prophecy (common in Isaiah) in which the Lord assured his people of his presence and purpose. • two burned-out embers: If Ahaz had God's perspective, he would have seen that Rezin and Pekah were minor threats who were about to be extinguished.

Isaiah 7:6

The son of Tabeel, otherwise unknown, was obviously sympathetic to Israel's and Syria's resistance against Assyria.

Isaiah 7:8

The Assyrian kings Esarhaddon and Ashurbanipal had Israel resettled with people from other places within sixty-five years (by 670 BC; see [2 Kgs 17:24–34](#)). • Damascus was crushed and completely destroyed by 732 BC, and Samaria was crushed by 722 BC.

Isaiah 7:9

The last sentence is a play on two Hebrew words: If you do not have faith (ta'aminu), you will not stand firm (te'amenu). Firm trust in the Lord is utterly essential, especially for a leader of God's people (see also [2 Chr 20:20](#)), and it must be firmly acted upon in order to demonstrate that it exists. Ahaz and his contemporaries trusted their enemy (Assyria) rather than God. By contrast, Hezekiah later demonstrated his faith in the Lord in a similar context (see [Isa 36–38](#)).

Isaiah 7:11

A sign of confirmation would be performed before Ahaz's eyes as a token of God's truthfulness. His son Hezekiah would also receive such a sign (see [37:30](#)).

Isaiah 7:12

I will not test the Lord like that: Despite this seemingly pious response (based on [Deut 6:16](#)), Ahaz was most likely already in negotiations with the Assyrians and had already decided whom he would trust for rescue in this war.

Isaiah 7:14

This prophecy received its ultimate fulfillment in the birth of Jesus Christ ([Matt 1:18–24](#)). Yet it is likely that it also had a partial fulfillment in Isaiah's day, either with the birth of godly king Hezekiah,

Ahaz's son, or with the birth of one of Isaiah's children. The similar sequence of the verbs in [Isa 7:14](#) and [8:3](#) (conceive . . . give birth . . . call) and the link between Immanuel and Maher-shalal-hash-baz in [8:5–10](#) suggest that Immanuel and Maher-shalal-hash-baz were the same person. • The name Immanuel (which means 'God is with us') symbolized God's presence and protection. God was with Judah during the attack by the alliance of Syria and Israel (734 BC), in the Assyrian crisis (701 BC), and throughout their prolonged existence until their fall in 586 BC. The kingdom of Israel fell during the time of Isaiah (722 BC). The assurance "I am with you" remained significant even in the exilic and postexilic periods ([41:10](#); [43:2, 5](#)). The greatest assurance ultimately came in Jesus Christ, the incarnate Son of God ([Matt 1:23](#); see also [Rev 12:5](#)).

Isaiah 7:15–16

By the time this child is old enough: The crisis involving the alliance of Syria and Israel against Judah was in 734 BC; by 732 BC Damascus, capital of Syria, was destroyed, and the northern kingdom, Israel, was defeated. • choose what is right and reject what is wrong: This was to happen by the age of 12, when a child was held responsible as an adult. In 722 BC, Israel went into exile. • he will be eating yogurt and honey: The land would be so depopulated that these delicacies would be available to all.

Isaiah 7:17

Israel broke away from Judah in 931 BC (see [1 Kgs 12:19–20](#)). • will bring the king of Assyria upon you: Ahaz called Assyria in to help ([2 Kgs 16:8–9](#)), but Assyria turned against him and made Judah a vassal state.

Isaiah 7:18–25

The repetition of in that day referred to the yet future day of the Lord. Judah would experience the judgment already announced by Isaiah as a foretaste of an even greater judgment to come: exile in Babylon (586–538 BC).

Isaiah 7:19

Locations such as desolate valleys, caves, and thorny places were places of refuge for the desperate (see [2:10](#)). However, Judah's enemies would find them there.

Isaiah 7:20

shave off everything: your land, your crops, and your people: In the ancient Near East, forced shaving was an act of disgrace (see [2 Sam 10:4-5](#)). Here it was a metaphor for the despoiling of the country.

Isaiah 7:23-25

Farmers faced near total disaster. Fertile agricultural fields (lush vineyards) would revert to wild grazing lands dominated by worthless plants (briers and thorns; see [5:6](#)).

Isaiah 8:1

The meaning of the name Maher-shalal-hash-baz ("Swift to plunder and quick to carry away") applies both to Judah's enemies ([8:4](#)) and to Judah itself ([8:7-8](#)). They had trusted Assyria in place of God, and now Assyria would turn on them and all but destroy them. God was with them (*Immanuel*; see [7:14](#)), but his presence would be destructive if they refused to trust in him (see [8:14](#)).

Isaiah 8:3

Like the name *Immanuel* ([Isaiah 7:14](#)), Maher-shalal-hash-baz is symbolic. This child might have partially fulfilled the Immanuel prophecy (see study note on Isaiah 7:14). The ultimate fulfillment of the Immanuel prophecy happened with the birth of Jesus ([Matthew 1:22-23](#)).

Isaiah 8:4

before this child is old enough: See also [7:16](#). • Damascus and Samaria were ruined and destroyed in 732 BC, fulfilling this verse along with [7:8](#), [19-20](#).

Isaiah 8:5-10

This prophecy connects the sign of Maher-shalal-hash-baz with the sign of Immanuel ([8:8](#), [10](#)).

Isaiah 8:6

The gently flowing waters of Shiloah supplied Jerusalem with water. Here they represent God's loving presence and provision (see [Ps 46:4](#)). • Ahaz rejected the sign and the promise of God's protection. He was not a man of faith ([Isa 7:9](#)), and now the people were following in his footsteps by placing their hope in Assyria to save them from King Rezin and King Pekah (cp. [7:7-9](#), [16](#)).

Isaiah 8:7

The mighty flood from the Euphrates River represents the invading Assyrian army (see [Jer 47:2](#)). The river would overflow all its channels when the Assyrians marched deep into Judah. This stood as a frightening contrast with the gently flowing waters of Shiloah ([Isa 8:6](#)).

Isaiah 8:8

chin deep: Judah barely survived the Assyrian assaults in 701 BC (see chs [36-37](#)). • submerging your land from one end to the other: From north to south, Judah was nearly devastated, except for the city of Jerusalem (see [1:8-9](#); chs [36-37](#)). • Immanuel: Despite their failure to trust him and the disaster it brought, God was still with his people (see [7:14](#)).

Isaiah 8:9-10

God's plan to rescue his stubborn people would ultimately be fulfilled. God planned to destroy Assyria, just as he does every other proud nation that rejects him or boasts in its own power.

Isaiah 8:10

God is with us: See [7:14](#); [8:8](#).

Isaiah 8:11–15

This text reveals the heart of Isaiah's message. The issue was fear of the Lord versus fear of people (see [7:9](#); [8:6](#)). When an individual fears people, the Lord becomes a trap and destruction is certain (cp. [Prov 29:25](#); see "Fearing People" Theme Note). For those who fear the Lord, he becomes a sanctuary; their salvation is assured.

Isaiah 8:12

People regarded Isaiah's message of non-involvement with Assyria as treasonous, part of a conspiracy. But Isaiah was not trying to play political games; rather, he proclaimed God's message. • What frightens them was the alliance of Syria and Israel attacking Judah (see [7:1](#), [4](#)).

Isaiah 8:13

To make the Lord . . . holy meant giving him first place in life and acknowledging that nothing is greater than he is. • Fear of God means reverencing him as God ([Prov 1:7](#)). The people of Judah were not to fear Israel and Syria or the Assyrians ([Isa 7:9](#); [10:24](#)).

Isaiah 8:14

He will keep you safe (literally *he will be a sanctuary*): God is a place of refuge. • stone . . . stumble . . . rock . . . fall: By trusting Assyria rather than God, the people of Jerusalem would find themselves in a trap and a snare as the Assyrians turned against them. For those who trust in the Lord, however, he is faithful and strong ([28:16](#); see [Ps 118:22–23](#); [Luke 2:34](#); [Rom 9:32–33](#); [1 Pet 2:6–8](#)).

Isaiah 8:16

instructions (Hebrew torah): The Torah defined Israel's covenant relationship with God, but the people were quick to forget (see also [1:10](#)).

Isaiah 8:16–17

The command to preserve Isaiah's teaching suggests that it was harshly received by his contemporaries, who might have wanted to snuff it out. Faithful disciples safely preserved the prophet's messages.

Isaiah 8:17

I will wait for the Lord . . . I will put my hope in him: Isaiah's message against Syria, Israel, and Assyria would be proven true in the historical events that followed. The fulfillment would further encourage the godly to await the final downfall of all ungodly power structures (see [8:9–10](#)). Waiting for the Lord requires submission, prayer, hope, and faith (see [25:9](#); [26:8](#); [33:2](#)), resulting in a quiet spirit and a renewal of inner strength ([40:31](#)). The book of Hebrews applies these words to Jesus Christ ([Heb 2:13](#)). • God had turned away; the people of Israel and Judah were alienated from the Lord because of their sin.

Isaiah 8:18

I and the children the Lord has given me (see the application to Jesus Christ in [Heb 2:13](#)): The names of the prophet Isaiah and his children carried significance as signs and warnings. Shear-jashub (*a remnant will return*; [7:3](#)) was a sign of God's faithfulness to Judah. Maher-shalal-hash-baz (*swift to plunder and quick to carry away*) signified the destruction of Damascus and Samaria ([8:1–4](#)) and the desolation of faithless Judah ([8:5–8](#)). The name of Isaiah (*Yahweh is salvation*) itself signifies that salvation is from the Lord alone. These three names also represent major themes in the book: the remnant, the desolation of Judah, and salvation. Immanuel (*God is with us*) embodies all of these themes, along with the idea that Judah would be protected if only it would trust in the Lord.

Isaiah 8:19–22

Isaiah contrasts his counsel with that of his ungodly contemporaries. Isaiah's message gives light, whereas the message of the spiritists led to darkness and death. • Mediums used various means of divination, including summoning the dead, in the attempt to determine the future (see

[19:3](#)). God had banned these useless activities ([47:9](#); [Deut 18:9–11](#)).

Isaiah 8:20

God gave instructions and teachings through the law and through his prophets, such as Isaiah (see [8:16](#)).

Isaiah 9:1

Zebulun and Naphtali were northern tribes in Israel ([Judg 6:35](#)). They were humbled by the Assyrian invaders under Tiglath-pileser III in 734 and 732 BC. In Jesus' lifetime, this prophecy was connected with his coming out of Galilee ([Matt 4:14–16](#)). • Galilee of the Gentiles was the region of Israel between the Sea of Galilee and the Mediterranean Sea. It was heavily influenced—culturally, religiously, and politically—by the surrounding Gentile nations.

Isaiah 9:1–7

Beyond destruction there is hope. In the Messiah's kingdom, the darkness would give way to great light, which was to dawn in Galilee and reach the whole nation, and then the whole world. The Messiah's rule would be marked by the vindication of the oppressed and the end of all oppression. He would bring justice and righteousness forever in a kingdom of peace.

Isaiah 9:4

The people experienced the rule of other nations as a yoke of . . . slavery and a heavy burden ([Jer 30:8](#)). • oppressor's rod: In [Isa 10:5](#), the Assyrians are called "the rod of [the Lord's] anger." Just as God's anger will cease, so will Assyria's oppression of Judah ([14:5](#)). • The Lord had destroyed the army of Midian through Gideon (see [Judg 6:35](#); [7:22–25](#)).

Isaiah 9:5

Burning the boots and uniforms marked the end of the need for instruments of war.

Isaiah 9:6

a child is born to us, a son is given to us: This child, the Messiah, would be David's descendant ([11:1](#)). • he will be called: These names can be read as four throne names, signifying the nature of the child's rule: (1) The Wonderful Counselor conforms to God's wisdom ([11:1](#); [25:1](#); [28:29](#); [40:13](#)), unlike the counselors of Judah ([1:26](#); [3:3](#)). (2) Mighty God is an affirmation of the Messiah's divine nature. (3) He cares for his children as the Everlasting Father, the father whose care continues forever (cp. [22:21](#); [63:16](#)). (4) The Prince of Peace is a leader who brings peace. • Alternatively, the four names could be collapsed into two: (1) "A Wonderful Counselor [is] the Mighty God"; and (2) "the Everlasting Father [is] a Prince of Peace" (on his nature, see [11:1–9](#)). • Jesus Christ, the Son of David ([Matt 1:1](#); [Luke 1:32](#); see also [Isa 7:14](#); [8:3](#), [18](#)), will bring in the kingdom of his peace ([Rev 19](#)).

Isaiah 9:7

Like Ahaz, this ruler will be a descendant of David. Unlike Ahaz and the rulers of Jerusalem ([1:21–23](#)), he would trust God and rule with justice and righteousness ([11:1–3](#)). Jesus the Messiah reigns for all eternity ([Luke 1:32–33](#)).

Isaiah 9:8–12

This prophecy of judgment was against the northern kingdom of Israel. Despite God's message that the Assyrians would crush them (chs [7–8](#)), the people of Samaria were foolishly confident that they could withstand the siege.

Isaiah 9:10

In their proud confidence, Israel thought it would replace whatever was lost with more expensive items (see [2:13–16](#); [Amos 5:11](#)).

Isaiah 9:11

Rezin's enemies were the Assyrians ([7:4](#), [17](#); [8:4](#)). Rezin was king of Syria (see ch [7](#)).

Isaiah 9:13–17

God's punishment was intended to bring repentance, not destruction; but Israel was apostate and refused to repent or seek the Lord.

Isaiah 9:17

Even widows and orphans, ordinarily objects of God's compassion ([1:17](#), [23](#); [10:2](#)), became objects of his wrath when they were unrepentant.

Isaiah 9:18–21

Following the decimation of leadership, civil war would destroy the nation like an out-of-control brushfire.

Isaiah 9:21

Manasseh and Ephraim represent the northern kingdom as its largest tribes. The two largest tribes of Israel and Judah fought amongst themselves. This is probably a reference to the war between Judah and the alliance of Syria and Israel, which is commonly called the Syro-Ephraimite War ([7:1–12](#)). In that conflict, brothers savagely fought against brothers ([2 Chr 28](#)).

Isaiah 10:1

What sorrow introduces a threat of divine judgment.

Isaiah 10:1–4

This prophecy was directed against Judah's leaders, who used their positions to enrich themselves at the people's expense.

Isaiah 10:3

The implied answer to Isaiah's rhetorical questions was that there would be no one to turn to when God punished Judah. • Disaster came first from the distant land of Assyria and later from Babylon.

Isaiah 10:5

The Assyrians were God's instrument (rod . . . club) in judging Syria, Israel, and Judah, but they would not go unpunished for their own wickedness.

Isaiah 10:5–19

This judgment was pronounced on Assyria because of their ruthless destruction of nations ([10:7](#)), blasphemous boasting ([10:12](#)), oppression ([10:13–14](#)), and self-perceived autonomy ([10:15](#)).

Isaiah 10:5–11.16

The primacy of the Lord's moral law was established in [9:8–10:4](#); this passage works out the implications of the law: (1) Assyria was only a tool in God's hands and was therefore as liable to judgment by God as any other nation ([10:5–19](#), [28–34](#)); (2) those among God's people who trusted in him and obeyed his covenant would be rescued ([10:20–27](#)); and (3) God would establish his kingdom on earth (ch [11](#)).

Isaiah 10:6

Despite their privileged calling as God's covenant people, Judah had become a godless nation, making them the object of God's anger ([10:4](#)). • The word plunder translates both the Hebrew words *shalal* and *baz*, recalling the name *Maher-shalal-hash-baz* (see [5:19](#); [8:1](#), [3](#), [5–10](#)).

Isaiah 10:7

will not understand: The Assyrians did not realize they were following God's intended purpose to punish Israel and Judah. Because they went about savagely killing and looting other nations of their own accord, God would also hold them guilty.

Isaiah 10:9

We destroyed: By 717 BC, the regions to the north of Judah were firmly in Assyrian hands. Calno, in northern Syria (referred to as *Calneh* in [Amos 6:2](#)), fell to the Assyrian king Tiglath-pileser III in 738 BC. Carchemish, on the Euphrates River, was taken

by King Sargon II in 717 BC. Hamath, on the Orontes River, was subjugated in 738 and 720 BC. Arpad was located south of Calno. Damascus and Samaria, the capitals of Syria and Israel, were taken in 732 and 722 BC, respectively ([Isa 7:8](#); [8:4](#)).

Isaiah 10:10

whose gods were greater than those in Jerusalem and Samaria: Assyria would make this argument while threatening Jerusalem ([36:19-20](#); [37:12](#)).

Isaiah 10:11

Assyria destroyed Samaria under Shalmaneser V and Sargon II in 722 BC ([2 Kgs 17:3-6](#)). If Samaria and Judah worshiped the same God, and Assyria had already defeated Samaria, the king of Assyria could expect to defeat Judah also.

Isaiah 10:12

Any royal power that exalts itself against the Lord, the Great King, is proud and arrogant (see [2:11-12](#)) and will be crushed.

Isaiah 10:13

my own powerful arm . . . my own shrewd wisdom (cp. [10:5](#)): God alone is all-powerful and wise. He plans the future, and he determines which nations will rise to power and which will be defeated.

Isaiah 10:15

ax . . . saw . . . rod . . . wooden cane: Such instruments are only as good as the person who uses them. Assyria considered itself independent of the hand of God, but their conquests were made possible only by his permission and to serve his purposes ([10:5](#)).

Isaiah 10:16

The fulfillment of this prophecy was in 701 BC, when 185,000 Assyrian troops were killed by plague and flaming fire (see [37:36](#)).

Isaiah 10:20

left . . . the survivors: A remnant from Jerusalem barely survived, but their safety was secure because God promised to preserve them (see [1:8-9](#); [4:2](#); [6:13](#); [37:31-32](#)). • All these wars would teach the Israelite remnant to no longer depend on allies such as Assyria. Instead, they would faithfully trust in the Lord (see [8:13](#); [17:7](#)).

Isaiah 10:20-27

In the midst of Assyrian oppression, there was hope for the remnant. This passage develops more fully the meaning of Shear-jashub, a remnant will return ([10:21](#); see [7:3](#); [8:18](#)).

Isaiah 10:22

God had similarly promised descendants as numerous as the sand of the seashore to Abraham ([Gen 22:17](#)). • rightly decided to destroy: God's decision was a just response to the people's persistent wickedness.

Isaiah 10:24

as the Egyptians did long ago: See [Exod 1:8-2:25](#).

Isaiah 10:24-34

God assured his people of his presence and purpose.

Isaiah 10:26

Gideon triumphed over the Midianites: See [Judg 7:25](#).

Isaiah 10:27

Israel's bondage ended in 539 BC with a new exodus from exile.

Isaiah 10:28–34

Look, the Assyrians are now at Aiath: The march described in [10:29–32](#) is a poetic account of Assyria's defeat. The places follow a route from the north down to Jerusalem. Upon arriving at Jerusalem, the Assyrians were forced to retreat. God was with Jerusalem, and eventually Assyria would be utterly destroyed. This passage might foretell Sennacherib's invasion in 701 BC (see chs [36–37](#)), but it could just as well describe an earlier or later invasion.

Isaiah 11:1

stump . . . shoot . . . new Branch . . . from the old root: This new growth refers to the continuity of David's royal family line despite its virtual cessation during the Exile (see also [6:13](#); [39:7](#); [Rev 22:16](#)). The new growth from the old roots would not be like the former frail and unjust descendants of David (see [Isa 4:2](#)). Jesus, the Messiah, is the final fulfillment.

Isaiah 11:1–16

The kingdom of the Messiah, first introduced in [9:1–7](#), is now considered in more detail. Isaiah challenged the Israelites about why they would trust in any of the nations when God had far better plans in mind.

Isaiah 11:2

The Spirit of the Lord will rest on the Messiah. The succession of David's line is guaranteed by the Spirit. The Messiah's coming would bring justice and righteousness ([11:4](#)), peace ([11:8](#)), and the extension of the Kingdom to the nations ([11:10](#); see also [32:15–16](#)). • The promised Messiah would have great wisdom and understanding, like Solomon, as well as knowledge and the fear of the Lord ([1 Kgs 3:28](#); [4:29](#); [Prov 1:1–7](#); [2:6–7](#)). • The Spirit of counsel and might alludes to [Isa 9:6](#). The Messiah will be full of wisdom and will have the power to execute his righteous rule.

Isaiah 11:3

obeying the Lord: Literally *the fear of the Lord*, as in [11:2](#) (see [Prov 1:7](#)).

Isaiah 11:4

The poor and . . . the exploited would receive the justice due to them, which the wicked leaders of Judah had previously withheld. • the force of his word: Literally *the scepter of his mouth* (see [Ps 2:9](#); [Rev 19:15](#)).

Isaiah 11:5

By virtue of the righteous character of the Messiah, his reign will be characterized by justice, righteousness, and truth, in contrast to the conditions of Jerusalem described in [1:21](#).

Isaiah 11:6

This prophecy was partly fulfilled during Isaiah's time or soon after. The complete fulfillment will occur when the Messiah (God's chosen one) arrives to begin and fully establish the age to come.

Isaiah 11:9

Nothing will hurt or destroy: There will be no evildoers, corruption, or sin on God's holy mountain (Zion).

Isaiah 11:10

the heir to David's throne: Literally *the root of Jesse* ([11:1](#); [Rev 5:5](#); [22:16](#)). • The Messiah will bring salvation to all the world ([Isa 2:1–5](#)). Members of other nations will even serve as priests and Levites ([66:20–21](#)), but only if they repent and believe in the true God.

Isaiah 11:11

The first time the Lord reached out his hand was at the Exodus; the second time will occur in the future when the Messiah gathers Gentiles ([11:10](#)) and his own people who live among the Gentile nations ([11:11](#)). The Exodus remained the paradigm of hope for those in exile (see [11:16](#); [35:8](#); [40:3](#); [43:19–20](#); [48:21](#)). • The remnant of his people

included Israelites who survived the Assyrian and Babylonian invasions and were sent into exile.

Isaiah 11:13

jealousy between Israel and Judah: The two kingdoms had become enemies during Judah's war with the alliance of Syria and Israel (see [7:1-12](#)). In the future, they would cooperate in joint military expeditions.

Isaiah 11:14

Philistia to the west: The Philistines were Israel's historic enemy. • The nations to the east included the Edomites, Moabites, and Ammonites. All foes would be vanquished.

Isaiah 11:15-16

Using imagery from Israel's past exodus, Isaiah encouraged his listeners by promising that God would bring his people out of Assyria the way he brought them out of Egypt ([Exod 14:29-15:18](#); see also [Rev 16:12](#)).

Isaiah 12:1

God's comfort is the main subject of chs [40-66](#).

Isaiah 12:1-6

The prophet's personal song of praise for God's salvation closes the meditations on trust in chs [7-12](#). God will prove himself trustworthy in his promises to rescue his people even though they initially refused to trust him. The song anticipates chs [40-66](#) with its themes of salvation, forgiveness, praise, joy, and the nations.

Isaiah 12:2

God's promise to save includes reconciliation ([1:18](#)), participation ([11:10](#)), cleansing and protection ([4:3-6](#)), peace and confidence ([32:16-17](#)), and restoration ([11:6-9](#)). • Lord God (Hebrew Yah Yahweh): The first word is an abbreviation of

the second. • The Lord God is my strength and my song: See [Exod 15:2](#); [Ps 118:14](#).

Isaiah 12:3

God's salvation is like a deep and unending source of water that provides life (see also [41:18](#); [Ps 87:7](#)).

Isaiah 12:4-5

Tell the nations what he has done: The story of salvation must be told, even beyond the community of Israel ([Pss 67:2](#); [70:4](#); [98:2](#)).

Isaiah 12:6

See [Pss 48:1](#); [96:4](#); [99:2](#).

Isaiah 13:1

At the time of this prophecy, Assyria was the major power. Isaiah anticipated the rise of Babylon as an even crueler kingdom that would destroy Judah and Jerusalem ([39:6-7](#); chs [46-47](#)). The universal language of [13:1-14:23](#) suggests that in this context, Babylon represents all wicked and arrogant nations in the same way that "Babylon the Great" does in the book of Revelation ([Rev 18](#)). Therefore, while this description of Babylon's fall applies to the fall of historic Babylon in 539 BC, it also applies until the final judgment against the ultimate kingdom of evil ([Rev 19](#)).

Isaiah 13:1-23.18

This section contains prophecies of judgment against the nations. By including a prophecy against Judah and Jerusalem ([22:1-25](#)) in the midst of prophecies against the pagan nations, Isaiah emphasized that Israel's identity as God's people would not protect them from God's punishment when they sinned as the other nations do.

Isaiah 13:2

A signal flag or banner that could be seen clearly from a great distance was often placed on a bare

hilltop as a call to battle. • God stands against Babylon as the symbolic representative of all evil kingdoms.

Isaiah 13:5

Just as Assyria was the rod of his anger ([9:4](#); [10:5, 15](#)), other nations serve as the Lord's weapons and carry out his will. The Medes and Persians conquered Babylon in 539 BC. • God's wrath is an expression of his justice as well as his intent to restore order to the world by obliterating evildoers ([10:25-26](#); see [Lam 2:22](#); [Ezek 7:19](#)).

Isaiah 13:6

When pronouncing judgment that is still in the future, the prophets sometimes spoke as though it had already arrived. This emphasized the urgency of turning back to God ([Ezek 30:3](#); [Joel 1:15](#); [3:14](#); [Obad 1:15](#); [Zeph 1:7](#)).

Isaiah 13:8

Pangs . . . like those of a woman in labor: The day of the Lord brings sudden and overpowering pain and fear for the wicked (see also [Jer 30:6](#); [Hos 13:13](#); [Mic 4:9](#), [10](#); [5:3](#)).

Isaiah 13:10

Cosmic upheaval and darkness are common images for the day of the Lord, a time of God's judgment (see also [Ezek 32:7-8](#); [Joel 2:10, 31](#); [3:15](#); [Matt 24:29](#); [Mark 13:24](#); [Rev 6:12-13](#); [8:12](#); cp. [Isa 30:26](#)).

Isaiah 13:11

punish the world: See [Rev 20:11](#).

Isaiah 13:12

Solomon's imported gold came from Ophir ([1 Kgs 9:28](#)).

Isaiah 13:13

God will shake the heavens. The earth will move: Cosmic upheaval will accompany God's coming in judgment (see study note on [5:25](#); see also [Hag 2:7, 21](#); [Heb 12:26-27](#); [Rev 16:17-18](#); [18:21-22](#)).

Isaiah 13:16

These terrible acts of war would be perpetrated against Babylon, itself a cruel conquering power (see also [Ps 137:8-9](#); [Jer 6:11-12](#); [Nah 3:10](#)).

Isaiah 13:17

The Lord is sovereign and controls history. He can stir up kingdoms to execute his will. • The Medes from northwestern Iran joined Persian King Cyrus in fighting against Babylon in 539 BC.

Isaiah 13:19-22

This picture of Babylon as a perpetually haunted ruin contrasts with its magnificence at its peak (see [Dan 4:29-30](#)).

Isaiah 13:20

Babylon will never be inhabited again: Babylon, often a symbol of idolatry, immorality, imperialism, and oppression in Scripture, will one day come completely to an end (see [Rev 18:2](#); [19:2](#)).

Isaiah 14:1

The Hebrew word here translated mercy draws from the imagery of a woman's maternal care for her child to illustrate God's merciful love for his people (see also [49:15](#); [66:13](#)). • God had initially chosen Israel as his special people when he called Abraham (see [41:8](#); [Gen 12:1-3](#)). Although their status did not change during the Exile, they faced God's wrath like any other wicked nation because they had rejected him. • settle once again in their own land: This promise began to be fulfilled in 538 BC (see [Ezra 1:1-11](#)). • People from many different nations would join Israel as the people of God (see also [Isa 2:3-4](#); [11:11-12](#); [19:18-25](#); [60:1-14](#)).

Isaiah 14:1-2

This message for Israel separates two prophecies of judgment against Babylon (ch [13](#); [14:3-23](#)).

Isaiah 14:2

Just as Israel was subject to the Lord, so the nations of the world would submit themselves to the Lord through Israel ([45:14](#); [49:7, 23](#); [60:12, 14](#); [66:23](#)). • The oppressed nation of Israel will rule over its enemies, assuming a position of power and favor with God.

Isaiah 14:3

God gives . . . rest (i.e., *relief*; [28:12](#); see [Deut 25:19](#); [2 Sam 7:11](#)) from the sorrow and fear, . . . slavery and chains Israel experienced under foreign oppressors (see [Isa 9:4](#)).

Isaiah 14:3-23

This taunting song for the king of Babylon is in the form of a funeral dirge (cp. [Rev 18](#)).

Isaiah 14:4

A taunt is a mocking comparison in song form. In this instance, the king of Babylon is compared to a dead man entering the world of the dead.

Isaiah 14:7-8

The land and people will be at rest and quiet because the oppression has ended and the king of Babylon has died. • The whole creation will join in praise, able to sing again (see also [42:11](#); [44:23](#); cp. [Rom 8:22](#)).

Isaiah 14:9

The Babylonians saw the place of the dead (Hebrew *Sheol*) as a place of no return. • stand up (literally *get up from their thrones*): The thrones reflect the Babylonian concept of the life hereafter

as a continuation of the same mode of existence as the present life. It appears that the other kings are honoring the great king of Babylon, but the next verses tell a different story.

Isaiah 14:10

weak as we are: The Babylonian king had no power over anyone after death and was unable to leave Sheol. The Israelites will mock this great king who on earth appeared to have no weaknesses.

Isaiah 14:11

Babylon's might and power and the sound of the harp were ended, and its magnificence was destroyed (see also [Rev 18:22](#)). • Maggots and worms symbolized death and decomposition ([Isa 66:24](#)).

Isaiah 14:12

fallen from heaven, O shining star: These words allude to the Canaanite story of the god Helel's rebellion against the god El (chief deity of the Canaanite pantheon) and his fall from heaven. Some see the fall of the king of Babylon here as symbolizing the fall of Satan (see [Ezek 28](#); [Luke 10:18](#); [Rev 12:9](#)). However, there is little to suggest that Isaiah understood it in that way. He was thinking of the historical king of Babylon. • son of the morning: The battle took place under the early morning sun. The Latin Vulgate translates the term as *Lucifer (morning star)*, a name for Satan in Christian tradition, but the Hebrew text makes no apparent reference here to Satan.

Isaiah 14:13

This verse alludes to the Canaanite belief that the chief god El and the other gods were enthroned on Mount Zaphon, a northern mountain (see [Ps 48:2](#); for a New Testament application, see [Matt 11:23](#); [Luke 10:15](#)).

Isaiah 14:14

Most High: See [Gen 14:19-22](#).

Isaiah 14:15–17

This is a restatement of [14:9–11](#). The dead spirits inhabiting the place of the dead will be startled and amazed that the Babylonian king, who ruled the world with his merciless might, has absolutely no power in death.

Isaiah 14:18–20

The absence of a proper burial was a sign of great shame and dishonor. Unlike other kings, the king of Babylon would be disgraced in judgment.

Isaiah 14:21

As another sign of disgrace, the king of Babylon would have no children to provide a future legacy.

- because of their father's sins: God looks at individuals in relationship to their families and their people. Here, the Babylonian king's children had joint responsibility for their father's actions (see also [Deut 5:9–10](#)).

Isaiah 14:22–23

Isaiah summarized the previous taunt ([14:3–21](#)) with this prophecy, spoken in the first person. God decrees the destruction and desolation of Babylon.

Isaiah 14:24

I have planned . . . I have decided: No nation can either diminish or resist God's plans to bring judgment against Assyria or his plans in general. The prophets understood and communicated God's plan so that his people could respond appropriately.

Isaiah 14:24–27

This prophecy resumes declaring judgment on Assyria (see ch [10](#)). The placement of this prophecy after the judgment against Babylon suggests close connections between Assyria and Babylon.

Isaiah 14:25

This prophecy told what would happen when Sennacherib attacked Hezekiah some years later in 701 BC (see chs [36–37](#)).

Isaiah 14:26

The Lord's power over Assyria is just one example of his sovereignty over the whole earth.

Isaiah 14:29

The king who attacked Philistia was probably Ahaz ([14:28](#)). • a more poisonous snake: This probably refers to one of the later Assyrian kings, either Sennacherib (701 BC), Esarhaddon (680 BC), or Ashurbanipal (668 BC).

Isaiah 14:31

The advancing army, probably Assyria, would stir up clouds of dust like smoke that were ominously visible in the north.

Isaiah 14:32

The Lord has built Jerusalem: God was fully willing and capable of defending Judah, and he did not want the kingdom to make alliances with nations such as the Philistines to protect themselves from the invading Assyrians.

Isaiah 15:1

Moab was Judah's enemy, situated on the eastern side of the Dead Sea. • In one night: Destruction would be sudden and decisive.

Isaiah 15:1–16.14

This message of judgment and lament concerned Moab's fall. The extensive references to Moabite place names indicate that Isaiah was thoroughly familiar with Moab.

Isaiah 15:2

In the ancient Near East, actions such as shaving or cutting off their beards revealed deep sorrow (see [Jer 48:37](#)).

Isaiah 15:4

Heshbon was the former capital of Sihon ([Num 21:23-26](#)). • Elealeh was located close to Heshbon. • Jahaz was between Heshbon and the Arnon River (see [Jer 48:34](#)).

Isaiah 15:5

My heart weeps for Moab: The prophet joined in the lament to express the greatness of Moab's pain. • Zoar was in the southeastern area of the Dead Sea ([Gen 14:2](#); [19:23](#)).

Isaiah 15:6

Identification of the waters of Nimrim is uncertain (see also [Jer 48:34](#)). • dried up . . . scorched . . . tender plants: For the theme of natural resources drying up as a form of judgment, see study note on Isa 24:4.

Isaiah 15:7-8

The precise locations of the Ravine of Willows and of Eglaim and Beer-elim are uncertain.

Isaiah 15:9

- *Dimon* is a play on the Hebrew word for *blood* (*dam*).
- *blood*: Many people from Moab had already died, but their punishment had just started.

Isaiah 16:1

Moab was known for its sheep (see [2 Kgs 3:4](#)). The lambs were sent as tribute to Judah in recognition of Judah's sovereignty over Moab. • Sela (*the cliff*),

an unknown remote site, was apparently where the Moabites escaped through the desert.

Isaiah 16:1-4

Moab is making a request to Judah for asylum (protection in another country).

Isaiah 16:3-4

Do not betray us . . . Hide them: Moab's situation would become so dire that they would beg for asylum in other lands.

Isaiah 16:4-5

This prophecy of salvation spoke of the future of David's dynasty. • Activities such as oppression and destruction would cease with the end of Moabite hostilities (see [2 Kgs 13:20](#)).

Isaiah 16:5

God would establish one of David's descendants as king (see also [9:7](#); [11:1-5](#), [10-12](#)).

Isaiah 16:6

The Moabites' hardened state of pride and arrogance and rage and boasting prevented them from humbling themselves before God.

Isaiah 16:6-11

The response to Moab's request for asylum ([16:1-4](#)).

Isaiah 16:8

The vineyards at Sibmah were located by the Moabite city of Heshbon. • Moab was like a luxuriant vine that extends far and wide, but Israel's beautiful vine reached to the ends of the earth ([27:6](#)). • The location of Jazer is unknown.

Isaiah 16:12

The hilltops were sites for pagan shrines (see [15:2](#)).
 • No one will be able to save them, including the idols the Moabites called on for protection (see [40:18-19](#); [44:18-19](#)).

Isaiah 16:14

Within three years, counting each day (literally *Within three years, as a servant bound by contract would count them*; see also [21:16](#)): A man who had sold himself into servitude for a period of time would calculate how much time remained right down to the final day. This verse refers to events that are unknown. • The glory of Moab will be ended, probably because of the Assyrian conquest of Moab (late 700s BC). • only a feeble few will be left alive: Though decimated by war, the Moabites still existed during Nehemiah's time ([Neh 13:23](#)).

Isaiah 17:1

Damascus, the ringleader in the alliance of Syria and Israel against Judah, fell when the Assyrian king Tiglath-pileser III invaded in 732 BC.

Isaiah 17:1-20.6

This section contains prophecies of judgment against Damascus, Israel, Ethiopia, and Egypt. The scene moves from the crisis of 734 BC (the alliance of Syria and Israel—see study note on 7:1-25) to the Assyrian crisis in 701 BC (see chs [36-37](#)).

Isaiah 17:2

The towns of Aroer were east of the Dead Sea (see [2 Kgs 10:32-33](#)). • Flocks will graze in the streets: The city would be useless for any other purpose.

Isaiah 17:3

The strategic fortified towns of Israel were the pride of Israel, but they could not resist God's purposes.

Isaiah 17:4

Israel's glory will grow dim: God will judge all human pride. • Israel's robust body will waste away like a person who is ill.

Isaiah 17:4-11

The vision shifts from Damascus ([17:1-3](#)) to the northern kingdom of Israel; Damascus and Israel were allies in the war against Judah, and both were later destroyed by Assyria.

Isaiah 17:5

The valley of Rephaim was a fertile valley in Judah; however, it looked bare after each harvest.

Isaiah 17:6

Although the God of Israel judged the wickedness of Israel, he was still its God.

Isaiah 17:7

The people referred to here are either Israelites or humanity at large. • look . . . turn their eyes: They will again put their trust in the Lord.

Isaiah 17:8

Canaanites and then Israelites worshiped the fertility goddess Asherah in wooded areas or, in the absence of wooded areas, using Asherah poles (see [27:9](#); [65:3](#); [Mic 5:14](#)).

Isaiah 17:9

The Hivites and Amorites were members of the original population of Canaan; they were to be destroyed when the Israelites conquered the land (see [Deut 20:17](#)).

Isaiah 17:10

The Israelites had mixed faith in the Lord with elements of Baal worship. They turned from the Lord, who alone is God and will not be held alongside an idol in people's hearts. • The term Rock refers to the Lord's ability to provide refuge (see [26:4](#); [30:29](#); [Ps 18:2](#), [46](#)).

Isaiah 17:12

At times, the sea represents opposition to God (see [Job 7:12](#); [26:12](#); [Pss 46:3](#); [93:3](#)).

Isaiah 17:12–14

God was present with Judah during the crisis.

Isaiah 17:13

God will silence them: The Lord is sovereign over the nations, as he is over the sea ([Ps 65:7](#)).

Isaiah 17:14

In the evening . . . by dawn: Despite frightening circumstances, Israel can have confidence in the Lord's ability to save quickly (see [37:36–38](#)).

Isaiah 18:1

Ethiopia was at the southern extremity of the kingdom of Egypt. At the time, Egypt was ruled by the dynasty of the Ethiopian Piankhi.

Isaiah 18:3

Both the battle flag and ram's horn were used to marshal and send signals to armies in battle (see [Judg 3:27](#); [6:34](#); [2 Sam 2:28](#)).

Isaiah 18:4

The Lord is untroubled by human activities; he watches quietly from his dwelling place and acts in his own time (see [Ps 2:1–4](#)).

Isaiah 18:5

your plans are ripening: Ethiopia had made every effort to form alliances to protect itself against Assyria, but its alliance with Judah would not help.

Isaiah 18:7

Conquered or weaker nations were often forced to pay tribute to a dominant king in the region (see [16:1](#); [2 Kgs 3:4–5](#)). The Ethiopians would come bringing gifts to honor the Lord for his defeat of the Assyrians (see also [2 Chr 32:23](#)).

Isaiah 19:1

Riding on a swift cloud shows God's sovereignty and power over creation ([Ps 104:3](#)). He is coming in judgment against Judah's enemies (see [Deut 33:26](#); [Pss 18:9–10](#); [68:4](#); [97:2–3](#)). • The idols of Egypt tremble because they are weak and impotent, unable to help (see [Isa 40:18](#); [45:16](#); [46:1](#)).

Isaiah 19:1–10

Egypt was vulnerable, depending on the Nile for food, fish, and industry. When the Lord struck the Nile, Egypt would be in dire straits, and their gods would not be able to help.

Isaiah 19:1–20.6

See also [Jer 46](#); [Ezek 29–32](#).

Isaiah 19:2

Egypt had a history of civil wars that ravaged the country. Egypt's fragile unity was breaking apart.

Isaiah 19:3

Idols . . . spirits, mediums, and those who consult the spirits of the dead were called upon in an attempt to ward off impending destruction (see [8:19–22](#); [47:12–13](#)).

Isaiah 19:4

hard, cruel master: In 671 BC, the Assyrian king Esarhaddon invaded Egypt and destroyed the royal city of Memphis. In 663 BC, Ashurbanipal attacked and destroyed Thebes (see [Nah 3:8-10](#)).

Isaiah 19:5

The waters of the Nile were Egypt's lifeline. Any disturbance in the regular pattern of flooding affected the whole nation. In ancient Egypt, the Nile was considered to be a god. However, the true God could easily dry it up.

Isaiah 19:9

There was no flax or thread: The drought crippled the linen industry.

Isaiah 19:11

Zoan was the capital of Egypt, located in the Nile delta (see [Num 13:22](#)). • officials . . . best counsel: The king depended on the strategies and counsel of wise men ([Isa 19:12](#); see [Gen 41:39-40](#)). • The officials of Zoan were known for all their wise ancestors, and Egypt liked to brag about them.

Isaiah 19:11-15

The prophet taunted the leaders and wise men of Egypt, who were helpless to avert tragedy.

Isaiah 19:12

Where are your wise counselors: Cp. [1 Cor 1:20](#).

Isaiah 19:13

Memphis was an ancient capital in Egypt located south of the Nile delta. It was destroyed by Esarhaddon in 671 BC.

Isaiah 19:15

There is nothing Egypt can do: No leader, idol, or conventional wisdom can stand against God's judgment. • The head and the tail represented all of Egypt's leaders from the greatest to the least important (see [9:14-15](#)).

Isaiah 19:16

An upraised fist (literally *waving the hand*) was a threatening motion.

Isaiah 19:18

five of Egypt's cities: This is probably just a way of saying "a number of cities" (see also [17:6](#); [30:17](#)). • Jews living in Egypt after the destruction of Jerusalem spoke Hebrew, here called the language of Canaan. • Heliopolis was devoted to Re, the sun god. At a time when Judah was resisting the Lord, Isaiah envisioned the Egyptians following the Lord.

Isaiah 19:19

This altar or monument refers either to the temple that was built by Jews at Elephantine in Egypt (500 BC), to some other Jewish place of worship, or perhaps to a memorial the Egyptians constructed in devotion to the Lord.

Isaiah 19:19-25

The new Egypt would receive a place in God's purposes together with Assyria and Israel.

Isaiah 19:20

The altar ([19:19](#)) would be a sign and a witness of the Egyptians' religious connection with Israel (see [19:24-25](#)). • God answers the prayers of those who cry to the Lord for help. • The Lord is a savior; he would protect the Egyptians even as he protected Jerusalem from the Assyrians.

Isaiah 19:22

strike Egypt: The Hebrew verb used here is the same as the one used for the tenth plague ([Exod 12:13, 23, 27](#)), bringing up associations of what God did during the Exodus. • The Lord, who brings a plague, can also bring healing. • he will listen to their pleas and heal them: This expresses a covenantal relationship between the Lord and Egypt (see [Isa 65:24](#)).

Isaiah 19:23

Traditionally, Egypt and Assyria were enemies of one another and of Israel. They were idolatrous to the core, but they would leave behind their enmity and their idols to worship the true God. • In the rugged terrain of the ancient Near East, a highway provided a means for safe, easy travel and trade (see [11:16](#); [35:8](#); [40:3](#); [62:10](#)).

Isaiah 19:24

Israel will be . . . a blessing in fulfillment of God's promise to Abraham ([Gen 12:3](#)).

Isaiah 19:25

Two designations usually reserved for Israel, my people and the land I have made (see [29:22](#); [32:18](#)), are applied here to foreign nations. The Lord promised to regard those from the nations who turn to him as his special possession ([63:17](#)).

Isaiah 20:1

Sargon of Assyria is Sargon II (721–705 BC). • Ashdod was one of the five Philistine cities that rebelled against Assyria in 713 BC.

Isaiah 20:1–5

Ashdod's reliance on Egypt and Ethiopia was useless. As a complement to his words, Isaiah walked about exposed and barefoot, a symbolic action for what God would do.

Isaiah 20:2

Prophets characteristically wore burlap or other rough clothing as a sign of mourning over the sins of the people (see [2 Kgs 1:8](#); [Mark 1:6](#)). • naked: That is, exposed in some way, possibly even completely nude.

Isaiah 20:3–4

This symbolic event took place some three years before the fall of Ashdod (see [20:2](#)). Through it, Isaiah became an object lesson for the people (see [8:18](#)).

Isaiah 20:5–6

Philistia's downfall was a warning to the people of Judah, who also relied on Egypt and other alliances rather than on God.

Isaiah 21:1

concerning Babylon—the desert by the sea: This description of Babylon was perhaps an ironic way to say that the land was physically lush but spiritually desolate. • Disaster . . . from the desert: Literally *from the desert, from the terrifying land* (cp. [Deut 8:15](#)).

Isaiah 21:2

I see: The prophet personalized Babylon's experience, which intensifies his poetry, as does the terse language and the repetition of similar sounds, such as the betrayer betraying (Hebrew habboged boged) and the destroyer destroying (Hebrew hashoded shoded; also in [33:1](#)). • The Elamites lived to the northeast of Babylon. Along with the Medes, they were archrivals of the Babylonians. • I will make an end to all the groaning Babylon caused: Babylon had caused groaning by attacking and enslaving many nations. It is likely that the Elamites and Medes played a part in the overthrow of Babylon in 539 BC ([21:9](#)).

Isaiah 21:3

I grow faint . . . I am too afraid: Through his vision, Isaiah experienced the terror of the Babylonian people (see also [Dan 8:27](#); [10:16-17](#)).

Isaiah 21:7

The riders were messengers who reported what had taken place on the battlefield.

Isaiah 21:9

Babylon is fallen, fallen: Assyrian king Sennacherib destroyed the city of Babylon in 689 BC. The final fall of Babylon was in 539 BC. In Scripture, Babylon represents all the ungodly power structures of this world, including nations and kingdoms that do not submit to God and his word. The apostle John gave hope with his prophecy that all Babylons will fall ([Rev 14:8](#); [18:2](#)). • All the idols of Babylon lie broken: False gods could not save the Babylonians (see [Isa 46:1-2](#)).

Isaiah 21:10

O my people: The focus shifted back to the people of Judah. • Judah would be oppressed (threshed and winnowed) by the Babylonians but Babylon, too, would fall. • I have told you everything: The prophet had been faithful in his duty to report what the Lord revealed to him.

Isaiah 21:11-12

Edom: Hebrew *Seir*, which was the mountainous area of Edom. • how much longer until morning: Edom's suffering would be a long ordeal. The Assyrians were dominant in the ancient Near East during the 700s and 600s BC.

Isaiah 21:11-17

These two prophecies pertain to Edom and Arabia, located in the territory between Babylon and Israel. These outlying regions suffered under Assyrian domination, and like Judah, they would not be able to rest under Babylon's oppressive regime.

Isaiah 21:12

Morning is coming, but it would mark the beginning of another oppressive era. Because the Babylonians were on the horizon, night will soon return.

Isaiah 21:13

Desdan was a tribe in Arabia (see [Ezek 27:20](#); [38:13](#)). • Caravans would hide in the deserts of Arabia from attacks by the Assyrians and Babylonians, both of whom harassed the Arabian tribes (see [Isa 21:1-10](#); [Jer 49:28-29](#)).

Isaiah 21:13-17

Compare [Jeremiah 49:28-33](#).

Isaiah 21:14

Tema was an oasis in Arabia on a main trade route from Babylon.

Isaiah 21:15

Assyrian weapons of war such as the drawn sword and the bent bow were highly advanced compared to the primitive weapons used by desert peoples.

Isaiah 21:16

Kedar was an Arabian tribe that had great wealth and possessions (see [60:7](#); [Ezek 27:21](#)).

Isaiah 21:17

Only a few . . . will survive: Cp. [10:22](#); [14:30](#); [16:14](#); [24:6](#), [13](#); [37:32](#).

Isaiah 22:1

concerning Jerusalem—the Valley of Vision: The meaning of the Hebrew phrase is uncertain.

Assuming that it refers to Jerusalem (see [22:5](#)), it is ironic: Jerusalem sits atop a hill, and visions were not typically thought to originate in a *valley*. Similarly, Jerusalem was proud of its self-perceived religious *vision*, but its inhabitants were spiritually blind (see [6:10](#); [42:18](#)).

Isaiah 22:1-4

The prophet rebukes the people for their excitement over the Assyrian retreat (701 BC). They did not foresee that the Babylonian army would later (in 586 BC) complete what the Assyrians failed to do, namely, the destruction of Jerusalem.

Isaiah 22:1-25

This message addresses the Assyrian siege of Jerusalem in 701 BC (see chs [36-37](#); [2 Kgs 18:17-19:37](#)) and perhaps the people's preparation for the subsequent Babylonian siege in 588-586 BC.

Isaiah 22:2

The reveling city was full of feasting and drinking ([22:13](#); see [23:7](#); [32:13](#)), probably in response to the Assyrian retreat. Now a new threat approaches—the Babylonian siege (586 BC). • The people died not in battle but by famine and disease. Siege warfare left the inhabitants of the city cut off from needed agricultural resources and in a terrible sanitation and health crisis.

Isaiah 22:3

Leaders might try to flee, but they would not escape (see [2 Kgs 25:4-6](#)).

Isaiah 22:4

Leave me alone to weep: Isaiah mourned the victims and the decimation of his people (see [6:13](#)).

Isaiah 22:5

Jerusalem's walls were broken by the invading Babylonians, who breached them with battering rams ([2 Kgs 25:4](#)).

Isaiah 22:5-8

The defeat of Judah would be a manifestation of the yet-future day of the Lord (see study note on 2:5-22). Jerusalem would be impotent in the day of disaster.

Isaiah 22:6

Elamites: Elam was to the east of Babylon and would later play a role in Babylon's defeat (see [21:2](#); also [Jer 49:34-39](#)). • The actual location of Kir is unknown (see also [Amos 1:5](#)).

Isaiah 22:7

The Kidron and Hinnom valleys were located to the east and south of Jerusalem.

Isaiah 22:8

to the armory: This magnificent building was both an armory and a storage place for valuables (see [39:2](#); [1 Kgs 7:2-6](#)).

Isaiah 22:8-11

The inhabitants of Jerusalem planned for war by counting weapons, checking walls, and preparing a water supply. However, the people did not consider God's plans (see [13:1-14:23](#)). Although Hezekiah was very prominent in these efforts, the second person verbs are plural. Isaiah was apparently not singling out Hezekiah, as he did Hezekiah's father Ahaz ([7:1-4](#)).

Isaiah 22:9

Jerusalem (literally *the city of David*): Calling Jerusalem "the city of David" evokes memories of Israel's greatest king and God's blessing upon him and the nation (see also [60:14](#)). • You store up

water in the lower pool: Hezekiah expended great energy in ensuring a constant supply of water (see [22:11](#); [2 Kgs 20:20](#)).

Isaiah 22:12–14

Judah's feasting and disobedience resulted in a prophecy of judgment.

Isaiah 22:14

you will never be forgiven for this sin: The people of Judah added sin upon sin to the point that God would justly condemn them. This foreshadowed the Exile; although it took place in 586 BC, Isaiah was already anticipating it in 701 BC.

Isaiah 22:15

The actions of Shebna represent among the populace a lack of confidence in God's ability to rescue Jerusalem from the Assyrian attack. • A palace administrator held the highest possible position in the royal court (see [22:21–22](#)).

Isaiah 22:15–25

Shebna and Eliakim were two royal officials in King Hezekiah's court (see [2 Kgs 18:18](#); [19:2](#)). Apparently assuming that death at the hands of the Assyrians was inevitable, Shebna planned for an ostentatious burial place ([Isa 22:16](#)). Although the rebuke of Shebna preceded Assyria's siege of Jerusalem in 701 BC (see [22:19–21](#); [36:3](#)), it connects well with the admonitions of [22:1–13](#) regarding the ensuing Babylonian siege.

Isaiah 22:16

Shebna was building a beautiful tomb . . . a monument. This lavish burial place was intended to last for centuries.

Isaiah 22:18

toss you away into a distant, barren land: Shebna would not find a resting place or have a memorial

(cp. [14:11–20](#)). • your glorious chariots: In his high position, Shebna had lived in luxury.

Isaiah 22:19–20

drive you out of office: Shebna ([22:15](#)) was demoted to court secretary by the time of Jerusalem's siege, when Eliakim ([22:20](#)) was the palace administrator ([36:3](#)). Eliakim was a true servant of the Lord.

Isaiah 22:21

A leader is like a father to the people when he truly cares for them and addresses their needs. In contrast, Shebna was concerned only for himself.

Isaiah 22:22

The key to the house of David represents a high position of honor in the royal court (see also [Rev 3:7](#)). • When he opens doors . . . when he closes doors: The officer with the highest position has sole authority in giving access to the king (cp. [Matt 16:19](#)).

Isaiah 22:25

I will pull out the nail: Even godly Eliakim would not be able to save Judah or David's dynasty from God's judgment. The people of Judah would go into exile more than a century later ([39:6–7](#)).

Isaiah 23:1

The ships of Tarshish plied the sea between the Phoenician coast and the port of Tarshish in Spain (see [2:16](#); [23:6](#)). • rumors you heard in Cyprus: Cyprus was the last port of call for sailors coming home from Spain before the final leg of their journey to Tyre.

Isaiah 23:1–18

Tyre was a prosperous seaport northwest of Israel. The relationship between Judah and Tyre went back to the time of David and Solomon ([1 Kgs 5:8–](#)

9). Tyre, with its proximity to plentiful forests and to the Mediterranean Sea, was one of the commercial centers of the ancient Near East. Its fleets were renowned, and its colonies brought it great prestige and riches. The city came under repeated attack by the Assyrians, Babylonians, and Macedonians, and it fell to Alexander the Great in 332 BC. Isaiah not only prophesied the end of Tyre but by implication warned all whose wealth and earthly securities lead to pride instead of dependence on God (see [Isa 2:12-16](#); [Matt 11:21](#)).

Isaiah 23:2

Sidon was a Phoenician port to the north of Tyre. • Tyre's commercial network of traders was extensive.

Isaiah 23:3

Fish, agricultural produce, flax, and linen were all harvests from along the Nile (see ch [19](#)). • Tyre was known as the marketplace of the world, comparable to modern cities like New York, Hong Kong, or London.

Isaiah 23:4

Part of the great port city of Tyre was on an island. The island city was a fortress of the sea, but it fell in 332 BC. • I am childless; I have no sons or daughters: This metaphor was a judgment on Tyre's colonial ports around the Mediterranean Sea. In the ancient world, to reach old age without having children was considered a terrible fate (see [49:21](#); [54:1](#)).

Isaiah 23:5

Egypt depended on the ships from Tyre for the export of its products (see [23:3](#)).

Isaiah 23:8

The Lord had brought this disaster on Tyre ([23:9](#)). • Through commercial links, Tyre had created wealth for itself and its trading partners; in this sense, Tyre was a great creator of kingdoms.

Isaiah 23:10

Sweep over the land like the flooding Nile: This difficult phrase means either (1) that the sailors who had returned from Tarshish were being invited to loot ruined Tyre; or (2) that the people of Tarshish were forced to move back to their agricultural fields to make their living (instead of trading) now that Tyre had been destroyed.

Isaiah 23:11

Phoenicia was the region north of Israel. Tyre and Sidon were its main cities.

Isaiah 23:13

Babylonia was stripped and looted by the Assyrians under Sennacherib (689 BC); eventually it rose to be a mighty empire once again.

Isaiah 23:15-18

There was hope for Tyre.

Isaiah 23:17

Metaphorically, Tyre was a prostitute because of its indifferent willingness to sell anything to anyone (cp. [Rev 17:2](#); [18:3](#), [12-13](#)).

Isaiah 23:18

Even though Tyre's earnings came from unrighteous commerce, the profits will be given to the Lord rather than being squandered. • There will be good food and fine clothing for the Lord's priests. The theme of the wealth of the nations being brought to the Lord in Jerusalem is more fully developed in [60:5-11](#); [61:6](#).

Isaiah 24:1

destroy the earth and make it a vast wasteland: There is a play here on the Hebrew words *baqaq* (*destroy*) and *balaq* (*make a wasteland*). The

devastation will begin with Judah and be extended to the whole world (see [1 Pet 4:17](#)). • All the earth will be destroyed, the people as well as national political structures.

Isaiah 24:1-23

Here the judgments described in chs [13-23](#) are extended to the creation at large.

Isaiah 24:1-27.13

This section is often referred to as the “Little Apocalypse” because of its similarities to the book of Revelation. In these chapters Isaiah takes readers out of the present into a vision of the future world. The universal imagery of the Little Apocalypse makes it difficult to assign the events described to any precise historical situation. That means that these chapters cannot be used to outline a sequence of events or create a historical blueprint for the future. Instead, the imagery is intended to create an impressionistic drama of an unfolding world that is both like and unlike the present. The combination of aspects of the old era with aspects of the new era (for instance, people of Zion will all be righteous [new], but still long for their redemption [old]) is consistent with the New Testament concept of the future age breaking into and overlapping with the present evil age ([2 Cor 4:4](#); [Gal 1:4](#)). Peter, for example, wrote of believers as living in the last days ([1 Pet 1:12](#); [2 Pet 3:3](#)) even though the last day remains yet future ([2 Pet 3:10](#)).

Isaiah 24:4

earth . . . dries up . . . land wastes away and withers: The prophets often used the imagery of a drought to get the attention of people who live off the land (see also [Jer 23:10](#); [Joel 1:12](#); [Amos 1:2](#)).

Isaiah 24:4-13

All humanity is guilty ([Rom 3:23](#)) and under condemnation (see [Isa 59:1-15](#)). Judgment is likened to a failed grape harvest that brings drinking and feasting to a halt.

Isaiah 24:5

Isaiah was probably referring to the everlasting covenant that God made with all humanity through Noah ([Gen 9:8-17](#)). The prophet saw a parallel with the wickedness in his day and the wickedness of the pre-flood world.

Isaiah 24:6

The effect of sin is so great that no earthly thing or action can adequately atone for it. Hope ultimately lies in God himself. God has reconciled the world to himself in Christ ([Col 1:19-20](#)).

Isaiah 24:7

Merrymakers will sigh and mourn because they are dependent on wine for pleasure.

Isaiah 24:8

Tambourines and melodious chords of the harp represent good times (see [5:12](#); [Rev 18:22](#)).

Isaiah 24:10

city writhes in chaos: With normal levels of urban disarray being raised to chaotic and dangerous disorder, people will be forced to seek refuge in locked homes.

Isaiah 24:11

Gladness has been banished from the land, not by edict, but because there is no reason to celebrate.

Isaiah 24:13

stray olives left on the tree: The remnant will include godly people both from Israel (see [17:6](#)) and from other nations. • The theme of the remnant is common in Isaiah (see “The Remnant” Theme Note; see also [10:22](#); [14:30](#); [16:14](#); [24:6](#); [37:32](#)).

Isaiah 24:14–16

In spite of wailing and ruin, the sound of praise is heard from all directions. Even while still experiencing the pain of the devastation of the old world, the godly will respond with joyous expectation for the new world.

Isaiah 24:16

But my heart is heavy with grief: The prophets were well acquainted with the emotional pain brought on by the sin of their people and its consequences (see [15:5](#); [21:4](#); [Jer 15:10](#); [Mic 1:8](#)). • Although aspects of the new world are present, the deceit of the old world still prevails for a time.

Isaiah 24:18

No one can escape the day of the Lord (see study note on 2:5–22). • Destruction falls like rain from the heavens (literally *the floodgates of heaven are opened*): The imagery is like the flood in Noah's time (see study note on Gen 7:11–12). • the foundations of the earth shake: An earthquake is characteristic of a *theophany*, a physical manifestation of God's presence (see also [Isa 6:4](#); [13:13](#); [19:1](#)).

Isaiah 24:21

The phrase translated gods (Hebrew *tseba' hammarom*, “armed host of the heavens”) might refer to pagan gods represented by the stars. It might also refer to the angels or even demons ([Rev 12:4](#), [9](#)). Judgment will extend to all parts of creation ([Isa 13:13](#); [34:5](#); see [Eph 6:11–12](#)).

Isaiah 24:22

put in prison . . . punished: See also [2 Pet 2:4](#); [Rev 9:2](#), [11](#); [17:8](#).

Isaiah 25:1–5

Isaiah here praises God for protecting the needy (see [12:1–6](#)).

Isaiah 25:1–12

The second part of the Little Apocalypse (see study note on 24:1–27:13) describes praise for God's judgment ([25:1–5](#), [11–12](#)) and salvation ([25:6–9](#)).

Isaiah 25:3

Assyria and Egypt were strong . . . ruthless nations, but in the future they will exalt God rather than their own power.

Isaiah 25:6

In Jerusalem: Literally *On this mountain*—that is, the mountain of the Lord (see [2:2](#); [24:23](#)): This does not refer to a geographical city but to Zion, the eternal city of God (see [1:8](#), [27](#)).

Isaiah 25:6–8

The banquet is a symbol of God's providing richly for all those who will receive his gracious invitation ([Rev 3:20–21](#); [19:9](#)).

Isaiah 25:8

He will swallow up death forever: Isaiah's hope was God's power over sin and sin's devastating results. In the New Testament this promise is realized in Jesus Christ ([1 Cor 15:54](#)). • The Lord's presence will be a source of eternal comfort; he will wipe away all tears (see [Rev 21:4](#)).

Isaiah 25:9–12

The new community of God's people will respond in joy and faith. When the enemy is defeated, God's people will be free forever.

Isaiah 25:10

- *on this mountain*: This refers to Mount Zion in Jerusalem.
- Moab (see [Isaiah 15:1–16:14](#)) represents the nations facing judgment, those who rely only on themselves (see [Isaiah 34:5–17](#)).
- *as straw is trodden*: The people would be helpless and dying in very shameful circumstances.

Isaiah 25:11

Isaiah used the image of a swimmer forcibly kept under water to illustrate that Moab's people are hopelessly doomed and their human pride will be conquered.

Isaiah 26:1

Our city refers to Zion, the eternal city of God, where the Lord is present to protect and bless his people (see [1:8](#), [27](#); see also [Ps 46](#)). Zion stands in direct contrast to the “mighty cities” of the nations ([Isa 25:2](#); [26:5](#)), which are helpless and are brought down to “ruins.” • The walls of God's salvation protectively enclose his people; no one can hurt them again.

Isaiah 26:1–6

The new community of God's people is likened to the citizens of a city, securely held together by the Lord. They are righteous, faithful, peaceful, and trusting.

Isaiah 26:1–21

This section of the Little Apocalypse (see study note on [24:1–27:13](#)) is a song of praise and a prayer for redemption.

Isaiah 26:2

Open access is given to all who, like God and his Messiah, are righteous and faithful. The citizens of true Zion are committed to the Lord.

Isaiah 26:3

A perfect peace, marked by harmony, quietness, and confidence, is a benefit of the new creation.

Isaiah 26:5

The proud and arrogant are often characterized as exalting themselves (see [2:11–12](#)), whereas God humbles them.

Isaiah 26:6

Justice finally occurs when the needy walk all over the ruins of the city where the proud have perished.

Isaiah 26:7

God will do what is right for those who walk in his way, even if they have to suffer a while longer (see [24:16](#)). One day, they will experience harmony and integrity (see [Prov 2:8–9](#); [15:19](#)).

Isaiah 26:7–21

The godly pray for the end of oppression and the full establishment of God's kingdom. Isaiah encouraged the godly to persevere as they wait for their final vindication and the resurrection of the body.

Isaiah 26:8

we show our trust (see [26:3–4](#); literally *we wait for you*): Waiting involves trust in the Lord and longing for his redemption. • People express their commitment to God by obeying his laws; mere lip service is not sufficient.

Isaiah 26:9

I search . . . I earnestly seek: Cp. [Ps 63:1](#).

Isaiah 26:10

God has shown kindness to the wicked. Although they deserve judgment (see also [Rom 2:4](#); [2 Pet 3:9](#)), he has been patient and forbearing and has blessed them. However, time will run out one day.

Isaiah 26:11

An upraised fist expresses anger and the threat of judgment (see also [19:16](#)). • Fire was often an image for God's judgment.

Isaiah 26:15

This verse is a confident expression of thanks for God's blessings. In Isaiah's time, during King Hezekiah's prosperous reign, the borders of the nation of Israel were extended, and people gave glory to God for his great deeds.

Isaiah 26:16

While waiting for God's salvation ([26:1](#)), the godly were in distress and longed for their vindication. They prayed beneath the burden of God's discipline. In Hezekiah's time, Judah was in distress when Sennacherib attacked and destroyed the whole nation except for Jerusalem.

Isaiah 26:17

The imagery of a pregnant woman in childbirth describes the nation's pain when Assyrian king Sennacherib attacked it in 701 BC (see [37:3](#)).

Isaiah 26:18

Only God can give salvation and bring life (see [59:9-15](#)).

Isaiah 26:19

those who die . . . will live: There is hope for the remnant. Some hold the minimal interpretation that this means the people would be restored to the land after the Exile (see [Ezek 37:11-12](#)) or that the Lord would preserve Jerusalem (see [Isa 29:4, 6-8](#)). More likely it refers to the resurrection of the body from the grave (see [25:7-8](#)). The Old Testament has little to say about the resurrection, but this text anticipates fuller development in the New Testament (see [1 Cor 15:12-58](#)).

Isaiah 26:20

God will punish the wicked, so the godly should go home and stay out of the way.

Isaiah 26:21

The wicked retain power now, but their oppressive rule will end in the day of the Lord's wrath, when he will punish them for their sins.

Isaiah 27:1

Israel adapted the imagery of Leviathan to refer to evil powers that oppose God. Leviathan's death symbolizes the end of evil, Satan, the demonic, and the dominion of forces hostile to God (see [51:9](#); [Pss 74:14](#); [104:7-9](#), [26](#); see also the serpent in [Gen 3](#); [Rev 12](#); [13](#); [16:13](#); [20:2](#), [10](#)).

Isaiah 27:2-6

The Song of the Fruitful Vineyard, in which the vineyard represents God's people (cp. [5:1-7](#)).

Isaiah 27:3

God identifies himself as the Lord of the covenant to assure his people that what he says and does is reliable (see [Exod 6:2-3](#)). The phrase is used many times throughout Isaiah. • watch . . . watering . . . watch: The Lord will provide even greater care and protection for his ultimate vineyard than he did for Israel, his first vineyard (see [Isa 5:1-2](#)).

Isaiah 27:5

God expects all his people to turn to him and to trust him for help. • Let them make peace with me is God's offer of reconciliation for his people.

Isaiah 27:6

Jacob's descendants will take root and the remnant will increase ([37:31](#); cp. [5:24](#); [14:30](#); for application to the Messiah, see [11:1](#), [10](#)). • fill the whole earth: The fulfillment of this prophecy extends beyond the restoration of Israel from exile to the second coming of the Lord Jesus. It includes all the righteous children of God—Jews and Gentiles—who suffer but remain obedient as they wait for the fullness of redemption (see [26:18](#); [John 15:1-8](#)).

Isaiah 27:7

Despite being God's covenant people, Israel was struck and punished like any other wicked nation. However, Israel was not completely destroyed; a remnant remained.

Isaiah 27:7-11

Isaiah reminded readers of the reasons for the Exile and judgment: Israel's sinfulness, God's righteous judgment, and the absence of divine compassion.

Isaiah 27:8

The Assyrians exiled large numbers of citizens from the northern kingdom of Israel when Samaria fell in 722 BC. The Babylonians exiled many from Judah from 605 to 586 BC. • Storms from the east were known for their destructive effects (see [Job 27:21](#); [38:24](#); [Jer 4:11](#)).

Isaiah 27:9

- God's justice requires him to punish sin to correct behavior and purify. The exile in Babylon happened to cleanse Israel's wickedness and remove all of Israel's sins (see [Romans 11:27](#)).
- This aimed to end all pagan worship in Israel, including the incense altars and the poles used for worshipping the goddess Asherah.

Isaiah 27:10

Places previously associated with human power and accomplishment would be ruined to the extent that animals would graze in them.

Isaiah 27:11

The people were outside of God's covenantal care; they foolishly turned away from him.

Isaiah 27:12

Yet: God's withholding of mercy from Israel ([27:11](#)) will be temporary. • from the Euphrates River . . . to the Brook of Egypt: God's remnant will return from Assyria and Egypt to the territory that God promised to Abraham ([Gen 15:18](#); see [1 Kgs 4:21](#)).

Isaiah 27:13

The great trumpet was used to gather the people (see [Matt 24:31](#)).

Isaiah 28:1

The drunks of Israel epitomized pride, spiritual complacency, and scorn for God and his commands. • Unlike Jerusalem, Samaria was in a fertile valley.

Isaiah 28:1-29

The glory of Samaria, capital of the northern kingdom of Israel, is here contrasted with the glory of the Lord. This section represents the first of the six woes (What sorrow . . .).

Isaiah 28:1-33.24

This section is connected by a series of six threats of judgment or woes (cp. [5:8-23](#)). Apart from the initial address to Samaria in [28:1-13](#), the remainder of the section is addressed to Judah, especially because of their inclination to trust Egypt to rescue them from Assyria ([30:2](#)).

Isaiah 28:2

the Lord will send: The covenant God will act against his own people, whose behavior had effectively disqualified them as God's people (see [Hos 1:9](#)). • The mighty army is that of the Assyrians, who destroyed Samaria in 722 BC.

Isaiah 28:5-6

In the future, after God's judgment has purged his people, he will restore a righteous remnant, transforming the desires and character of his people. Samaria will no longer be the source of Israel's pride; instead, they will glory in the Lord, their true crown.

Isaiah 28:7

The priests and prophets led the people astray. • Intoxicating beverages such as wine and alcohol were prohibited for priests while fulfilling their duties ([Lev 10:9](#)).

Isaiah 28:7-13

The focus returns to the lamentable present situation in Israel (and Judah). The leaders and people will be ensnared by their own schemes.

Isaiah 28:9-10

The people had become hardened to God's revelation ([1 Cor 14:21](#)).

Isaiah 28:11

God will have to speak through circumstances such as hardship, exile, and death in order to get through to his hardened people. • a strange language: In the New Testament, Paul applied this text to the spiritual gift of tongues as a sign of judgment to unbelievers (see [1 Cor 14:21-22](#)).

Isaiah 28:12

Had his people listened, God's revelation would have led them to rest (see [48:18-19](#)). But they would not listen because of their hard hearts ([65:12](#)).

Isaiah 28:13

one line at a time, one line at a time, a little here, and a little there: The Hebrew here is difficult to understand. The words might be intentional nonsense to illustrate the point that the people were so spiritually blind that God's clearest revelation was nonsense to them (see [6:9-10](#)).

Isaiah 28:14-22

After having pronounced judgment on Samaria ([28:1-13](#)), Isaiah now pronounces judgment on Jerusalem. The leaders of Judah are accused of being as blind as those in the northern kingdom of Israel.

Isaiah 28:15

cheat death (literally *have made a covenant with death*) . . . dodge the grave: There are two interpretive possibilities: (1) The people had sold themselves to the Canaanite god of death, Mot, in return for his supposed protection. (2) The prophet was being sarcastic; the people thought their various political and economic moves guaranteed their personal security, but they had actually destroyed themselves. • lies and deception: The

leaders did not think of themselves as deceptive, but they were.

Isaiah 28:16

The Lord himself is the reliable foundation stone in Jerusalem, a precious cornerstone of the true city of God. There would be real hope in Jerusalem if the leaders and the people would only turn to him. If they would trust in God, they would be secure in the most terrible storm or the most devastating earthquake (see [8:14](#); [Ps 118:22](#); [Matt 7:24-27](#); [21:42](#); see the application to Jesus Christ, [Rom 9:33](#); [10:11](#); [1 Cor 3:11](#); [Eph 2:20](#); [1 Pet 2:4-7](#)).

Isaiah 28:17

The Lord judges people on their works, which reveal the presence or absence of living faith (for justice and righteousness, see [1:21-23](#)).

Isaiah 28:20

The bed. . . . The blankets: The leaders were ill-prepared for God's coming in judgment.

Isaiah 28:21

as he did . . . at Mount Perazim: See [2 Sam 5:20](#). • God had rescued Israel through a hailstorm at Gibeon ([Josh 10:10-12](#)), but now he would turn against them.

Isaiah 28:23

Listen to me: The analogy that follows was written as a wisdom poem, with Isaiah calling on his audience to pay careful attention and to discern what is right.

Isaiah 28:24-29

A farmer knows that there are right and wrong ways to do things, but the leaders of Judah were not that intelligent.

Isaiah 28:27-28

The Lord has a variety of means (a heavy sledge . . . a light stick) for accomplishing his purposes. There are degrees of judgment.

Isaiah 28:28

he doesn't keep on pounding it: This process would end; after judgment would come redemption.

Isaiah 28:29

wonderful teacher (or *counselor*; see [9:6](#)): God's people should learn wisdom about God's ways, as the farmer has done.

Isaiah 29:1-2

Ariel was another name for Mount Zion ([29:8](#)); it probably means *altar of God*.

Isaiah 29:1-8

In the Assyrian siege, the Lord would be fighting against Jerusalem, but he would force the Assyrians to abandon Jerusalem in his own time.

Isaiah 29:1-14

This is the second of the six woes (What sorrow . . .).

Isaiah 29:3

The Lord himself would come against Jerusalem, surrounding and attacking it.

Isaiah 29:4

God's goal was to destroy the sinful pride of the people of Jerusalem. Their voice would rise as if from the grave. Through the Assyrians, God would humble his people, but he would not abandon them.

Isaiah 29:6

will act for you (literally *you will be visited*): God would bring rescue for his people. • thunder and earthquake . . . storm and consuming fire: These phenomena indicate a theophany (see study note on 5:25).

Isaiah 29:7

The Assyrians' sudden lifting of the siege came like a dream . . . like a vision in the night. God would save Judah and judge Assyria.

Isaiah 29:8

Like a hungry or thirsty person, the Assyrians could taste the victory over Jerusalem. Yet they never became victorious.

Isaiah 29:8–12

Jerusalem's blindness kept its people from understanding God's plan.

Isaiah 29:10

a spirit of deep sleep: The people's folly was reinforced by God's judgment on them (cp. [Rom 1:24–32](#); [11:8](#)); they had no perception of reality. • Prophets were also sometimes called visionaries. Neither the people nor their prophets would understand what God was doing ([Isa 6:9–10](#)).

Isaiah 29:13

These people used pious-sounding language in their prayers and talk (see [Matt 15:8](#); [Mark 7:6–7](#)), but they did not truly honor God. • In their hearts, they were not committed to the Lord at all. • In their worship, they followed man-made rules and regulations rather than God's word.

Isaiah 29:14

Human wisdom . . . intelligence . . . will disappear (see [1 Cor 1:19](#)). The prophet had already spoken

of the failure of Egypt's wise men ([Isa 19:11–12](#)); even Judah's wise men would blunder.

Isaiah 29:15

Their plans might refer to the advice that royal counselors were giving Hezekiah, who at first attempted to free himself from Assyria by making alliances with Egypt (715 or 701 BC). • The people were conspiring to commit evil deeds in secret, but God saw everything.

Isaiah 29:15–24

This threat of coming judgment is the third of the six woes (see study note on 28:1–33:24). It begins with judgment but moves to a vision of creation being renewed and of the wicked coming to an end.

Isaiah 29:16

Potter . . . clay: The Lord's sovereignty is beyond challenge. Scripture does not discourage asking God hard questions, but there is no place for resistance to God's will (see [10:15](#); [45:9](#); [64:8](#); [Rom 9:20](#)). • He didn't make me: Such claims against God demonstrate a total unwillingness to recognize God's intimate involvement with every aspect of a person's life.

Isaiah 29:17

The forests of Lebanon are usually an image of luxuriant growth (see [2:13](#); [14:8](#)), but here they represent desolation.

Isaiah 29:18

The people were deaf and blind in heart and spirit (see [6:10](#); [42:18](#); [43:8](#)). Yet humanity and all of creation would be renewed (see [35:1–5](#)).

Isaiah 29:21

The false testimony that led to the oppression of the poor through trickery in the courts of Isaiah's era would end. Because of God's work in their

hearts, the people would turn from their sinful behavior of the past.

Isaiah 29:22

Abraham was the father of all Israel (see [Gen 12:1-3](#); see also [Gal 3:29](#)). • Rescued from human abuse and God's judgment, the people would no longer be ashamed; their disgrace resulted from the apparent failure of what they had trusted (see [Ps 71:1](#); [1 Pet 2:6](#)).

Isaiah 29:22-24

The prophecy of woe, which began at [29:15](#), now ends with a prophecy of salvation.

Isaiah 30:1

The wisdom of the people of Judah was not directed by God's Spirit (cp. [11:2](#)); instead, they had formed alliances that God did not approve of. Although the Assyrian attack on Jerusalem was overwhelming, making an alliance with Egypt demonstrated that the leaders of Judah depended on human resources for their protection rather than on God. Fortunately, Hezekiah later had a change of heart (see chs [36-37](#)).

Isaiah 30:1-5

This prophecy was against Judah's dependence on Egypt. It is the fourth of the six woes (see study note on [28:1-33:24](#)).

Isaiah 30:1-33

After threatening Judah with judgment because of their stubbornness and their reliance on Egypt ([30:1-17](#)), God again committed himself to deal compassionately with his people and to break the power of their enemies.

Isaiah 30:4

Zoan: See [19:11](#). The location of Hanes is uncertain.

Isaiah 30:6

Caravans moved from Judah through the Negev and the Sinai Peninsula to Egypt to avoid the main coast road that was under Assyrian control. It was a dangerous region, filled with lions and poisonous snakes. People would risk their lives to make a worthless alliance. • Being weighed down with riches might refer to money being sent to Egypt to buy that nation's help.

Isaiah 30:6-7

This taunt was against those who were busy trying to please the Egyptians in order to get Egypt's military support.

Isaiah 30:7

Harmless Dragon: In ancient mythology, Rahab was the enemy of the good gods and was depicted in fearsome terms, somewhat like a giant crocodile (see [27:1](#); [51:9](#); [Job 41:1-34](#)). By saying that Egypt was *harmless*, the prophet meant that it would be of no help to Judah.

Isaiah 30:8-11

God instructed the prophet to write down the vision for future generations. The present generation was rebellious; they rejected God's word in favor of the false prophets' fantasies (see [8:16-17](#)).

Isaiah 30:11

Stop telling us: The people of Judah did not want to be confronted about sin or judgment.

Isaiah 30:12

The whole society accepted oppression and lies. People reinforced each other's delusions, so it was considered acceptable to trust that Egypt would protect them from Assyria, even though that was a lie. It was also considered legal and legitimate to oppress the poor by taking their land.

Isaiah 30:12-17

Judgment would suddenly overtake the people of Judah because they were content with their fantasy world, and they refused God's path to rest and quietness.

Isaiah 30:15

The people of Judah needed to repent of their sinful ways ([30:12-14](#)), returning to the Lord, in order to be rescued. • Trust in the Lord would bring quietness and confidence, unlike their frantic negotiations with Egypt.

Isaiah 30:16

Judah's reliance on Egypt to supply swift horses (see [Ps 33:17](#)) amounted to a rejection of God's help and threatened to bring about its fall.

Isaiah 30:17

One . . . Five: This curse is the opposite of God's blessing for obedience ([Lev 26:8](#); [Deut 32:30](#)). • The Assyrians had dominated the rest of the land of Judah, leaving Jerusalem isolated like a lonely flagpole on a hill.

Isaiah 30:18

A faithful God would restore righteous order to the world by punishing the wicked and rescuing his people from them (see [1:27](#); [Ps 96:10-12](#)). • God blesses those who wait; faithful people do not rush ahead of him to solve their own problems but instead rely on his power and goodness.

Isaiah 30:18-33

This prophecy of salvation includes promises that directed Israel's attention away from their present adversity to the glorious future awaiting the children of God.

Isaiah 30:19

This was probably a challenge and promise to Hezekiah during the Assyrian siege of Jerusalem (see chs [36-37](#)). If he would just trust in God, his people would weep no more. • The Lord cares for the needs of his people; when they ask for something, he will surely respond.

Isaiah 30:20

adversity for food and suffering for drink: A city under enemy siege for a long time would eventually be overcome by starvation and disease. God did not intend that this disaster should destroy the people of Jerusalem, rather that it would be a tool to teach them.

Isaiah 30:21

The people's own ears will hear and follow God's instructions (see [6:9-10](#); [29:18](#); [35:5](#)).

Isaiah 30:22

One aspect of Hezekiah's reforms was to remove silver idols and other idolatry of Ahaz's era and to call the people back to the worship of the God of Israel ([2 Kgs 18:4-5](#); [2 Chr 29](#)).

Isaiah 30:23-24

The people of Judah would again enjoy covenant blessings rather than curses (see [Lev 26:4](#)).

Isaiah 30:26

The Lord who struck his people would also heal them and cure the wounds he gave them.

Isaiah 30:27-33

In this prophecy of judgment against the nations, Isaiah foretold that Assyria's power would be broken by God's strong arm, not by the Egyptians.

Isaiah 30:28

like a flood up to the neck: Assyria's destruction would be as devastating as their invasion of Judah (see [8:8](#)).

Isaiah 30:30

His mighty arm presents an image of strength that echoes God's victory over the Egyptians in the Exodus ([63:12](#); see [Exod 15:6](#)). • devouring flames ... huge hailstones: Such phenomena are associated with God's appearance in a theophany (see study note on Isa 5:25).

Isaiah 30:31

royal scepter: The Lord, the true King, would be victorious over the threatening Assyrian king.

Isaiah 30:32

tambourines and harps: Instruments formerly silenced in judgment ([24:8](#)) would again be used by God's people; this time, the people would celebrate the Lord's goodness rather than becoming spiritually complacent (see [5:12](#)).

Isaiah 30:33

Topheth was a pagan altar in the valley of Ben-Hinnom outside Jerusalem where child sacrifices were offered to the Ammonite god Molech by burning ([2 Kgs 23:9-10](#)).

Isaiah 31:1

What sorrow: This is the fifth of the six woes (see study note on 28:1-33:24). • Looking to the Lord implies seeking his guidance with a worshipful attitude (see [Deut 4:29](#); [Ps 105:3-4](#)).

Isaiah 31:1-3

Isaiah delivered another vision regarding Judah's negotiations with Egypt, which probably took place in 705-701 BC. During that time, the conquering Assyrians were on the move, threatening Judah. At

first, Hezekiah tried political and military means to avert being totally conquered (see [2 Kgs 18:13-16](#)).

Isaiah 31:4-9

This prophecy concerned God's protection of Jerusalem and its rescue from the Assyrians.

Isaiah 31:9

princes will flee: This was fulfilled when Sennacherib fled to Nineveh after God destroyed 185,000 troops (see [37:36-37](#)). • God himself was the fire or flame that would devour Assyria.

Isaiah 32:1

a righteous king: The Messiah ([11:1](#)); the emphasis now is on righteous and wise leadership ([Prov 8:20](#)). • In Isaiah's day, honest princes were few and far between (see [Isa 3:1-6](#); [28:7-19](#)).

Isaiah 32:2

like a shelter ... a refuge: The same words were also used to describe God's protection ([25:4](#)) and his provision of life-giving water ([41:18](#); [43:19-20](#)). The leaders would serve as God's agents in blessing his people.

Isaiah 32:5

Only foolish people value fools and scoundrels as heroes (see also [19:11, 13](#); [32:6-8](#)).

Isaiah 32:6

Because they do not care about God's standards of justice and righteousness, fools have no regard for those who are hungry or thirsty (see [1:17](#); [58:7, 10](#)).

Isaiah 32:7

smooth tricks . . . crooked schemes: See [Prov 6:12, 18; 16:27; 24:8-9](#).

Isaiah 32:9

The women of Jerusalem lie around in ease. Complacent in their high standard of life and low standard of morality, they put their trust in wealth and status to maintain their way of life.

Isaiah 32:9-15

This prophecy of judgment was against the complacent women of Jerusalem. God's promises regarding the future did not justify continuing in sin.

Isaiah 32:10

In a short time: Assyria's siege of Jerusalem (701 BC) was looming.

Isaiah 32:11

Burlap was worn to show . . . grief, especially when mourning (see [Ps 30:11](#)). The Assyrian conquest of the farmlands of Judah and most of its cities (except Jerusalem) would cause rich people in the large cities to mourn.

Isaiah 32:14

Jerusalem was eventually destroyed, but by the Babylonians, not the Assyrians (for a prediction of this, see [39:1-8](#)).

Isaiah 32:15

The Spirit would transform the nation into a godly community and bring in an era of justice and righteousness (see also [Joel 2:28-32](#)). The Spirit is connected to the Messiah ([Isa 11:1](#)) and the servant ([42:1; 61:1](#)). • wilderness . . . bountiful crops: When the people are transformed, nature will be too.

Isaiah 32:17

Being right with God and humans will bring peace (Hebrew shalom; see [26:3; 48:18; 52:7](#); cp. [Isa 3:18](#)). Peace is more than the absence of conflict. It includes personal wholeness and does not depend on outside circumstances (see also [Rom 5:1](#)).

Isaiah 32:18

Living in safety and feeling at rest were blessings of Israel's covenant with the Lord (see [Lev 26:5-6](#)), but the people's sin had previously brought curses rather than blessings (cp. [Isa 32:9-11](#)).

Isaiah 32:19

the forest . . . the city: The godly would remain secure even with evidence of God's judgment all around them.

Isaiah 33:1

This was the sixth threat of woe (see study note on 28:1-33:24). • Although the Hebrew text does not specifically name Assyria as the object of the prophecy in this chapter, Isaiah undoubtedly had Assyria in mind; they were the *destroyer* most immediately at hand when the prophecy was written. The prophecy applies, however, to any who seek to destroy God's people; this included, but was not limited to, the Babylonians (see chs [13-14](#)). • When you are done betraying: Wicked nations often break political agreements with other nations when these contracts are no longer to their own advantage.

Isaiah 33:2

The godly community prayed for God to be merciful in response to the promise of [30:18](#).

Isaiah 33:9

Sharon, Bashan, and Carmel were all fertile areas. Their desolation represents the destruction Assyria had inflicted on Israel.

Isaiah 33:11

In most passages, the Assyrians were turning other nations into worthless dry grass and stubble (see [17:13](#); [29:5](#); [40:24](#); [41:2](#)). Here, ironically, they get a taste of their own medicine.

Isaiah 33:14

The godless were people who lived without regard for God and his law. • The image of a devouring fire came from God's judgment of offenders during the wilderness journey ([Exod 24:17](#); [Deut 4:24](#)). God still expects people to worship him with reverence and awe ([Heb 12:29](#)).

Isaiah 33:15

A godly life provides evidence that an individual truly knows God (see [Col 3:5-17](#); [Jas 2:14-18](#); [1 Pet 1:14-16](#); [1 Jn 1:5-6](#)).

Isaiah 33:17

The king is the human representative ([32:1](#)) of the Great King, God himself ([33:22](#)). • The land belonging to God's people would appear to be without borders because the foreign enemies had been judged ([54:3](#)).

Isaiah 33:17-24

This vision is about God's reign in Zion.

Isaiah 33:18

Assyrian officers brought great terror to Judah when the Assyrians defeated various cities around Jerusalem ([2 Kgs 18:13](#)).

Isaiah 33:19

The strange, unknown language was the tongue of Assyria and later of Babylon (see [28:11](#)).

Isaiah 33:24

The people of Israel were the people of Zion (cp. [33:20](#)). • sick . . . the Lord will forgive their sins: See [43:25](#).

Isaiah 34:1-17

This prophecy of judgment was against the nations at the terrifying day of the Lord (see study note on [2:5-22](#); see also [63:1-6](#)).

Isaiah 34:2

completely destroy: See [Lev 27:28-29](#).

Isaiah 34:3

It was a disgrace for a corpse to remain unburied.

Isaiah 34:4

The heavens . . . stars: See also [13:10](#); [Joel 2:30-31](#); [Matt 24:29](#); [Mark 13:24-25](#); [2 Pet 3:10-13](#); [Rev 6:13-14](#).

Isaiah 34:5

Edom here represents what all the nations would experience, just as Moab was singled out in ch [25](#).

Isaiah 34:6

Bozrah was a city in Edom, southeast of the Dead Sea.

Isaiah 34:8

The Lord's revenge refers to God's wrathful but righteous vengeance against his enemies and the oppressors of his people on the day of the Lord. • Edom will be paid back: There will be retribution for Edom's crimes against Judah (see also [Ps 137:7](#); [Lam 4:21](#); [Obad](#); [Mal 1:3-5](#)). Edom, with its history of treachery, would come to an end.

Isaiah 34:9

Edom's judgment was similar to the judgment of Sodom and Gomorrah ([Gen 19:24](#); see also [Jer 49:17-18](#)).

Isaiah 34:10

See also [Rev 14:11](#); [19:3](#).

Isaiah 34:11

The identification of some of these birds is uncertain, but they inhabited wild and deserted places and many were considered unclean ([Deut 14:11-18](#)).

Isaiah 34:11-14

Wild animals, night birds, and hostile plants with thorns and nettles created an eerie environment.

Isaiah 34:16

Search the book of the Lord: Isaiah's prophecy was God's witness to the truthfulness of his word. • The power of the Spirit enacts the Lord's decrees, assuring that all prophecy comes together to be fulfilled as God promised.

Isaiah 35:1

God's land would become like a wasteland, spiritually desolate and physically depleted. However, God would turn the desert into a garden (see also [32:15](#)), taking his people from exile to glory.

Isaiah 35:1-10

God will come to vindicate and transform his people. Instead of being deaf, blind, and lame (see [6:10](#)), the people will be pure, holy, and redeemed.

Isaiah 35:2

Lebanon . . . Mount Carmel . . . Sharon: There will be a reversal of earlier judgments (see [2:13](#); [10:34](#); [29:17](#); [33:9](#)). • glory . . . splendor of our God: See also [6:3](#); [40:5](#).

Isaiah 35:3

Tired hands and weak knees express discouragement and anxiety (see [Heb 12:12](#)).

Isaiah 35:4

do not fear: The Lord here assures his people of his presence and purpose (see also [7:4](#); [10:24](#); [40:9](#); [43:1](#); [44:2](#); [54:4](#)). • The essence of the good news is that God is coming to save his people (see also [40:9](#); [52:7](#); [62:11](#)). God's coming brings spiritual transformation as well as rescue from enemies.

Isaiah 35:5

eyes . . . ears: There will be a transformation from spiritual blindness and deafness to understanding and knowing God ([6:10](#); [29:18](#); [32:3](#); [42:7](#); see also [Luke 7:22](#); [Acts 26:18](#)).

Isaiah 35:6

The lame . . . those who cannot speak: All disabilities will be removed (see [Matt 11:5](#); [12:22](#); [Mark 7:37](#); [Acts 3:7-8](#)).

Isaiah 35:8

The imagery of the great road recalls Israel's crossing through the Red Sea ([51:10](#)). • Only holy and undefiled people will share the Highway of Holiness. God's goal in salvation is that humans will share in his character and act as he does (see [Eph 5:1-2](#); [1 Pet 2:21](#)).

Isaiah 35:10

Jerusalem: The prophecy extends beyond the return of Israel from exile to the final establishment of God's kingdom on earth. It will be

characterized by joy and gladness and the absence of sorrow and mourning (see also [25:7](#); [51:11](#); [Rev 21:4](#)).

Isaiah 36:1

King Sennacherib of Assyria ruled from 705–681 BC. Hezekiah, like many other kings under Assyrian vassalage, had reasserted his independence when Sennacherib came to the throne in troubled circumstances. By 701 BC, the Assyrian king was ready to punish Hezekiah. Sennacherib recorded having conquered forty-six fortified cities and many villages, and having taken 200,146 captives. Hezekiah responded by attempting to appease Sennacherib (see [2 Kgs 18:14–16](#)), but it was too late.

Isaiah 36:1–39:8

Jerusalem's rescue from King Sennacherib of Assyria is a focal point of chs [1–39](#). The Lord promised to rescue his people by remaining present with Jerusalem (see [7:14](#)) and by maintaining a remnant (see study note on [10:20](#)). Even though much of the country was desolate and the population decimated because of their foolish alliance with Assyria (chs [7–8](#)), the Lord preserved his people from total conquest through Hezekiah, a godly king. Hezekiah faced the same test that Ahaz did, a test of trust (note the recurrence of words for *trust* in the Assyrian officer's challenge in ch [36](#)). But Hezekiah has learned the lessons taught in chs [13–35](#) and, at least initially, he passed the test. This narrative is duplicated in [2 Kgs 18:13–20:19](#).

Isaiah 36:2

Lachish was a city overlooking the low-lying hills to the west of Jerusalem. It had to be taken before the final attack on Jerusalem could be launched. • the aqueduct that feeds water into the upper pool: This was a pool on the north side of Jerusalem, not the Gihon Spring in the Kidron valley. • Isaiah had met Ahaz on this same road leading to the field where cloth is washed some thirty-three years earlier (see [Isa 7:3](#)). At that time he had challenged Ahaz to trust God. However, Ahaz trusted Assyria instead, and this desperate situation was a result. Now the challenge to trust God came from mocking, foreign lips (see [28:11–13](#)).

Isaiah 36:3

Eliakim eventually advanced in rank, while Shebna was demoted (see [22:15–24](#)).

Isaiah 36:4

Great king is a title similar to *emperor*.

Isaiah 36:4–22

The Assyrian chief of staff attempted to use intimidation to negotiate a settlement without bloodshed. In his first speech ([36:4–10](#)), he rightly argued against Egypt's ability to rescue but wrongly charged Hezekiah with misplaced trust in the Lord. Strikingly, the Assyrian did not see the contest as being between the gods of Assyria and the Lord but rather between Sennacherib—the great king—and the Lord.

Isaiah 36:5

Who are you counting on: Judah had asked Egypt to help them (see [30:1–5](#)).

Isaiah 36:6

Egypt... is completely unreliable: Isaiah argued the same case, pointing to the Lord as the only reliable source of help ([31:1–3](#), [7](#); [39:7](#)). • A kind of reed that breaks easily grows near the Nile (see [Ezek 29:6–7](#)).

Isaiah 36:7

We are trusting in the Lord our God: Ironically, the Assyrian chief of staff knew about and played on Isaiah's message ([26:4](#); [36:15](#); [37:10](#)). • Hezekiah showed his zeal for the Lord by tearing down the pagan shrines and altars ([2 Kgs 18:4](#)), but the Assyrians mistakenly thought Hezekiah had angered God in the process.

Isaiah 36:8

At this time, cavalry mounted on horses was the newest military technology. The Assyrian chief of staff was mocking the Judeans because he knew that Judah had no trained men who knew how to ride.

Isaiah 36:10

The Lord himself told us: It was common for a king to claim the approval of a deity in destroying other kingdoms. This claim was consistent with Isaiah's prophecy in [10:5-6](#).

Isaiah 36:11

Aramaic was the lingua franca used throughout the Assyrian Empire, understood by the elite but not by the common people of Judah.

Isaiah 36:13-20

In the Assyrian chief of staff's second speech, he claimed that his nation's gods were more powerful than the God of Judah (cp. [10:9-10](#)). God's ability to rescue his people was at stake. In the ensuing drama, the Lord shocked the Assyrian with his power ([37:36-37](#)).

Isaiah 36:14

Don't let Hezekiah deceive you: This public accusation against Hezekiah was intended to undermine the people's confidence in him.

Isaiah 36:15

Hezekiah demonstrated a strong faith in the Lord, unlike Ahaz (ch [7](#)). Hezekiah's faith would bring rescue, whereas Ahaz's lack of faith brought him trouble (see [7:9](#)).

Isaiah 36:16-17

The Assyrian was tempting the people of Jerusalem with provisions that the Lord had promised to provide his obedient people (see [1:19](#); [37:30-35](#);

[Deut 8:7-9](#)). It was a tempting offer, but a counterfeit. And it covered up the reality of exile that would have followed ([Isa 36:17](#)).

Isaiah 36:19

The populations of Hamath and Arpad had been relocated to Samaria, where the new local deities were the gods of Sepharvaim ([2 Kgs 17:24](#)). The logic of the argument made sense to an Assyrian. If the Assyrian gods defeated all the gods of the other nations and the God of the Israelite nation of Samaria, would they not also defeat the God of Judah?

Isaiah 37:1

Hezekiah responded to the threats by seeking the Lord's favor. • The king tore his clothes and put on burlap as a sign of mourning and prayer.

Isaiah 37:4

perhaps . . . God has heard the Assyrian chief of staff . . . defy the living God: Hezekiah's hope was not based on Judah's or his own goodness, or the presence of the Temple in Jerusalem; instead, it was based on God responding to Assyria's blasphemy.

Isaiah 37:5-7

God answered that he would deal with the Assyrians and rescue the remnant of his people from their distress (see [63:9](#)).

Isaiah 37:8

Libnah was a city on the Philistine plain near Lachish. Sennacherib was preparing to fight both Egypt and Jerusalem when he sent word to Hezekiah.

Isaiah 37:9

King Tirhakah of Ethiopia was then the ruler of Egypt.

Isaiah 37:12

The argument was that Judah's god, like the gods of other nations already conquered by Assyria, would be unable to save Judah (see also [36:18-20](#)). • Gozan, Haran, Rezeph, . . . Eden, and Tel-assar were cities in Mesopotamia.

Isaiah 37:14-20

When he received Sennacherib's boastful threat, Hezekiah returned to the Temple and prayed for rescue. His prayer stands in contrast to Ahaz's response to danger decades earlier (see ch [7](#)).

Isaiah 37:16

God of Israel: Hezekiah was not taken in by the false claims of Sennacherib that the Lord was powerless. In his prayer, Hezekiah acknowledged that, because the Lord is the Creator, he is God of all the kingdoms of the earth. The Lord is sovereign over all kingdoms. • The mighty cherubim were located in the Temple atop the Ark of the Covenant, which was God's throne in his Temple (see study note on Lev 16:2; see also [Pss 80:1](#); [99:1](#)).

Isaiah 37:20

you alone, O Lord, are God: Hezekiah was concerned for the Lord's reputation, which Sennacherib had impugned. Hezekiah recognized that if the Lord defeated the Assyrians and their gods, his holy name would be glorified among all the nations of the world (cp. [Exod 9:16](#); [14:4](#), [17-18](#); [Josh 2:9-11](#); [1 Sam 4:7-8](#)).

Isaiah 37:21

Because you prayed: Prayer is powerful; it moved God's heart and was part of the reason why the Lord answered with this message of hope.

Isaiah 37:22

The virgin daughter of Zion: Jerusalem is personified as a young woman who mocks the Assyrian king (see also [3:26](#)).

Isaiah 37:23

Whom . . . Against whom: Sennacherib's speech was not so much an insult against Judah as it was against the Lord.

Isaiah 37:24

Isaiah seems to be familiar with the typical royal Assyrian boasts, including that they possessed the highest mountains. These words sound very much like those found in the annals of the Assyrian kings inscribed on the walls of their temples.

Isaiah 37:25

I have dug wells . . . I stopped up all the rivers of Egypt: Sennacherib's boasts demonstrate his attitude of independence. However, the Lord alone is sovereign over nature ([42:15](#); [43:19](#); [44:27](#)).

Isaiah 37:26

I planned for you to crush . . . into heaps of rubble: Assyria was God's agent of destruction, but the Assyrians did not realize that they were only a tool in God's hand (see ch [10](#)), fulfilling what God had planned long before ([14:24-27](#)).

Isaiah 37:28

you have raged against me: Assyria was utterly hostile to the Lord, which brought them even greater condemnation.

Isaiah 37:29

my hook . . . my bit: The Assyrians would be led away like animals, just as they had led so many of their captives away.

Isaiah 37:30

This year . . . next year . . . the third year: Because of the Assyrian siege and its destruction of agriculture, the people of Judah would not be able to plant and harvest as usual. The promise that life would resume after the siege assured them that God was with them and would provide as they carried out their everyday activities. They needed to develop their trust in God over a period of three calendar years in the confident expectation that God's word would be true (cp. [30:15](#), [18](#)). Perhaps the point was that after rescue from the Assyrians, it would be too late in the present year for fall planting. They would have to wait until fall in the second year to plant again, and they would reap their first crop in the spring and summer of the third year.

Isaiah 37:30-35

In this prophecy of salvation, Isaiah assured Hezekiah that Jerusalem would be spared and that the remnant was under God's protection. The names of Isaiah and his sons anticipated God's rescue (see [7:1-11:16](#)). The book's record of God's presence and rescue provided assurance that the Lord would always have a remnant that he will protect and rescue.

Isaiah 37:32

The passionate commitment of God includes his energetic zeal to keep his promise, the best guarantee his people could ever have (see also [9:7](#)).

Isaiah 37:33

armies . . . arrow . . . shields . . . banks of earth: Despite their advanced military technology and great power, the Assyrians would not succeed against Jerusalem.

Isaiah 37:35

for the sake of my servant David: God had promised David a perpetual dynasty (see [9:6-7](#); [2 Sam 7:8-17](#)).

Isaiah 37:36

The angel of the Lord was a special heavenly agent through whom God worked on earth. Often his role was to communicate special messages (see [Gen 16:7-14](#)), but sometimes he brought judgment (see [2 Sam 24:16](#)). • killed 185,000 Assyrian soldiers: The Lord began to fulfill what he had repeatedly promised—rescue of Jerusalem and judgment of Assyria (see [Isa 10:16](#), [33-34](#); [30:31](#); [31:8](#)).

Isaiah 37:38

One day: Sennacherib was probably killed in 681 BC, about twenty years after his withdrawal from Jerusalem. • Esarhaddon was king of Assyria from 680-669 BC. It is ironic that Sennacherib, who mocked the Lord, was killed by his sons in the temple of his god.

Isaiah 38:1

About that time (literally *in those days*): This is a very general time statement. Hezekiah's illness and subsequent healing probably preceded Jerusalem's rescue (chs [36-37](#)), even though Isaiah places it afterward. Merodach-baladan's reign in Babylon ([39:1](#)) ended before Sennacherib's invasion in 701 BC. The order in the text indicates a connection between these two events (see [38:6](#)).

Isaiah 38:1-9

The story of Hezekiah's healing connects Hezekiah's extension of life with Jerusalem's relief from the Assyrians. The events of this story took place before Jerusalem's rescue from the Assyrians but were placed in a thematic rather than chronological order. One theme is the importance of prayer (see [37:14-20](#); [38:2-3](#)). The Lord does listen! Hezekiah had learned the lesson of trust that his father, Ahaz, refused. As a result, Judah and Jerusalem were spared total destruction by the Assyrians. Yet Hezekiah was not the Messiah, the Son of David promised in [7:14](#); [9:1-7](#); [11:1-16](#); [16:5](#); [32:1](#), and [33:17-22](#). Thus, these accounts of his failure and mortality (chs [38-39](#)) prepare the reader for the revelation of the true Messiah that follows (chs [40-66](#)).

Isaiah 38:3

I have always been faithful to you: Hezekiah's heart was right with the Lord for most of his reign ([2 Kgs 18:1-5](#)), although his dependence on Egypt was a time of weakness when he did not act faithfully ([Isa 31:1-9](#)).

Isaiah 38:5

the God of your ancestor David: Hezekiah faithfully walked in David's footsteps (see [37:35](#); [38:1-22](#)).

Isaiah 38:6

I will rescue you . . . I will defend this city: This promise refers to the rescue of Jerusalem (chs [36-37](#)); it also provides a greater context for understanding Hezekiah's sickness and healing. Just as Hezekiah received another fifteen years, Jerusalem also received a temporary reprieve (see ch [39](#)).

Isaiah 38:9-20

Hezekiah's poem contains both lament ([38:9-14](#)) and praise ([38:15-20](#)), although the praise is distinctly muted until the final verse.

Isaiah 38:10

enter the place of the dead? (literally *enter the gates of Sheol*?): This image comes from an ancient idea that people enter death through gates (see [14:9](#)). Old Testament believers did not understand the afterlife as the New Testament reveals it. It was a shadowy place where all the dead were together and where no praise of God existed (see [38:18](#); [Pss 88:10](#); [115:17](#)).

Isaiah 38:11

Hezekiah lamented that if he died, he would not enjoy fellowship with God, his family, and his friends.

Isaiah 38:12

These images depicted the brevity of life (cp. [2 Cor 5:1](#)).

Isaiah 38:15

I will walk humbly: Hezekiah might have previously taken his life and good health for granted. Now he recognized that these gifts from the Lord can be withdrawn at any time.

Isaiah 38:16

God's restoration of Hezekiah's health also symbolized the restoration from exile that Judah would experience in the future.

Isaiah 38:21-22

Hezekiah received a sign, reminiscent of another sign the prophet had offered Ahaz ([7:11](#)). Ahaz and Hezekiah were two bookends to a long story. Ahaz represented the ungodly king and Hezekiah the godly king. The former brought disaster on his people, while the latter rescued his people (but see ch [39](#)).

Isaiah 38:22

Hezekiah could not go to the Temple with an infection (see [Lev 13](#)), so going to the Temple signifies restored health.

Isaiah 39:1

Merodach-baladan, the king of Babylon (722-710 and 704-703 BC), planned to rebel against Assyria and sought help from Hezekiah. His envoys visited after Hezekiah had been very sick and had recovered but before Sennacherib's final attack in 701 BC.

Isaiah 39:1-8

Hezekiah was exemplary in godliness, prayer, and care for the people of Jerusalem. But he failed the

Lord by parading his financial and military strength before the envoys from Babylon.

Isaiah 39:2

silver . . . aromatic oils . . . his armory: Showing these treasures demonstrated to Babylon's envoys that Hezekiah had the resources to be a worthy ally.

Isaiah 39:6-7

carried off to Babylon: This prophecy was given before the prophecy of the rescue of Jerusalem ([37:35](#)). Although this pronouncement of judgment and exile comes as a surprise ending to the story of Hezekiah, the exile of both Israel and Judah had been in the background from the beginning ([10:3-4](#), [20-23](#)). The Lord had promised that he would spare Judah and Jerusalem when the Assyrians attacked in 701 BC, but he had clearly revealed to Isaiah that worse things would come if they did not change their ways. God had demonstrated the truth of his sovereignty and trustworthiness in his defeat of the Assyrians, but that did not mean the people had changed. The only way the promises of [2:1-5](#) and [4:2-6](#) were going to be realized was through the fires of judgment ([4:4](#)). Until the burning coal of exile was applied to the nation's unclean lips ([6:5-7](#)), their mission to the nations would fail.

Isaiah 40:1-31

This chapter introduces chs [40-66](#). In this section, comfort refers to the result of God's merciful way of dealing with people in the age to come. It includes encouragement, strength, and acceptance. God wants to rescue his people ([40:1-11](#)) and is more than able to do so ([40:12-26](#)). The exiles needed to believe God's promises and wait on him for their rescue ([40:27-31](#); see also [30:15-18](#)).

Isaiah 40:1-55.13

This section announces the good news of God's coming salvation. The Lord is coming to vindicate his own and to judge his enemies. Salvation would be accomplished through the arrival, suffering, and exaltation of the Lord's servant—the Messiah, Jesus Christ.

Isaiah 40:1-66.24

The rest of Isaiah provides a message of comfort and a revelation of God's character and his purposes for Israel. As [39:6-7](#) predicted, Judah would experience judgment and exile after the time of Isaiah. Throughout chs [40-66](#), Isaiah prophesied from the vantage point of the Exile having already become a reality. Therefore, the Babylonian exile provides the background for understanding these chapters.

Isaiah 40:2

Speak tenderly: The prophet's message was to encourage Jerusalem with the good news of God's forgiveness, reconciliation, and restoration. • From the prophetic perspective, Israel's sad days are gone because the Exile is over. • punished her twice over for all her sins: Israel experienced the full brunt of God's wrath ([51:19-23](#); cp. [61:7](#)).

Isaiah 40:3

the voice of someone shouting: In [Mal 3:1](#) this person (possibly the Elijah of [Mal 4:5](#)) was God's messenger who prepared the way for God's coming. In the Gospels, this announcer was identified with John the Baptist ([Matt 3:3](#); [Mark 1:3](#); [Luke 3:4](#); [John 1:23](#)). • Clear the way . . . Make a straight highway: The announcer's message would expedite God's coming (see [Isa 35:8](#)). As God made a way for Israel through the Red Sea ([43:16](#)), so a way would be opened up for the Lord (see [52:11-12](#)).

Isaiah 40:3-5

There is now a shift from the general announcement of the good news to the specific expectation of God's coming. The good news ([40:1-2](#)) is grounded in God himself. Isaiah portrayed the Lord as coming on a highway through the desert (see ch [35](#)), although the imagery is here reversed: In ch [35](#), the people were traveling to Zion, toward the Lord. Here, the Lord is coming toward his people (see also [52:8](#), where the two images are brought together).

Isaiah 40:5

The future revelation of God's glory would include the return of Judah from exile but would also go beyond it. The New Testament confirmed that the revelation of God's glory came in Jesus Christ ([John 1:14](#); [Heb 1:3](#)). • The Lord has spoken: The coming salvation and judgment would certainly occur because the Lord, who keeps his word, had declared it (see [Isa 1:20](#); [58:14](#)).

Isaiah 40:6

Shout: So that all can hear. • People are not worthy of the revelation of God's glory because they are mortal.

Isaiah 40:6–8

All humanity is mortal and fleeting. By contrast, God persists in his plans and succeeds. Time does not limit him from carrying out his will (see [14:24](#)).

Isaiah 40:7

The breath of the Lord refers to God's spoken words of judgment (see [4:4](#)).

Isaiah 40:8

the word of our God stands forever: All of God's words (his plans as well as the written word) will succeed. God might frustrate human expectations, but everything will happen according to his wise plan (see [14:24](#); [55:8–11](#); see also [Matt 25:34](#)).

Isaiah 40:9

God is coming to save and restore human beings (see also [35:4](#); [Rev 22:12](#)).

Isaiah 40:9–11

God is the good news. Although he comes like a warrior to rescue his people with power, he also holds them tenderly as a shepherd.

Isaiah 40:10

The Lord's rule is not like that of the unjust and powerless rulers whom he will judge. It is compassionate, just, righteous, and powerful. • with a powerful arm: God manifested his power in events such as the defeat of the Egyptians ([63:12](#)), the judgment of his enemies ([30:30](#); [48:14](#); [51:9](#)), and the rescue of his people ([59:16](#)).

Isaiah 40:11

Isaiah used the familiar biblical metaphor of a shepherd to speak of God's care for his people (see also [49:10](#); [Ps 23:1](#); [Jer 3:15](#); [23:4](#); [Ezek 34:11–17](#); [Matt 2:6](#); [John 10:1–18](#)).

Isaiah 40:12–13

These rhetorical questions evoke the answer "No one!" God alone created all that exists. He will judge creation ([24:17](#)), and he alone can and will restore creation through his salvation.

Isaiah 40:12–17

Against the backdrop of Israel's questions (spoken by the prophet), the Lord affirmed that he is the incomparable God, a wise and sovereign creator who rules over the nations.

Isaiah 40:15

God is sovereign over all the nations of the world and over their human power structures. In comparison to God, they are almost nothing. This included the Babylonian Empire, which was merely a tool in God's hand. • whole earth: Literally *coastlands or islands*.

Isaiah 40:16

Lebanon was prized for its abundance of wood and its wildlife (see [2:13–16](#); [Ps 104:16–17](#)).

Isaiah 40:17

The nations, including their leaders ([40:23](#)), pagan structures ([41:24, 29](#); [44:9-11](#)), and all enemies of God's people ([41:11-12](#)), are worth nothing apart from God.

Isaiah 40:18

To whom . . . What image: Earlier in the book, idolatry was shown to be ridiculous ([16:12](#); [37:16-19](#)). Chapters [40-48](#) open up a much more extensive argument against idolatry. Idols are symbolic representations of gods and, at times, other religious concepts. Those who worship them don't recognize the implication that they are man-made trinkets. Idols are powerless ([41:7, 22-24](#); [48:14](#)), give a false sense of security ([42:17](#)), delude people ([44:20](#)), and lead to severe disappointment ([42:17](#); [45:16, 20](#)). They cannot help those who care for them. In fact, they are so weak that they fall down ([40:20](#); [41:7](#)). In the end, idols compete for God's glory ([42:8](#)) and take away human dignity ([44:9](#); see also [41:21-29](#)). • The Lord, the true God, is incomparable (see [40:25](#); [46:5](#); [Pss 86:8](#); [89:6](#)); no one could resemble him.

Isaiah 40:20

image that won't fall down: This is a sarcastic remark; it would be embarrassing if the idol did not even have the power to remain standing (see [40:18](#); [41:7](#); [1 Sam 5:4](#)).

Isaiah 40:21

Idolaters fail to discern who God is or to respond wisely to him. The godly in Israel would understand and see the hand of God in the unfolding story of redemption, which includes both exile and restoration ([41:20](#)).

Isaiah 40:22

God sits enthroned as King over all the earth (see [6:1](#); [Pss 2:4](#); [80:1](#); [99:1](#); [102:12](#); [113:5](#)). God is so immense and awesome that humans are like grasshoppers in comparison. • Belief in God as creator of the heavens and earth contradicts the popular Babylonian and Egyptian belief that the

sun, moon, and stars represent gods. • like a curtain . . . his tent: See also [Ps 104:2](#).

Isaiah 40:23

great people: God is unimpressed by human power and fame.

Isaiah 40:25

The Holy One is a shortened form of "the Holy One of Israel," a common designation for God in Isaiah (see also [10:17](#); [43:15](#); [Ps 22:3](#)).

Isaiah 40:26

Look up into the heavens: Just as God directed Abraham to look into the sky ([Gen 15:5](#)), he also directed Israel to look to the stars for encouragement (see also [Isa 51:2-3](#)). The cosmos bears witness to God's great power and incomparable strength. The Strong One is able to strengthen the weak ([40:27-31](#); see [Ps 147:5](#)).

Isaiah 40:27

does not see your troubles . . . ignores your rights: The coming exile, a period when God's powerful presence and rescue would not be seen, would prompt questions (see also [49:14](#); [54:7](#); [Lam 5:20-22](#)).

Isaiah 40:28

heard . . . understood: Cp. [40:21](#). • the everlasting God, the Creator of all the earth: Creation reveals God's power and wisdom. He is also the Creator of the age to come, a world of righteousness, justice, and peace ([45:8](#); [48:6-7](#); [65:17-18](#)). • He never grows weak or weary: God is not susceptible to human limitations.

Isaiah 40:29

The weak in this context are those who face persecution or oppression (such as the Babylonian

exile); the Lord is their only recourse (see [49:4–5](#); [50:4](#); [Pss 68:9](#); [119:28](#)).

Isaiah 40:31

trust in the Lord: See [33:2](#); [49:23](#); [51:5](#). • like eagles: This powerful image of rescue reminded readers of the Exodus event of long ago ([Exod 19:4](#); [Deut 32:10–12](#); see also [Ps 103:5](#)).

Isaiah 41:1

The nations coming together for a trial have to listen in silence to the presentation of God's arguments. • Bring your strongest arguments: Literally *let them find new strength*, a play on [40:31](#). • God invited the nations to come . . . and speak, challenging them to refute his case.

Isaiah 41:1–7

The Lord here invited the nations to a trial where he would prove that he alone is God. They were defenseless as he declared that a king from the east ([41:2](#)) would crush Babylon, opening the way for Israel to return.

Isaiah 41:2

This king from the east was Cyrus, the Persian king who conquered Babylon in 539 BC and permitted the Jews to return to their land and rebuild Jerusalem (538 BC; [Ezra 1:1–4](#)). Isaiah's prophecies about Cyrus (see [Isa 44:28–45:13](#); [48:14–15](#)) encouraged Israel to look to the Lord as sovereign over all of human history, including the actions of great kings. • Who gives this man victory over many nations? As victorious as the conquering Cyrus was, he was still subject to the Lord.

Isaiah 41:4

each new generation from the beginning of time: God is sovereign over all things. From the beginning he has unfolded each stage of history according to his plan. • In the book of Revelation, Jesus identifies himself as the Alpha and the Omega, the First and the Last, the Beginning and the End ([Rev 1:8](#), [17](#); [2:8](#); [21:6](#); [22:13](#)). • I alone am he: The

Lord alone is God (see also [Isa 43:10](#), [13](#); [46:4](#); [48:12](#); [Deut 32:39](#)). Jesus used similar expressions for himself (see [John 6:35](#); [8:12](#), [24](#); [9:5](#); [10:7](#), [9](#), [11](#), [14](#); [11:25](#); [14:6](#); [15:1](#), [5](#)).

Isaiah 41:5–7

This taunt against idolatry was a response to God's raising up of Cyrus; the nations hope to find protection in their idols.

Isaiah 41:6

Be strong! The nations put their hope in things that have no strength, objects made by human craftsmen.

Isaiah 41:8

The servant—here the nation of Israel—was God's chosen one, whose calling was grounded in God's purposes. • Abraham my friend: The phrase in Hebrew could mean *Abraham who loves me* or *Abraham whom I love*. See also [Jas 2:23](#).

Isaiah 41:8–16

These two prophecies of salvation for God's servant Israel ([41:8–13](#), [14–16](#)) prepare for the first of the suffering servant songs (see study note on [42:1–4](#)).

Isaiah 41:9

I have chosen you restates [41:8](#) to emphasize God's commitment and faithfulness to his people Israel, who had not been faithful to him. • not throw you away: Because of the Exile, the people felt that God had rejected them (see [49:21](#); [54:6](#)). However, God had good purposes for them.

Isaiah 41:10

I am with you: The promise of God's presence (see [7:14](#)) is central to the Bible. Because God is present, his people do not need to fear (see also [43:1–2](#), [5](#)). • I am your God: The Lord used the language of the

covenant to affirm that he is their God and that they are his people (see also [Jer 7:23](#); [31:1](#), [33](#); [Ezek 14:11](#); [36:28](#); [37:27](#); [Zech 8:8](#)). • hold you . . . my victorious right hand: The Lord used language reminiscent of the Exodus (cp. [Exod 15:6](#)) to encourage Israel (see also [Isa 41:13](#); [63:12](#)).

Isaiah 41:14

In exile, Israel was in a lowly state. • God is the Redeemer. He works mightily to rescue and restore people from sin and its consequences (for Israel, the Exile; for application to Jesus, see [Luke 2:38](#); [21:28](#); [Rom 3:24](#); [1 Cor 1:30](#); [Gal 4:5](#); [Eph 1:1-14](#); [Titus 2:14](#); [Heb 9:12](#)).

Isaiah 41:16

When the grain is thrown into the wind, the chaff is blown away. Likewise, Israel's enemies appeared to be strong but would easily be driven off.

Isaiah 41:18

rivers . . . fountains . . . pools of water . . . springs: These images would strike a responsive chord in an agrarian culture. They also suggest that rescue from the Exile would be a second exodus (cp. [Exod 15:27](#); [17:6](#)).

Isaiah 41:21

the King of Israel: See [6:5](#); [43:15](#); [44:6](#).

Isaiah 41:21-29

This trial scene develops the Lord's case against idolatry. Idols are nothing but a human creation, whereas God is the Creator of all things. Idols cannot speak, act, accomplish anything, or save their worshipers.

Isaiah 41:25

I have stirred up a leader: The God who had planned the Exile through Babylon had already planned for Israel's restoration from exile through

Cyrus (see [41:2](#); see also [13:17](#)). • Although Persia is located to the east, rough terrain required those traveling to Israel and Judah to enter from the north. • I will give him victory . . . He will trample them: As Babylon was sent to trample Assyria, so Persia would trample Babylon.

Isaiah 41:26

Idols and false gods could not predict the future.

Isaiah 41:27

The messenger with good news told of God's coming to rescue his people (see [40:9](#)).

Isaiah 42:1

who pleases me: God used similar language at Jesus' baptism ([Matt 3:17](#)). • I have put my Spirit upon him: Any leader might be called a servant, but the presence of the Spirit suggests a king of David's line or a prophet like Moses (see [Num 11:17](#), [24-29](#)). • Establishing justice is the responsibility of a king (see [Isa 9:6-7](#); [Ps 72:1](#)). • This king's mission will be a greater mission to the nations than simply governing the small nation of Judah.

Isaiah 42:1-4

The servant here is not the people Israel (as in [41:8-28](#) and elsewhere in chs [41-48](#); see [49:5-6](#)) but is a royal figure who accomplishes his mission with care for people, especially for those who are hurting. The passage is the first of four songs about this servant ([42:1-4](#); [49:1-13](#); [50:4-11](#); [52:13-53:12](#)). He brings in an era of universal justice. For the connection of the servant with Jesus Christ, see [Matt 12:18-21](#).

Isaiah 42:2

shout or raise his voice: The royal servant will have calm confidence in his message and calling from God (see also [11:1-5](#)).

Isaiah 42:3

The royal servant will be gentle with the oppressed and discouraged (see [3:15](#); [41:17](#)).

Isaiah 42:4

distant lands: The nations long for justice and for instruction on bringing it about. In this regard the servant is like Moses, to whom the law was given. However, the servant is greater in that he extends justice beyond Israel to all the nations.

Isaiah 42:6

my people, Israel . . . my covenant with them (literally *a covenant for the people*): It is also possible that “the people” referred to all the peoples/nations of the earth (see [49:6](#)). • light to guide the nations: See also [51:4](#); [Acts 13:47](#).

Isaiah 42:7

The servant will open the eyes of the spiritually blind (see [6:10](#); [29:18](#)) and free the spiritual captives from the prison of sin, in addition to those who were captive in the Babylonian exile (see [61:1](#) with [Luke 4:18](#)).

Isaiah 42:8–9

I am the Lord: As Creator of the world, and as the only one who can bring about the things he predicts, the Lord alone is glorious and worthy of praise.

Isaiah 42:10–11

The various geographical regions represent the extremes of human habitation. The whole earth is called to praise God for his commitment to redeem humanity. • Kedar and Sela ([42:11](#); see also [16:1](#); [21:16–17](#)) were representative desert sites.

Isaiah 42:13

a mighty hero . . . a warrior: The background of this theme is God’s victory at the Red Sea during the

Exodus ([Exod 15:3](#)). • God will be victorious over all his enemies in order to rescue his people ([Isa 51:9](#); [63:1–6](#); see also [Pss 54:7](#); [108:9](#); [112:8](#)).

Isaiah 42:14

I have long been silent . . . restrained myself: Israel had experienced God’s absence in the Exile, which came about because of their idolatrous ways ([57:11–13](#); [2 Kgs 17:6–24](#)). The godly will pray for God’s presence and renewed involvement in their situation ([Isa 64:12](#)), and the Lord will answer their prayers because of his commitment to their redemption ([62:1](#), [6](#)).

Isaiah 42:18–20

The Israelites who refused to listen to what God said and to understand what they saw God doing in history were rendered spiritually blind and deaf (see [6:9–10](#)). They had knowledge of the truth through God’s word and the prophets, but their closed minds refused to act upon it.

Isaiah 42:21

exalted his glorious law: God’s word is a witness to his righteous rule (see [1:10](#)).

Isaiah 42:22–25

Throughout its history, Israel’s sin ([42:24](#)) made Israel fair game for foreign oppressors. Many nations, Assyria and Babylon in particular, became instruments God used to pour out his fury ([42:25](#)) on his rebellious people.

Isaiah 42:25

Generation after generation of Israelites did not learn their lesson, even when God disciplined them through military defeat.

Isaiah 43:1

the Lord who created you: The language of creation (see study note on [40:28](#)) was now applied to God’s

formation of the nation Israel. • I have ransomed you: At the Exodus, when God brought his people out of bondage. Similarly, God planned to bring his people out of exile and back into their land. Ultimately, Jesus gave his life as a ransom for all humanity ([Matt 20:28](#); [1 Tim 2:6](#); [Heb 9:15](#)) • I have called you by name; you are mine: Despite having faced his wrath, the people of Israel are still God's chosen people.

Isaiah 43:1-7

In this promise of salvation, the Lord addressed his plundered people in the first person.

Isaiah 43:2

Conquering forces could be compared to flooding rivers (see [8:8](#)). • I will be with you: God is committed to being with his people to protect and care for them (see [7:14](#); [41:10](#); [43:5](#); [45:14](#)). • Israel experienced God's judgment as the fire of oppression during the Exile.

Isaiah 43:7

One of God's purposes in restoring his people was to display his glory to the watching world.

Isaiah 43:8-13

The Lord here called on Israel, his blind servant, to be his star witness in a mock trial against idols and false gods. Israel knew that the Lord alone is God, and the people had experienced his salvation.

Isaiah 43:10

you are my witnesses: By their very presence in exile, Israel was evidence that God is truly God. He predicted the Exile long beforehand, and now it had come to pass. God alone is the true God because he speaks and acts and controls all of history. Idols and false gods could do none of these things. Israel would later become even greater evidence because God had also predicted their redemption ([43:11-12](#)).

Isaiah 43:14-21

The Lord assured Israel of its coming redemption from Babylon; the redemption would be modeled on Israel's past redemption from Egypt and would be greater in some ways ([43:18](#)).

Isaiah 43:18

God did not want the Israelites to forget the exodus from Egypt. However, they needed to look forward in faith to the spectacular event that was about to occur rather than dwelling on the past.

Isaiah 43:21

One purpose of redemption is to honor God through the praises of the redeemed (see [1 Pet 2:9](#)).

Isaiah 43:22

Israel's history of rebellion had led them into crisis after crisis, yet their rebellion was so great that they stubbornly refused to ask God for help. When they did pray, their wickedness often caused their prayers not to be heard ([1:15](#)).

Isaiah 43:25

God alone can and does blot out . . . sins, no matter how many or how great (see also [44:22](#)).

Isaiah 43:27

leaders: God held Israel's and Judah's kings especially responsible for leading the nation into sin (see [2 Kgs 21](#)).

Isaiah 44:1-5

The promise of salvation extended the usefulness of sinful Israel to another generation ([44:3](#)). The past was bleak (see [43:22-28](#)), but the future would be a glorious new era transformed by the Spirit.

Isaiah 44:3

The restoration theme is connected with God's promise to pour out the Spirit (see also [32:15-17](#); [Joel 2:28-32](#); [Acts 2:16-18](#)). • on your descendants . . . children: The next generation of Israelites offered hope.

Isaiah 44:6-20

This passage uses the form of a trial speech to press God's argument that disgrace comes to all who trust in idols and false gods.

Isaiah 44:15-17

he uses part of the wood to make a fire . . . he takes the rest of it and makes himself a god to worship: This description of the process of making an idol drips with sarcasm and ridicule at the stupidity of the foolish idol worshipers (see also [44:19](#)).

Isaiah 44:18-19

Their minds are shut: Idol worshipers cannot see the irony in using one part of a log to warm themselves and another part of the same log to be their god.

Isaiah 44:21-22

The Lord promised to forgive Israel's sins.

Isaiah 44:23

All creation is called to celebrate God's redemption of Israel (cp. [1:2](#)).

Isaiah 44:24-45.8

The Lord alone is sovereign over history. He raised up Cyrus of Persia to execute judgment on Babylon and restore Israel to the Holy Land.

Isaiah 44:25

False prophets and fortune-tellers used forbidden forms of divination to try to predict the future. Eventually God would expose them as deluded liars (see [3:2](#); [9:15](#); [47:13](#); [Deut 18:10-11](#)).

Isaiah 44:27

The sudden depletion of natural resources at times indicates a divine judgment (see [42:15](#); cp. [43:20](#)). Here, however, God's ability to dry up streams with just a word illustrates his power to do what he said he would do through Cyrus of Persia.

Isaiah 44:28

He is my shepherd: Cyrus went beyond simply permitting the Jews to return to their homeland. He facilitated a major restoration project to rebuild Jerusalem and restore the Temple (see [45:13](#); [Ezra 1:2-4](#); [6:3-5](#)).

Isaiah 45:1

anointed one: This designation, commonly reserved for David or the Messiah, is here applied to Cyrus. Cyrus was anointed in the sense that he was selected to fulfill a special mission. This title was never used of any other foreign ruler (cp. [1 Sam 10:1](#); [Rom 13:1](#)). • whose right hand he will empower: The Lord would give Cyrus victory over Babylon (see [Isa 43:14](#)).

Isaiah 45:3

so you may know: Cyrus's victories provided factual proof that the Lord has the power to fulfill his plans, whereas idols and false gods do not (see [41:21-29](#)).

Isaiah 45:4-5

I call you by name: Cyrus did not know the Lord, but the Lord knew him. Isaiah predicted the rescuer Cyrus by name 150 years in advance. This prophecy would prove to the exiles that the Lord is indeed God and that he knows the future.

Isaiah 45:7

light . . . darkness . . . good times and bad times:
Everything is under God's control.

Isaiah 45:9-11

pot . . . its maker . . . baby . . . its father: It is ridiculous
for a creature to question the wisdom of its creator.

Isaiah 45:9-13

The Lord confronts those who question his right to
use a pagan king to achieve his purposes. He, the
Creator, is free and sovereign in his activities. He
promised to bring his people back to their land, and
he would use anyone he chose to accomplish that
purpose.

Isaiah 45:14

Egyptians . . . Ethiopians . . . Sabeans: Israel's
restoration would bring them a new sovereignty.
Foreign nations would honor God, and because
they recognized God's special blessing on his
people, they would also want to honor his people.

Isaiah 45:17

Israel would never again be humiliated and
disgraced, oppressed, harassed, or abused. The
finality of these declarations suggests that this
promise will be fulfilled at the end of time.

Isaiah 45:18

Ancient pagan people viewed the world as a place
of empty chaos. However, God's purposes are good,
and he made the world from the beginning as a
place to be lived in with him in harmony.

Isaiah 45:18-25

Salvation is from the Lord alone. He is the creator,
the revealer, and the executor of his will in human
history. He promised to establish a new era of

salvation and righteousness (see [45:8](#)). Every
human being will submit to God, either willingly or
unwillingly ([45:23-24](#)).

Isaiah 45:22

Let all the world look to me: All humanity needs to
seek the Lord, the true God who created all things,
while he may be found ([55:6](#)). • In God there is
salvation, the only hope for all of humanity ([45:8](#)).

Isaiah 45:23

God's words are always true. God's swearing by his
own name reinforces the certainty that he will
never go back on his word (see also [14:24](#); [54:9](#);
[62:8](#); [Heb 6:13](#)). • Every knee . . . every tongue: At
the end of time all nations will submit to his
authority, whether willingly or unwillingly (see
[Rom 14:11](#); [1 Cor 15:25-27](#); [Phil 2:10-11](#)).

Isaiah 45:24

In this context, the people are all who turn to the
Lord for salvation, even those from foreign nations
([45:22](#)).

Isaiah 45:25

justified: Literally *righteous* (see also [45:8](#), [24](#)).

Isaiah 46:1

Marduk-bel was the most important god in the
Babylonian pantheon. Bel (similar to "Baal")
designated lordship. • Nebo (*Nabu*, *Nebu*), the
patron deity of Babylonian scribes, was thought to
be the son of Marduk-bel. • Instead of being
paraded in glory at a Babylonian festival, these
gods would be hauled away on ox carts and
disposed of, rejected by the Babylonian people.

Isaiah 46:1-2

This taunt was against the self-contradiction of
Babylonian religion.

Isaiah 46:3

Those who remain in Israel refers to the remnant that would be left alive after the destruction of Jerusalem in 586 BC. • The Lord, the Creator of humanity, cares for and carries his people (contrast the Babylonian idols that must be carried instead). • since you were born . . . before you were born: The Lord chose Israel even before they were a nation (see also [49:5](#)).

Isaiah 46:8–13

Many of the exiles would be completely discouraged and not believe the prediction of God's rescue. God challenged this unbelief.

Isaiah 46:10

God knows the future before it even happens; he has comprehensive control over all events, and all his acts match his words ([41:4](#), [26](#)). He is the First and the Last ([44:6](#); [48:12](#)).

Isaiah 46:11

The swift bird of prey from the east refers to Cyrus, the Persian king (see study note on 41:2).

Isaiah 46:12

Formerly, Israel cared little for doing right (literally *righteousness*; see also [58:2](#); [59:9](#)).

Isaiah 46:13

The good news for Israel was that God was coming to set things right (literally *I will bring my righteousness near*; see [40:9](#); [51:5](#)). • show my glory to Israel: Unlike a craftsman who bestows material splendor on an idol ([44:13](#)), the Lord bestows true dignity on his people.

Isaiah 47:1

To sit in the dust was a way of expressing humiliation.

Isaiah 47:1–4

In this taunt against Babylon, the queen of nations is humiliated, forced to work as a servant girl.

Isaiah 47:1–48.22

Two conclusions can be drawn from the preceding evidence that the Lord alone is God: (1) Babylon's great pride is foolishness ([47:1–15](#)); (2) Israel needs to pay attention to the word of the Lord ([48:1–22](#)).

Isaiah 47:3

God's vengeance against those who oppose him and those who oppress his people (see [34:8](#)) will bring justice to the world by purging it of wickedness.

Isaiah 47:5–11

Babylon's confidence and arrogance were well known (see [14:13–17](#); [Dan 4:30](#)). All of this nation's charms, magic, and wisdom were useless against the disaster decreed for it.

Isaiah 47:6

The people of Israel had provoked God's wrath, prompting him to use Babylon to punish them. Now wicked Babylon itself would be punished.

Isaiah 47:8

I am the only one, and there is no other: This was a claim to divinity (cp. [45:5](#); [47:10](#)). Only the Lord can make such a claim. For any created thing, including a nation, to utter this is the height of hubris. • To be a widow or to lose one's children was a disgrace.

Isaiah 47:9

Witchcraft and magic were commonly used in an attempt to ward off evil and to secure a happy future.

Isaiah 47:10

In this context, 'wisdom' and 'knowledge' probably refer sarcastically to the pseudo-knowledge gained through occult practices, which actually led Babylon away from the truth and into disaster ([47:11](#)).

Isaiah 47:12–15

In the face of calamity, Babylon would turn to occult practices for help, but it would not find help.

Isaiah 47:13

Babylon was advanced in astronomy, which the astrologers and stargazers used as a form of divination (see [Dan 2:2](#), [10](#); [5:7](#)).

Isaiah 48:1

Jacob . . . Judah: Although Isaiah's normal focus was on Judah, here he addressed all the tribes of Israel.

Isaiah 48:1–2

Israel was religious but not truly committed to the Lord.

Isaiah 48:1–11

This prophecy is a *disputation*, a speech in which the prophet argues a set of points against his audience.

Isaiah 48:1–22

The Lord here calls on Israel to forsake her historic rebelliousness and listen to what he says. The Hebrew word translated *listening* is often

synonymous with *obeying* or acting upon what is heard.

Isaiah 48:3

The Lord had forewarned Israel of what was going to happen in the Exile.

Isaiah 48:6–7

Even though Israel had repeatedly failed to believe God's past predictions, here he revealed new things that were not yet heard. Specifically, God revealed that Babylon would fall and Israel would be restored.

Isaiah 48:10

The Exile was a furnace of suffering (cp. [Deut 4:20](#)) through which God refined Israel.

Isaiah 48:11

I will not let my reputation be tarnished: Israel's exile raised questions among the nations about the Lord's character and reputation. The nations would not have perceived that Israel's wicked character led to the Exile. Instead they would have viewed it as a failure of Israel's God to protect his people and their land (see [36:19–20](#); [37:12](#); [Ezek 36:19–26](#)).

Isaiah 48:12–22

This final trial speech reviews the arguments of chs [40–48](#) and announces the final conclusion.

Isaiah 48:14

chosen Cyrus (literally *him*) as his ally: See [44:28](#); [45:1–2](#).

Isaiah 48:15

I will send him and will help him succeed: Cyrus would humiliate Babylon and liberate Israel ([45:1–4](#)).

Isaiah 48:16

I have told you plainly: God's promises are clear, though not always specific as to manner and time.

- now the Sovereign Lord and his Spirit have sent me with this message: The identity of the one who is sent is unclear. Isaiah might be referring to himself as a Spirit-inspired prophet who spoke the very words of God to Israel. The connection with the Spirit suggests that it refers to the promised servant, the Messiah.
- The presence of the Spirit assures the servant's success.

Isaiah 48:18

Peace and righteousness will be established when the Kingdom of God comes in its fullness (see [66:12](#)).

- like a gentle river . . . like waves: An abundance of comforting peace and overflowing resources of righteousness (cp. [Amos 5:24](#)) could have been Israel's if its people had only listened to God.

Isaiah 48:19

Your descendants . . . like the sands: This would fulfill God's covenant to Abraham ([Gen 22:17](#)); by contrast, the Israelites were nearly wiped out in the Exile (see [Isa 44:26](#)).

Isaiah 48:20

Leave Babylon: See also [52:11-12](#); [55:12](#).

Isaiah 48:21

not thirsty . . . rock . . . water gushed: These reminders of God's provision in the Exodus provide a fitting summary of what he would do to rescue Israel from captivity in Babylon (see [Num 20:11](#)).

Isaiah 48:22

This refrain, no peace for the wicked (also [57:21](#)), continues the sharp divide between the godly and the wicked (see [66:24](#)). Peace speaks of God's kingdom, from which the wicked are excluded.

Isaiah 49:1

distant lands: The servant's ministry would extend beyond Israel (see [42:4](#), [10](#), [12](#); [51:5](#); [60:9](#); [66:19](#)).

- called me before my birth . . . from within the womb . . . by name: The promised servant's prophetic call was similar to the call of Jeremiah (see [Jer 1:5](#); see also [Gal 1:15](#)). It was not a general call but a very specific, personal one (see also [Isa 43:1](#); [45:3-4](#)).

Isaiah 49:1-13

This has traditionally been regarded as the second of four suffering servant songs (see study note on [42:1-4](#)). The suffering role of the promised servant becomes increasingly clear (see also [50:4-9](#); [52:13-53:12](#)).

Isaiah 49:1-55:13

God intended to rescue the Israelites from exile. However, the question remained: How could sinful Israel again become the servant of the Holy One? God would make a way for Israel's sin to be atoned for and their fellowship with him to be restored. That way would be the promised servant, who would come for Israel and for all peoples. This servant was introduced in [42:1-9](#), but in this passage he becomes the central focus.

Isaiah 49:2

my words of judgment: The servant's mission would be prophetic (see [11:4](#); [Eph 6:17](#); [Heb 4:12](#); [Rev 1:16](#); [2:12](#), [16](#); [19:15](#)).

Isaiah 49:3

The suffering servant would come out of Israel (see [41:8](#)) and would himself be the true Israel. He would serve as both king ([42:1](#)) and prophet ([49:1](#)), anointed with the Spirit of God ([61:1](#)) and commissioned ([48:16](#)) as a faithful witness to God's purposes ([43:12](#); [48:20](#)). In his mission toward both Israel and the other nations ([49:6](#)), he would suffer rejection and disgrace while being faithful, unlike the nation of Israel (see [50:4-9](#)). His

suffering would be on behalf of God's chosen people. Jesus became the ultimate fulfillment of the suffering servant (see study note on 52:13–53:12).

Isaiah 49:4

my work seems so useless . . . to no purpose: Even though people stubbornly refuse his message, the servant would reach out to them. • I will trust God: Despite discouragement and suffering, the servant would continue to discharge his duty faithfully, trusting God for the outcome. God promised to reward the servant's faithfulness (see also [40:10](#); [50:8](#)).

Isaiah 49:6

a light to the Gentiles: As the Messiah, the servant's mission would have a worldwide reach (see [11:10](#), [12](#); [42:6](#)). The apostle Paul explained his apostolic mission to the Gentiles on the basis of this prophecy ([Acts 13:47](#); [26:23](#)).

Isaiah 49:7

The promised servant would be despised and rejected by the nations (see [52:14–53:5](#)) as well as by his own people (see also [50:6–7](#); [53:8–9](#)). • Kings and princes will also bow low to express respect and humility before the servant (see also [52:15](#)), whom God will exalt after he has suffered. God is faithful to his servant.

Isaiah 49:8

God acts at just the right time to accomplish his purposes ([Acts 1:7](#); [2 Cor 6:2](#)). Israel returned to reestablish the land of Israel after the Exile. The land was restored and the city rebuilt beginning with Cyrus's edict ([Isa 44:26–28](#)).

Isaiah 49:10–11

Like a shepherd, the Lord in his mercy will lead the returning exiles beside cool waters; he promised to comfort them and tend to their needs (see also [40:11](#); [Ps 23:1](#)). • level paths . . . highways: The Lord would open up the way of salvation.

Isaiah 49:12

The remnant would come from the north (i.e., from Babylon and Persia), from the west by sea, and from as far south as Egypt.

Isaiah 49:13

This hymn of praise is in response to the salvation that the servant would make possible.

Isaiah 49:14

Although the prophet announced cause for rejoicing ([49:8–13](#)), the exiles continued to ponder the calamity that came upon them when Babylon invaded the land, destroyed Jerusalem, and carried the people of Judah into exile where they felt deserted and forgotten.

Isaiah 49:18

like jewels or bridal ornaments: As a wedding calls for festivity and public display, so God's restoration of Israel would be an open act for all to see (see also [61:10](#)).

Isaiah 49:19–21

The population explosion would reach beyond Israel to include the members of foreign nations who turn to the Lord (see [56:6–8](#); [Rev 7:9](#)). • more room: The expanded population would require space far beyond the traditional boundaries of the land of Israel (see also [Zech 2:4](#)).

Isaiah 49:22

carry your little sons . . . your daughters: The mighty rulers of the nations, some of whom had previously killed children in Israel, would aid in their return to Zion (see also [60:3–9](#)). Elsewhere Isaiah envisioned people of foreign nations streaming to Zion to worship the Lord (see [2:2–4](#)).

Isaiah 49:23

you will know that I am the Lord: The stunning role-reversal—kings and queens serving the lowly exiles upon their return—would reveal God’s power to do the unimaginable (see also [60:16](#)). • The godly would experience temporary disgrace in the Exile but would not ultimately be put to shame, as the idolaters and ungodly were.

Isaiah 49:24

Who can snatch . . . Who can demand: The people considered it nearly impossible that they would be rescued from their oppressors.

Isaiah 49:25

The Lord is like a warrior who will fight to protect his children, as promised to Abraham ([Gen 12:3](#); see also [Isa 54:15](#)).

Isaiah 50:1

God was not at fault for the people’s problems; it was their sin that brought about their exile (see also [59:1–15](#)). • Jerusalem—the mother city of Judah ([Ps 87:5–6](#))—was destroyed, and the people of Judah were taken into exile in 586 BC.

Isaiah 50:1–3

This disputation shows that God was not forced to give Israel up, and therefore he could take the nation back as his people if he desired.

Isaiah 50:2

Why didn’t anyone answer: The people had not responded to God’s repeated call to trust in him and repent of their sins. They were deaf and stubborn (see [6:9–10](#); [29:18](#); [35:5](#); [42:18–19](#)). • The Lord came and called the people through the prophets (see also [65:1–3](#)). • Is it because I have no power to rescue? God was fully able to rescue Israel and Judah from the Assyrians and Babylonians, but he first had to deal justly with his people’s sinfulness (see [59:1](#)). • speak to the sea and make it dry: This was an allusion to the parting of the Red

Sea during the exodus from Egypt ([Exod 14:21–22](#)).

Isaiah 50:3

Phenomena such as darkness and the wearing of clothes of mourning were associated with the day of the Lord ([13:10](#); see study note on 2:5–22). The mention of darkness might allude to the plague of darkness in Egypt ([Exod 10:21](#)).

Isaiah 50:4

The Lord, who never grows weary ([40:28](#)), sends the servant with good news (see [40:28–31](#)) to comfort those who are weary (see study note on 40:1–31).

Isaiah 50:4–11

This is the third of four servant songs (see study note on 42:1–4). The faithful and suffering servant portrays an ideal Israel; the image was realized in Jesus Christ.

Isaiah 50:6

beat me . . . pulled out my beard . . . mockery and spitting: These connections with the experience of Jesus at his crucifixion are too close to be coincidental—Jesus is the true suffering servant (see [Matt 27:27–31](#)).

Isaiah 50:7

Externally, the servant would be disgraced and put to shame, but within himself he would calmly await God’s vindication (see [29:22](#); [54:4](#); [61:7](#)). • set my face like a stone: The servant would be determined to do God’s will (see [Luke 9:51](#)).

Isaiah 50:8

He who gives me justice is near: God vindicates those who suffer for doing his will. Vindication is an act of God by which he exalts those who have been wrongly disgraced and strikes down the wicked,

self-exalted, and arrogant (see also [2 Thes 1:6–9](#)). • bring charges . . . my accusers: Confidence in God's vindication removes fear and bolsters faith (see [Rom 8:31–34](#)).

Isaiah 50:9

Who will declare me guilty? The implied answer to this rhetorical question is, "No one!" This answer foreshadows the New Testament understanding of justification (see [Rom 8:31–35](#)).

Isaiah 50:10

The test of whether or not an individual fears the Lord is how he or she responds to God's righteous servant. The same idea is present in Jesus' claim that no one can come to the Father except through him ([John 14:6](#)). • Those who trust in the Lord have great hope for the future (see [Isa 12:2](#)).

Isaiah 50:10–11

This is a call for response to the servant's ministry.

Isaiah 50:11

warm yourselves by your own fires: Spiritually complacent people are unresponsive toward God. Though they have comfort and security now, they will soon fall down in great torment (see [66:24](#)).

Isaiah 51:1

The rock and the quarry represent Abraham and Sarah ([51:2](#)).

Isaiah 51:1–8

This prophecy calls for trust in the Lord. Each of its three units begins with the phrase, Listen to me ([51:1](#), [4](#), [7](#)).

Isaiah 51:2

Abraham . . . became a great nation: The exiled community had decreased in number. They needed to have faith that God could restore them again to a healthy and thriving population.

Isaiah 51:3

Eden . . . the garden of the Lord: God's salvation will one day reestablish conditions like those in which human beings first lived (see [Gen 2–3](#)).

Isaiah 51:4

my law . . . my justice: The work of the servant will prosper because justice will be the rule in God's kingdom on earth (see [42:1–4](#)). • a light to the nations: The nations will receive the Lord and his revelation (see also [42:6](#); [49:6](#); [60:1–3](#); [66:19–23](#); [Matt 4:15–16](#); [Luke 2:32](#); [John 1:4–9](#); [12:35–50](#); [Acts 13:47](#)).

Isaiah 51:5

God is strong enough to crush his enemies and rescue his people, such as when he rescued Israel in the Exodus (see [51:9](#); [Exod 6:6](#); [15:16](#)).

Isaiah 51:6

die like flies: The wicked will die in great multitudes on the day of God's judgment.

Isaiah 51:7

cherish my law in your hearts: Beyond simply knowing God's word, the Lord desires for his people to internalize, treasure, and obey it (see also [Ps 37:31](#); [Jer 31:33](#)). • Those who obey the Lord often endure scorn and insults (see also [Matt 5:10–12](#)).

Isaiah 51:9–10

Wake up, wake up: God does not sleep; this prayer is for God to act immediately to save his people (see [52:1](#); see especially God's military garb in [59:17](#)). •

in the days of old: The exodus from Egypt was an act of redemption that displayed God's power as he made a path of escape ([51:10](#)) for his people (see also [11:15](#)).

Isaiah 51:13

you have forgotten the Lord: The Lord will never forget Israel (see [44:21](#); [49:15](#)), so they should not forget him. • The Creator of the world also created the nation Israel.

Isaiah 51:14

The Exile brought such brutal conditions as imprisonment, starvation, and death.

Isaiah 51:15

I am the Lord: The Lord uses this formula to identify himself as the covenant God and to assure his people of the truth of his word and the reliability of his actions (see [27:3-4](#)).

Isaiah 51:16

my words in your mouth: The focus shifted back to the servant. • You are my people: Israel was the covenant community.

Isaiah 51:17

Wake up, wake up: Israel used these words in a prayer to the Lord ([51:9](#)). Israel's problems were not the result of God's slowness to act; rather, the people were slow to believe God's promises. • the cup of the Lord's fury: The Lord will appropriately measure out his judgment; those who fall under his judgment must figuratively drink from his wrath (see also [Matt 26:39](#)).

Isaiah 51:17-23

The prophet called the people of Israel to be done with their past and to anticipate God's future for them.

Isaiah 51:20

children have fainted: A sad commentary on Jerusalem's desolation is provided in [Lamentations 1:13, 22; 2:11-12, 19](#).

Isaiah 51:22

God would be the Defender of Israel as he was when Assyria besieged Jerusalem ([38:6](#)).

Isaiah 51:23

The tormentors were the Babylonians who brought about destruction, war, and famine ([51:19](#)).

Isaiah 52:1

This second call to wake up (see [51:17](#)) was in preparation for a glorious future. • holy city: The new city would be holy because its citizens would be holy (see [4:3](#)). • enter your gates no longer: Things that are unclean will not be permitted to enter the holy city (see [Rev 21:27](#)).

Isaiah 52:3

I sold you into exile . . . Now I can redeem you: The Lord was fully in control when he gave his people into the hands of their enemies. Likewise, he remained fully in control and could redeem them if he chose to do so.

Isaiah 52:4

in Egypt . . . oppressed by Assyria: The exodus from exile would be like Israel's past exodus from Egypt.

Isaiah 52:5

The oppressors would shout in exultation because they believed they had conquered not only Israel but also its God. • My name is blasphemed all day long: The condition of God's people affects God's reputation in the eyes of the watching world (see [37:6, 23; 48:11](#)).

Isaiah 52:6

Just as God did to Moses before the Exodus ([Exod 3:15](#)), he will reveal himself in the coming rescue from exile.

Isaiah 52:7

How beautiful on the mountains: See [Nah 1:15](#); [Rom 10:15](#). • The good news goes beyond proclaiming an end to the Exile; it also points to the peace and salvation of the age to come ([Isa 54:13-14](#); see [40:9-10](#); [41:27](#)).

Isaiah 52:7-12

This is a poetic description of God's promise to rescue his people from the alienation their sin created. The imagery is of a besieged city waiting for word that its hero has defeated the enemy armies. Paul applies these words to the proclamation of the Good News of the Lord Jesus ([Rom 10:15](#)).

Isaiah 52:8

The watchmen were those looking for the news of Zion's redemption. • the Lord returning to Jerusalem: The sin of the city's inhabitants had driven God away.

Isaiah 52:10

victory of our God: The rescue of God's people from disgrace foreshadows an even greater victory when God will reign victoriously to the ends of the earth (note the many similarities with [Ps 98:1-3](#)).

Isaiah 52:11

Here the imagery of leaving the unclean enemy city encourages the people to purify themselves by turning away from all known sin. Those who carry home the sacred objects of the Lord need to be pure.

Isaiah 52:11-12

This is an exhortation to leave the captivity of sin (see [48:20](#) on leaving physical captivity in Babylon). See also [2 Cor 6:17](#); [2 Tim 2:19](#).

Isaiah 52:12

not leave in a hurry: At the time of the Exodus the people had to leave quickly (see [Exod 12:11, 31-36](#)). Isaiah drew this contrast to emphasize the newness of God's plan. • protect you from behind: See [Exod 13:21](#); [14:19-20](#).

Isaiah 52:13

prosper ... be highly exalted: The servant would be wise and successful, set apart with the great and noble. Similar terms describe God in [6:1](#) and [57:15](#).

Isaiah 52:13-53:12

This is the fourth of four passages that speak about the promised servant (see study note on 42:1-4). The Hebrew poem is carefully constructed in five three-line stanzas. It begins with the servant's exaltation ([52:13](#)), proceeds to his humiliation ([52:14-53:9](#)), and ends with his exaltation ([53:10-12](#)). The faithful servant's suffering would bring reconciliation between God and humans. The Lord Jesus perfectly fulfilled this prophecy (see ch [40](#); [Matt 8:17](#); [Acts 8:30-35](#); [Rom 10:15-17](#); [15:21](#); [1 Pet 2:24-25](#)).

Isaiah 52:14

were amazed: No one expected that the rescuer would suffer and die.

Isaiah 52:14-15

Despite the servant's greatness, the actual way he would appear on earth would shock people.

Isaiah 52:15

startle many nations: They would be amazed that a rescuer would appear so weak and helpless and

would stand speechless. • What they will see and what they will understand will be in complete contrast to anything they had previously imagined.

Isaiah 53:1

our message: The identity of the speaker has been debated—the main possibilities are (1) a faithful remnant of Israel, and (2) Isaiah himself. Most likely, Isaiah the prophet was speaking for and with Israel. • powerful arm: God’s strength, so dramatically described in the previous chapters (see [50:2](#); [51:5](#), [9](#); [52:10](#)), would actually manifest itself in weakness and apparent helplessness through the servant’s humiliation and exaltation (see [1 Cor 1:27–30](#)).

Isaiah 53:2

a tender green shoot . . . in dry ground: Such a plant is vulnerable to extinction (cp. [37:27](#)). It can hardly stay alive for itself, let alone provide anything for anyone else. • nothing beautiful or majestic: The servant appeared to have no greatness or self-evident royal splendor (see [52:13–15](#)). • nothing to attract us to him: People like their leaders to be physically attractive and personally charismatic. The servant would be neither.

Isaiah 53:3

a man of sorrows, acquainted with deepest grief (or *a man of pains, acquainted with illness*): The servant would fully experience the effects of sin and the Fall. • we did not care: Because people would fail to see how such a weak, insignificant person could do anything beneficial for them, they would be unconcerned about his suffering.

Isaiah 53:4

The callous world would assume that the servant somehow brought his suffering on himself, never realizing that he was suffering for them. • troubles . . . punishment: These descriptions of the servant’s humiliation contrast with the descriptions of his exaltation.

Isaiah 53:5

he was pierced: See also [Zech 12:10](#). • crushed . . . beaten . . . whipped: These were typically punishments for crimes. Sin is a crime against God. • be whole: Hebrew *shalom*, usually translated “peace.” *Shalom* means to experience wholeness in body, in mind, and in relationships with others. The servant would be injured so that humanity can be whole and healthy in all aspects of life (see also [Isa 57:18](#)). We do not need to suffer divine condemnation for our sins because the servant has already done so (see [Gal 1:4](#)).

Isaiah 53:6

strayed away . . . left God’s paths: These are metaphors for sin (see also [Rom 3:10–18](#)).

Isaiah 53:7

See [1 Pet 2:21–25](#) for the fulfillment of this prophecy in Jesus Christ.

Isaiah 53:7–8

The Ethiopian eunuch was reading this passage when Philip met him ([Acts 8:32–33](#)).

Isaiah 53:8

Unjustly condemned: The servant will be given no legal protection or proper defense. • cut short in midstream: To die in midlife was understood to be God’s judgment.

Isaiah 53:9

no wrong . . . never deceived anyone: See [1 Pet 2:21–25](#). • in a rich man’s grave: Literally *he was with the rich in his death* (see [Matt 27:57–61](#)). Although the Bible often considers riches as a blessing from God, it regularly condemns the rich as crooked and oppressive. The point here might be ironic: This good man would be buried with oppressors.

Isaiah 53:10

The servant's grief would accomplish a greater good; the forgiveness and reconciliation of sinful humanity. Note also God's good plan to prosper and exalt the servant. • when his life is made an offering for sin: The suffering of the servant provided a substitute for others, just as the animal sacrifices in the Temple did. • Having many descendants and enjoying a long life are rewards for godly and wise living (see [Prov 3:2](#); [17:6](#); [20:7](#)). Because the servant left his fate in his God's hands, he would receive eternal rewards from the God who vindicates the righteous (see [Phil 2:9-11](#)).

Isaiah 53:10-12

The final stanza of the poem first explains why the servant suffered and was treated unjustly in the place of others; it then explains what the result of that obedience would be.

Isaiah 53:11

his experience (literally *his knowledge*): This clearly does not refer to intellectual knowledge but to all that the servant would experience in his obedience, suffering, and intimate relationship with God. • The servant's righteous obedience enables people to be put right with God (see [Gen 15:6](#); [Rom 5:18-19](#)), for he will bear all their sins.

Isaiah 53:12

the honors: See [Phil 2:9-11](#). • He was counted among the rebels: *Rebels* (Hebrew *poshe'im*) is a stronger word than *sinner*s and is a key word in Isaiah. It refers to those who are in willful defiance of a lawful authority, in this case, God. • interceded for rebels: The servant would pray for sinners in the midst of his suffering (see [Exod 32:30](#); [Luke 23:34](#)).

Isaiah 54:1

In the ancient world, a woman who had never given birth after being married for a time would be ashamed. Isaiah compares Jerusalem to a barren woman who rejoices at the long-awaited blessing of children (see [Gal 4:27](#)).

Isaiah 54:1-3

The prophet encourages Jerusalem, likened to a barren woman, to rejoice because its fate was rapidly changing. She would have so many children that she would outgrow her home (see [Gal 4:27](#)).

Isaiah 54:1-17

Salvation flows from the vindication of the suffering servant. The promises mentioned here go beyond the return from Babylonian exile and apply to the coming of Jesus Christ, the extension of the kingdom to the church, the benefits of the second coming of Jesus Christ as the bridegroom of the church, and the new Jerusalem.

Isaiah 54:1-55:13

This is an invitation to participate in the restoration to God's favor made possible through the ministry of the promised servant.

Isaiah 54:3

Israel's descendants (cp. [53:10](#)) would occupy other nations in fulfillment of God's promise to Abraham ([Gen 22:17](#)) and to Jacob ([Gen 28:14](#)). • As desolation took place ([Isa 6:11](#); [14:21](#)), the people of God would inherit the earth and resettle the ruined cities ([51:6](#); [52:10](#); [65:17](#); see also [Matt 5:5](#); [Rom 4:13](#)).

Isaiah 54:5

Creator . . . husband: The Lord committed himself to the abandoned woman (his people in exile) as her maker ([44:24](#)) and husband (see also [62:4-5](#); [Hos 2:19-20](#)). • The Redeemer transforms misery into freedom and fulfillment (see also [Isa 41:14](#)).

Isaiah 54:7-8

The pain of separation would be brief compared to the depth of the renewal of love and compassion. • The Lord abandoned Israel in exile for a little while because of the people's sins. • everlasting love: The

Lord is eternally committed to his people, making the seventy-year punishment of exile seem short indeed (see [25:1](#); [Hos 2:1](#)).

Isaiah 54:9

The Exile was similar in both drama and trauma to the flood in the time of Noah. In both instances, people sinned grievously against the Lord, but the Lord renewed his commitment to creation (after Noah's flood) and to his people (after the Exile).

Isaiah 54:10

God's faithful love for his people endures despite their unfaithfulness. • God's covenant of blessing was the assurance of his presence, resulting in wholeness, blessing, and protection. It replaces the shame and disgrace of the Exile (see [Ezek 34:25](#); [37:26](#)).

Isaiah 54:11

The Lord himself would rebuild the city (see [Heb 11:10](#)). • Lapis lazuli is a semi-precious stone.

Isaiah 54:11–17

This is a vision of the renewed Jerusalem as a city under God's protection, a place of peace and righteousness (see [59:21–60:22](#)). This section forms the background of John's vision of the new Jerusalem ([Rev 21:10–21](#)).

Isaiah 54:13

I will teach: Jesus alluded to this verse in [John 6:45](#). • They will enjoy great peace, the benefits of God's presence and protection ([Isa 53:5](#); see [48:17–18](#); [54:10](#)).

Isaiah 54:14

Jerusalem would again be a righteous city, secure under a government that is just and fair (see [1:26](#)).

Isaiah 54:15

God gives assurance that no nation can defeat his people. The Lord has promised to protect them, just as he had promised Abraham ([Gen 12:3](#); see [Isa 49:25](#)).

Isaiah 54:17

no weapon . . . will succeed . . . accuse you . . . vindication: God will protect his people in war and in the courtroom. • These benefits are enjoyed by the servants of the Lord: Only the true children of God—people who come out of Israel and the nations—will enjoy the promised blessings of the age to come that God establishes.

Isaiah 55:1

thirsty . . . wine or milk: The invitation to eat and drink is similar to Wisdom's call in [Prov 9:5](#). The image promises the slaking of thirst not only by water but also by more costly items such as wine and milk. John applied a similar theme to Jesus Christ ([John 4:14](#); [6:27](#), [35](#); [7:37](#); [Rev 21:6](#); [22:17](#)). • it's all free: Reconciliation with God is for anyone and has no cost.

Isaiah 55:1–13

This final chapter of the prophecies of comfort (chs [40–55](#)) summarizes the section's prominent themes: blessing, covenant, witness, word, nations, glory, forgiveness, and joy.

Isaiah 55:2

Listen to me . . . eat what is good: Responding positively to God satisfies one's spiritual, social, and physical being (see [1:19](#); [58:13–14](#); [Prov 4:10](#)).

Isaiah 55:3

Come to me. . . . Listen . . . find life: Those who respond obediently to God's word find eternal life (see also [55:11](#)). • an everlasting covenant . . . I promised to David: King David received a special covenant from God, a promise to preserve his kingly line (see [2 Sam 7:15–16](#)). David's dynasty

was eternally confirmed in the kingship of the Messiah, Jesus Christ (see [Isa 9:6–7](#); [11:1–16](#); [Acts 2:22–36](#); [13:34](#)).

Isaiah 55:6

while you can find him: When God graciously extends an invitation to salvation, people must respond ([65:1](#); [Jer 29:13–14](#); [Hos 5:6](#); [10:12](#)). Those who do not seek him at such times risk never having the opportunity again.

Isaiah 55:6–9

The prophet calls for a response while the time is right.

Isaiah 55:7

Let the wicked change . . . turn to the Lord: True conversion demands a change of how we live in favor of God's requirements (see [1:16–17](#); [30:15](#); [59:20](#)). • have mercy on them: God's compassion reaches out to the needy and finds them where they are. • he will forgive generously: Forgiveness of sin is foundational to the good news of redemption (see [Eph 1:7](#); [Col 1:14](#); see also [Pss 32:1](#); [86:5](#); [99:8](#); [103:2–5](#)).

Isaiah 55:8–9

My thoughts are nothing like your thoughts: God's plans are marvelous ([Ps 92:5](#); cp. [Ps 94:11](#)). God's creatures, including humans, can never fully understand the Creator's thoughts, but his revelation through his messengers gives great insight and knowledge of some of the things he will do.

Isaiah 55:10–11

The Creator not only sends rain and snow but also his word (Hebrew *dabar*). In this context, *dabar* means his *will* or *plan* (see [14:24](#); [40:8](#)). God's written word, as an expression of God's plan, accomplishes his purposes. God is effective in whatever he does (see [14:26–27](#); [46:10](#)).

Isaiah 55:12

Joy is found in being redeemed from bondage. • Godly people experience an inner peace not known to the wicked ([48:22](#)). • mountains and hills . . . trees of the field: Creation participates in the freedom of the children of God ([44:23](#); [49:11](#), [13](#); see [Rom 8:19–23](#)).

Isaiah 55:12–13

The prophet encourages his people to forget the past, to leave Babylon, and to accept the perspective of the coming age.

Isaiah 55:13

Redemption is like the transformation from desert to forest (see also [35:1](#); [41:19](#); [60:13](#)). • great honor to the Lord's name: God's glory will be more and more visible to humanity as his redemption takes effect.

Isaiah 56:1

Be just and fair: A key aspect of the message of chs [1–39](#) is the call for justice in relationship with others and God. True godliness comes only through having character that is shaped by the character of God, which only happens by understanding and consistently applying God's word. • I am coming soon: This statement summarizes the message of chs [40–55](#), that the Lord is creating a world of harmony, peace, restoration, vindication, and the removal of enemies ([46:13](#)).

Isaiah 56:1–8

This section summarizes chs [1–55](#) with an invitation to the outcasts to participate in God's redemption.

Isaiah 56:1–66.24

This last major division of the book of Isaiah brings together themes from chs [1–39](#) (sin, justice and righteousness, responsibility, vengeance and vindication) and chs [40–55](#) (salvation, the age to come).

Isaiah 56:2

Blessed: Cp. [30:18](#); [32:20](#); see also [Pss 1:1](#); [119:1](#); [Matt 5:3](#). • The Sabbath, as a sign of the covenant ([Exod 31:13-17](#)), is God's gift to his people; it belongs to this age as well as to the age to come ([Isa 56:4, 6](#); [58:13-14](#); see [Heb 4:1-13](#)).

Isaiah 56:3

Foreigners who commit themselves to the Lord would become full participants in the covenant community. Previously, their participation had been carefully regulated ([Deut 23:3, 7-8](#)). • eunuchs: In the past, an emasculated person was excluded from the community ([Deut 23:1](#)). Both eunuchs and foreigners had no share in Israel's holiness and were considered marginal to God's kingdom. In the age to come, God would bring to the center those who had previously been marginalized (cp. [Matt 20:16](#)).

Isaiah 56:3-7

The blessing ([56:2](#)) would extend to eunuchs and to the Gentiles.

Isaiah 56:4

The Sabbath is a sign of the covenant ([Exod 31:13-17](#)).

Isaiah 56:5

within the walls of my house: Those previously excluded would have a place in God's presence. • a memorial and a name: Everlasting existence in God's presence is better than the blessing of physical descendants.

Isaiah 56:6

The essential ingredient for covenant fellowship is love for God ([Deut 6:5](#); [30:20](#); [Matt 22:34-38](#)). • Keeping the Sabbath is a sign of keeping the covenant itself (see [Exod 31:13-17](#)).

Isaiah 56:7

burnt offerings and sacrifices: God had previously rejected sinful Israel's expressions of piety ([1:11-13](#)) but would welcome offerings from righteous Gentiles or foreigners. Nationality is worth little without true piety. • a house of prayer for all nations: The Lord would open the doors of the Temple to all nations (see [2:2-4](#)). Jesus rebuked the people for desecrating the Temple and for preventing it from functioning as the house of prayer ([Matt 21:13](#); [Mark 11:17](#)).

Isaiah 56:8

The outcasts of Israel were those dispersed among the nations as the result of the Exile (see also [11:12](#)). • The others would be eunuchs and Gentiles ([56:3-7](#); see also [57:19](#); [John 10:16](#)).

Isaiah 56:9

Wild animals are here a metaphor for the hostile nations surrounding Judah.

Isaiah 56:9-57:13

This is a reflection on the prevalence of evil among God's people; they were greedy ([56:9-12](#)), hostile to the righteous ([57:1-2](#)), and idolatrous ([57:3-13](#)).

Isaiah 56:10

The leaders of Israel failed to guide and protect God's people from the sins that led to the Exile. • sleeping and dreaming: See [29:10](#).

Isaiah 56:11

ignorant shepherds: Israel's leaders did not know how to rule in a godly way (see also [Ezek 34:1-6](#)). By contrast, the Lord is the faithful Shepherd of his people ([Isa 40:11](#)). • all following their own path: They had no concern for God or his standards of godly leadership (see also [53:6](#)). • personal gain: Cp. [33:15](#).

Isaiah 57:1

the evil to come: Judgment that would come on the wicked nations. • protecting them: At times, God allows the godly to die in order to protect them from harsher times to come.

Isaiah 57:1-2

This is a lament for the righteous who suffer in a wicked society.

Isaiah 57:2

The wicked would not be able to rest in peace ([57:21](#)).

Isaiah 57:3

witches' children . . . adulterers and prostitutes: Baal religion, which flourished in Israel before the Exile (see [1:21-23](#)), included lewd sexual practices.

Isaiah 57:4

mock . . . sticking out your tongues: The wicked oppressed the righteous by their insults ([57:1-2](#); see also [28:9, 14](#)).

Isaiah 57:5

beneath the oaks and under every green tree: Tree groves were commonly used as places of pagan worship (see [1:29-30](#)). • sacrifice your children: The horrible practice of child sacrifice was occasionally practiced in Israel (see [Ps 106:37-38](#)).

Isaiah 57:6

Liquid offerings and grain offerings were believed to satisfy the basic needs of the gods and thus to earn their favor.

Isaiah 57:8

climbed into bed: The people of Israel had a sickening commitment to the fertility religions, which included sex as part of their rituals.

Isaiah 57:11

The people were living in fear of false gods instead of fearing the Lord (see [8:12-13](#)).

Isaiah 57:12

The Lord did not consider the people's so-called good deeds (literally *righteousness*; see [59:16](#)) to be truly righteous.

Isaiah 57:13

your idols . . . fall over: See study note on 40:18. • inherit the land: The Hebrew word translated land can also signify the whole earth (see [Pss 25:13; 37:9, 11, 22, 29, 34; Matt 5:5](#)). • my holy mountain: God's servants will enjoy God's presence in Zion (see [Isa 2:2; 56:7](#)).

Isaiah 57:14-21

The Lord here promises to be present with the humble, to heal them, and to grant them his peace. The promise extends to all the citizens of Zion, both Jews and Gentiles. The Holy One comes to the humble with an all-inclusive offer of salvation, while dealing justly with the wicked.

Isaiah 57:15

Even though God is the high and lofty one, he promises to dwell with the humble.

Isaiah 57:18

I will heal them anyway: Salvation is by God's grace (see [19:22; 30:26; 53:5](#)).

Isaiah 57:19

words of praise: God's redemption should bring a response of praise from its recipients. • both near and far: Both Gentiles and Jews are included (see [56:3](#); [John 10:16](#); [Eph 2:17](#)).

Isaiah 57:20

restless sea . . . never still: Those who live in constant opposition to God (see [Pss 46:3, 6](#); [93:3-4](#)) do not enjoy inner quiet because they are not at peace with God ([Isa 30:15](#); [32:17](#)). • churns up mud and dirt: Their activity has little productivity (see [Ps 40:2](#)).

Isaiah 57:21

no peace: Cp. [57:2](#); see also [48:22](#).

Isaiah 58:1-4

This is a charge against religious Israelites who were pleased with themselves because of their religious activities.

Isaiah 58:2

they act so pious (literally *they seek me*): They may have been truly committed to a religious form, but they failed to truly meet God in their religious activities.

Isaiah 58:3

Fasting should be a time of self-deprivation in order to focus on God and pleasing him ([Lev 16:29](#); see [Zech 7:5](#)). However, these people were only interested in pleasing themselves and continuing in their sins.

Isaiah 58:5

This is a satirical portrayal of the people's fasting as mere external piety without repentance and righteous acts. Ritualistic and insincere fasting is nothing but pomp. • Wearing burlap and ashes are expressions of sorrow and mourning. • please the

Lord? The people erroneously believed that the Lord would bless them, if only they performed the right rituals.

Isaiah 58:6-7

True fasting creates an awareness of injustice and oppression and prompts the practitioner to reach out to help the needy in their struggles (see [42:7](#); [Matt 25:35-36](#); [Jas 1:27](#)).

Isaiah 58:8

your salvation (literally *your light*): The light of the coming age (see [42:6-7](#); [60:1-3](#)) will dawn on those who turn fully to the Lord. The night of divine judgment and oppression will be over. • your wounds: The nation of Israel was wounded when they were conquered and sent into exile. • protect you from behind: See also [52:12](#).

Isaiah 58:9

the Lord will answer: Cp. [1:15](#); see also [19:22](#). • Stop . . . spreading vicious rumors: God calls for an end to acts and words that destroy relationships (see [Prov 6:12-14](#)).

Isaiah 58:10

your light . . . as bright as noon: God would rescue and vindicate his people (see [Job 11:17](#); [Ps 37:6](#)).

Isaiah 58:12

a rebuilder of walls: Nehemiah would later fulfill this promise (see [Neh 2:17](#)).

Isaiah 58:13

Like the practice of fasting, the Sabbath was intended to be an expression of self-denial and worship. It consists of delighting in the Lord, trusting him to provide for one's needs while abstaining from work, and living in obedience to his will.

Isaiah 58:14

As people honor God through obedience, they themselves will be honored by God. • the inheritance I promised to your ancestor Jacob: The promised inheritance includes living with many descendants in the holy land and enjoying God's presence, blessing, and protection ([Gen 31:3](#); [35:9-12](#)).

Isaiah 59:1

not too weak: The delay in their rescue could not be attributed to an inherent weakness in the Lord.

Isaiah 59:1-8

The people complained that the Lord could not rescue them, but the real problem was that they had not repented ([59:20](#)) and were still living in sin.

Isaiah 59:1-20

The Lord alone can and will usher in his salvation. Like a warrior, he will break into the world to avenge himself on his enemies and to vindicate his holy people.

Isaiah 59:2

your sins . . . cut you off: The Israelites, like all people ([Rom 3:15-17](#)), had sinned, which resulted in alienation from God (he has turned away).

Isaiah 59:4

being fair and honest: Israel did not practice these qualities that are part of God's nature and that he expects from people ([1:21](#); see [25:1](#)).

Isaiah 59:5-6

The images of deadly snakes and spiders' webs represent plans designed to destroy others' lives and relationships.

Isaiah 59:7-8

Paul quotes from these verses in his description of the depravity of all people ([Rom 3:15-17](#)). • Misery and destruction: The people lamented being victims of oppression ([Isa 51:19](#)), yet they were oppressors themselves.

Isaiah 59:9-15

Israel's history of rebellion was well established. The prophet here confesses the nation's sins and laments that they could not apprehend the light of God's salvation.

Isaiah 59:10

people without eyes: See [6:10](#); [Deut 28:29](#).

Isaiah 59:11-14

The people growl and moan with longing for redemption, finally coming to terms with their sinfulness.

Isaiah 59:15-17

The Lord goes out as a warrior intent on achieving victory against the wicked (cp. [Eph 6:14](#)).

Isaiah 59:18

repay his enemies: The Lord will dole out righteous retribution on the whole earth. His justice requires people to be judged for the evil they have done (see also [3:9-11](#); [13:9](#)).

Isaiah 59:19

In the west . . . in the east: I.e., in all parts of the world.

Isaiah 59:21

The members of the new community have the Spirit, and they know and practice God's word (see

also [Ezek 36:24-28](#)). The Lord promises to regenerate the children by his Spirit and bring them into the covenant of obedience and love for the Lord ([Joel 2:28](#); [Acts 2:39](#)).

Isaiah 60:1-3

God will come to be with his people and will transform Zion's destiny from the darkness as black as night caused by sin and judgment.

Isaiah 60:3

The transformation of all nations and mighty kings will be so radical that all kingdoms will take notice and be drawn to God through his people (see also [Rev 21:24](#)).

Isaiah 60:5-7

Zion's losses from warfare will be restored by the wealth of many lands; foreign nations will be eager to make a contribution ([60:11](#); [61:6](#); [66:12](#); see [Rev 21:26](#)).

Isaiah 60:6

Midian and Ephah were Midianite tribes located southeast of Israel. • Sheba was a region in southern Arabia (see [1 Kgs 10:1-2](#)) famed for frankincense ([Jer 6:20](#)). • These were real nations—the restoration would be a historical reality, not just an idealistic vision. Many nations would submit themselves to and worship the Lord.

Isaiah 60:7

Kedar was a tribe in Arabia ([21:16-17](#)). • Nebaioth was an Ishmaelite tribe. • I will make my Temple glorious: The glory of God will be even more evident than it was in Solomon's Temple (see [6:1-5](#); [Hag 2:9](#); [Rev 21:11, 22](#)).

Isaiah 60:9

filled you with splendor: See [Rev 21:26](#).

Isaiah 60:10

their kings will serve you: God's people who were previously humiliated ([2:11](#)) will be exalted.

Isaiah 60:10-16

Those who previously oppressed the people of God will one day participate in restoring the holy city (see [2:2-4](#); [19:18-25](#); [Neh 2:8](#); [Amos 9:12](#)).

Isaiah 60:11

There are two likely reasons for why the gates are not closed at night (see also [Rev 21:25](#)): (1) So much traffic will be coming into the city ([Isa 60:8-10](#)) that the gates will need to be open. (2) The citizens of Zion will no longer need to fear enemies because the Lord is their protector ([60:18](#)); the nations that remain will be serving the Lord and his people ([60:9, 12](#)).

Isaiah 60:12

In the coming age, nations that refuse to obey God will be destroyed.

Isaiah 60:13

The Temple was God's sanctuary, the symbol of his presence on earth. Believers now are the temple of God by the indwelling Spirit ([1 Cor 3:16](#)). We still await the fullness of God's presence ([Rev 21:22](#)).

Isaiah 60:15

beautiful forever, a joy to all generations: This would be radical change from the conditions of the Exile in Babylon. Fulfillments of this prophecy include the Jews' restoration from exile, the coming of Jesus Christ, and the inclusion of the Gentiles in the church. The final fulfillment awaits the glorious second coming of Jesus Christ, which will usher in the new Jerusalem.

Isaiah 60:17

gold . . . silver . . . bronze . . . iron: These metals are for adornment and strength (cp. [54:11](#); [Rev 21:15-21](#)). • Peace and righteousness will bring harmony and blessing among people and with God.

Isaiah 60:17-20

These verses portray Zion's future grandeur (cp. [Rev 21:10-22:4](#)).

Isaiah 60:18

praise will be on the lips of all who enter there (literally *they will call your gates "praise"*): Entrance into the city of salvation will be through the metaphorical gates of praise to the Lord for his great salvation.

Isaiah 60:19-20

Natural sources of light such as the sun and the moon will be as nothing in comparison to the brightness of God's presence (see also [9:2](#); [30:26](#); [Zech 2:5](#); [Rev 21:23-24](#)).

Isaiah 60:21

The citizens of Zion will be righteous, enjoying a right relationship with God and with others ([Rev 21:27](#)). • their land: Or *the entire earth* ([Isa 54:5](#); [62:7](#); [65:17](#); [66:22](#)).

Isaiah 60:22

I, the Lord: The Lord identifies himself as the covenant God of Israel. His identity ensures that he will make it happen (see [27:3-4](#)).

Isaiah 61:1

The presence of God's Spirit ensures the success of the servant's mission (see [11:1-5](#); [42:1](#)). • The servant will restore and heal the marginalized poor and the brokenhearted (see [25:4](#)).

Isaiah 61:1-3

The servant here proclaims the good news that his ministry will restore Zion. The Lord Jesus applied these words to his own mission ([Luke 4:18-19](#)).

Isaiah 61:2

The time of the Lord's favor is the day of God's salvation (see [49:8](#)). • the day of God's anger: God now turns his wrath against the enemies of his people. It will be a day of righteous vengeance (see [34:8](#); [63:3-4](#)).

Isaiah 61:3

Putting ashes on one's head was a sign of mourning (note the reversal of the judgment stated in [3:16-25](#)). Mourning would be replaced by joy. The words translated crown of beauty and ashes form a wordplay in Hebrew. • joyous blessing (literally *oil of gladness*): A face covered with oil was a sign of blessing and well-being (see [Pss 45:8](#); [133:2](#)). • The remnant would start out as small offshoots but would grow into great oaks (see [Isa 60:21](#)).

Isaiah 61:6

priests . . . ministers: The nation would fulfill its original calling ([Exod 19:6](#)).

Isaiah 61:7

The people had suffered God's wrath for their sins ([40:2](#)); now they would receive a double share of God's blessing.

Isaiah 61:8

Those who belong to the community of God's people are to imitate the character of God, who loves justice (see [Mic 6:8](#)) and hates wrongdoing ([Isa 33:15](#)).

Isaiah 61:9

Their descendants: The covenant will be effective from generation to generation. • The Lord has

blessed them in fulfillment of his promise to Abraham ([Gen 12:1-2](#); see [Isa 65:23](#)).

Isaiah 61:10

clothing of salvation . . . robe of righteousness: With great joy God will clothe his people with the benefits of his salvation and righteousness (see [51:5](#); [56:1](#)), like a bridegroom . . . or a bride (see [49:18](#); [62:5](#); [Jer 2:32](#); [7:34](#); [16:9](#); [25:10](#); [33:11](#)).

Isaiah 62:1-12

The servant here commits himself to proclaiming the good news continuously until the glory of Zion is realized.

Isaiah 62:2

The real beauty and glory of God's people would not be seen in earthly treasures or a rebuilt city but would shine forth from their righteousness. Others would be drawn by this divine gift. • A new name reflects the change in Zion's status (see [62:4](#)).

Isaiah 62:4

The Forsaken City: In the Exile, the Lord abandoned his people to the judgment they deserved ([54:7](#)). • The Bride of God: The people will be "married" to the Lord—an appropriate image for the close covenant relationship ([54:5](#); [Hos 1-3](#)).

Isaiah 62:6-7

The watchmen probably represent the prophets. • they will pray day and night: They will continually seek the full restoration and blessing of Zion, unlike the destructive watchmen of [56:10](#).

Isaiah 62:8

The Lord swore an oath just as he did when he had sworn an oath to Noah ([Gen 8:20-9:17](#)), to Abraham ([Gen 22:16](#); see also [Luke 1:73](#); [Heb 6:13](#)), and to David ([Ps 89:3](#)). • I will never again

hand you over: In order to punish and purge a remnant from his people, God had intentionally brought in the Assyrians and Babylonians to decimate them (see [Isa 6:12-13](#)). He would never do this again.

Isaiah 62:9

The people would eat and drink the fruit of their labor ([65:13](#), [22](#); see [Lev 23:39-40](#); [Deut 14:22-26](#)). This is the opposite of what happened when God judged them (see [Deut 28:38-40](#); [Amos 5:11](#); [Mic 6:14-15](#)).

Isaiah 62:10

highway: See also [40:3](#); [57:14](#). • A flag for all the nations to see is a signal that directs foreigners to come to Zion for God's salvation. Earlier, a similar signal was used to call for the nations to attack Judah ([5:26](#)).

Isaiah 62:10-12

This call to prepare for God's coming salvation combines elements from all parts of Isaiah: the proclamation (the signal or banner, see [5:26](#)), the preparation of the road ([40:3](#); [57:14](#)), the coming of God with his reward ([40:5](#), [9-10](#)), and the holy and redeemed citizenry ([35:8-10](#)).

Isaiah 63:1

The Lord's robes are stained red with blood ([63:3](#); cp. [Rev 19:13](#)). • The name Bozrah (Hebrew botsrah) is a wordplay on the verb batsar ("gather grapes").

Isaiah 63:1-6

The judgment of Edom typifies God's judgment of all the nations (see also [34:5-15](#)).

Isaiah 63:2

The term red (Hebrew 'adom) is a wordplay on the name *Edom*.

Isaiah 63:4

the time . . . to avenge my people: See study note on 34:8. • to ransom: See study note on 43:1.

Isaiah 63:6

made them stagger: The wicked nations would be forced to drink from the intoxicating cup of God's wrath ([49:26](#); [51:17](#), [21](#)).

Isaiah 63:7

unfailing love . . . all he has done . . . his great goodness: The whole history of God's care for his people demonstrates his compassion, provision, and protection.

Isaiah 63:7-14

The prophet reflects on Israel's past, how God showed his unfailing love and how his people alternatively rebelled against him, suffered hardship, returned to the Lord, and experienced his blessing.

Isaiah 63:8

They are my very own people: God's possession of and commitment to his people was central to the covenant (see [43:1](#)). • they will not betray me: The Lord expected his own people to honor their relationship with him, unlike the nations, whose story is a history of treachery ([Gen 3-11](#)). But Israel, too, betrayed their God ([Isa 63:10](#)). • their Savior: God rescued and protected his people (see [43:3](#)).

Isaiah 63:9

he also suffered: God identified with his suffering people, and their suffering brought him grief. Later, Jesus suffered on behalf of all humanity. • and he personally rescued them: e.g., see [Exod 12:25-33](#); [14:10-31](#); [23:20-23](#).

Isaiah 63:10

But they rebelled: See also [1:2](#), [4](#); [59:1-15](#); [Pss 78, 106](#). • Persistent disobedience and unbelief grieved his Holy Spirit ([Ps 106:33](#); [Matt 12:32](#); [Mark 3:29](#)). • he became their enemy: Examples include Israel's period of wandering in the wilderness (see the book of Numbers), the period of the judges (see the book of Judges), and the period leading up to the Exile (see the book of Jeremiah).

Isaiah 63:14

God gave his people rest after he brought them into the Promised Land (see [63:9](#); [Josh 1:13](#); [22:4](#); [23:1](#)).

Isaiah 63:15-64.12

The prophet's reflections on the past ([63:7-14](#)) inspire him to pray that God would now rescue his people as he has done before.

Isaiah 63:16

our Father: God's fatherhood and his commitment to his children are much more important and secure than national ancestry (see [9:6](#); [64:8](#); [Deut 32:6](#); [Ps 68:5](#); [Mal 2:10](#); [Matt 6:9-15](#); [Rom 8:15-17](#)).

Isaiah 63:17

The prophet understands that God has the power to keep his people faithful, so he asks, why have you allowed us to turn from your path? • Return and help us: God likewise has the power to call his people back to himself ([Ezek 36:25-27](#)) and to defeat all their enemies.

Isaiah 63:18

The people were supposed to be holy, but their lack of holiness had led to destruction. • The holy place was the Temple, which the Babylonians destroyed in 586 BC ([64:11](#); [2 Kgs 25:1-21](#)).

Isaiah 63:19

Israel was constantly turning from God and then being punished by him.

Isaiah 64:5-6

constant sinners . . . infected and impure with sin: See also [59:1-15](#). The only hope for salvation and transformation is through Jesus Christ (see [Rom 7:25-8:11](#)).

Isaiah 64:7

you have turned away from us: See [1:15](#); [30:20](#); [59:2](#). • turned us over to our sins: Because the people were so bent on sinning, God left them to perish in their sinful ways (see [Rom 1:24](#)).

Isaiah 64:8

clay . . . potter: See also [29:16](#); [45:9](#); [Rom 9:20-21](#).

Isaiah 64:10

holy cities: All the cities of Judah were considered holy to God. However, the Temple in the host city of Jerusalem was the most holy place.

Isaiah 65:1-2

The Lord opened up every opportunity for the people of Israel to seek him ([55:6](#); [58:2](#)), but they did not do so.

Isaiah 65:1-66.24

Here the Lord responds to the prayer in [63:7-64:12](#).

Isaiah 65:3

Sacred gardens were a part of the fertility religion of Baal.

Isaiah 65:4

worshipping the dead: God had banned the practice of necromancy (consulting dead spirits; see [8:19-22](#); [47:9](#); [Deut 18:9-11](#)). • the flesh of pigs . . . other forbidden foods: See [Isa 66:3-4](#); [Lev 11:7](#); [Deut 14:3, 8](#).

Isaiah 65:5

you will defile me! I am holier than you! The people of Israel used the language of ritual purification, as stated in the laws of Moses, yet they practiced rites influenced by paganism. Because of this hypocrisy, they were a stench in God's nostrils (see [1:10-15](#)).

Isaiah 65:6

my decree is written out: God is fully committed to carry out his plan. • The godly had asked whether the Lord would stand silent forever ([64:12](#)). God answered that he would not but would deal with the wicked before restoring the righteous remnant.

Isaiah 65:7

The people of Israel practiced their pagan religion at sacred shrines on mountains and hills (see [1 Kgs 14:23](#); [Hos 4:13](#)).

Isaiah 65:8-16

The Lord planned to spare and reward a remnant of righteous people.

Isaiah 65:10

Sharon was a fertile and beautiful marshy region southwest of Mount Carmel (see [33:9](#)). The valley of Achor in the vicinity of Jericho was associated with the curse on Achan ([Josh 7:24-26](#)); it would be transformed into a place of blessing ([Hos 2:15](#)). These western and eastern regions might represent the renewal of the whole land.

Isaiah 65:11

Fate and Destiny are names of pagan gods (*Gad, Meni*) that were thought to bring fortune and determine one's destiny.

Isaiah 65:12

'destine': This verb (Hebrew *manithi*) is a wordplay on *Meni* (see study note on 65:11). God alone controls human and national destinies.

Isaiah 65:13–15

The contrast between the wicked (addressed as you) and God's servants pertains to all areas of life. God punishes the wicked but blesses those who truly serve him (see [65:17–25](#)).

Isaiah 65:15

The new name given to the faithful represents a new identity and a deeper relationship with the Lord (see also [62:2](#)).

Isaiah 65:16

evil of earlier days: Cp. [Rev 21:4](#).

Isaiah 65:17

The new heavens and new earth will be a place of righteousness (see also [2 Pet 3:13](#); [Rev 21](#)). Paul described those who believe in Christ as already being part of the new creation (see [2 Cor 5:17](#); [Gal 6:15](#)).

Isaiah 65:18–19

Jerusalem here symbolizes God's eternal kingdom ([Rev 21:1–4](#)).

Isaiah 65:24

God will be present with his people (see also [19:22](#); [30:19](#); cp. [1:15](#); [59:2](#)).

Isaiah 65:25

The snakes represent evil ([27:1](#); [Gen 3](#)).

Isaiah 66:1

my throne . . . my footstool: God's kingdom extends over all creation (see [40:22](#); [Matt 5:34–35](#)). • a temple . . . a resting place: Because the entire universe is God's dwelling place, humans cannot limit him to a building (see [1 Kgs 8:27](#)). • Stephen quoted [Isa 66:1–2a](#) in his last sermon ([Acts 7:49–50](#)).

Isaiah 66:2

God is pleased to dwell with those who have humble and contrite hearts ([57:15](#); [Ps 51:17](#)). • who tremble at my word: The humble and contrite submit themselves to God's will, whereas the arrogant resist it.

Isaiah 66:3

delighting in their detestable sins: Literally *delighting in abominations*, which refers to pagan worship practices. • sacrifice a bull . . . blessed an idol: Wicked people brought sacrifices as prescribed by the law, but their sin rendered those sacrifices equivalent to pagan offerings (see [1:11–17](#)).

Isaiah 66:6

terrible noise from the Temple: This parallels the situation described in [Ezek 9](#) when God's executioner began to destroy the wicked people of Jerusalem. • vengeance against his enemies: God would deal out retribution to the disobedient members of his own people. They were his enemies because of their persistent sin and rejection of God.

Isaiah 66:7

birth pains . . . gives birth to a son: See [9:6–7](#); [54:1–3](#).

Isaiah 66:8

by the time . . . her children will be born: A miraculous repopulation of Zion would occur (see [49:19-20](#); [54:1-3](#); cp. [1:8-9](#)).

Isaiah 66:9

The Lord promised that he would surely recreate his holy nation.

Isaiah 66:12

a river: The people, who lost peace and prosperity in the Exile, would receive it back abundantly (see [48:18](#)).

Isaiah 66:13

I will comfort you: Cp. [40:1](#).

Isaiah 66:14

flourish like the grass: Contrast [40:7](#); [64:6](#). • God's enemies included the disobedient from the foreign nations and from within Israel (see [61:2](#); [66:6](#)).

Isaiah 66:15-16

the Lord is coming with fire: God will appear with furious judgment against his enemies (see [Ps 7:13](#)). By contrast, he will reveal his glory to his people (see [Isa 40:5, 10](#)). • God will judge all creation as a part of the process of renewing the earth (see [24:1-4](#); [65:17](#)).

Isaiah 66:17

Apostates who 'consecrate' and 'purify' themselves through idolatrous practices are an abomination to God (cp. [1:28-31](#); [65:4](#)).

Isaiah 66:18-23

When God reveals his glory to all people, the nations join in God's plan of redemption; they can even serve as priests and Levites before him. The godly from all nations last from generation to generation as they serve the living God.

Isaiah 66:19

The sign is the proclamation of God's glory among the nations ([66:20](#)). God will establish a righteous and faithful new people consisting of godly Gentiles together with faithful Israelites ([Rev 15:3-4](#); see also [Acts 2](#)).

Isaiah 66:21

That some of the Gentiles would serve as priests and Levites signifies the removal of God's distinction between Hebrews and Gentiles (see [56:7](#); see also [Gal 6:15](#); [Eph 4:11-13](#)).

Isaiah 66:22

always be my people: God's promise to Abraham was secure ([Gen 17:7](#); see also [Gal 3:8, 14](#)). • a name that will never disappear: The identity of this new people will last forever (see [Isa 59:21](#)).

Isaiah 66:24

Isaiah gives a final warning of the severity of God's judgment. The book begins and ends with the condemnation of those who have rebelled (see [1:2-4](#)). • The judgment of God on wicked humans will generate utter horror because such people will have no hope and no relief from suffering (see also [Matt 5:22](#); [25:41](#); [Mark 9:47-48](#); [Rev 20:11-15](#)).